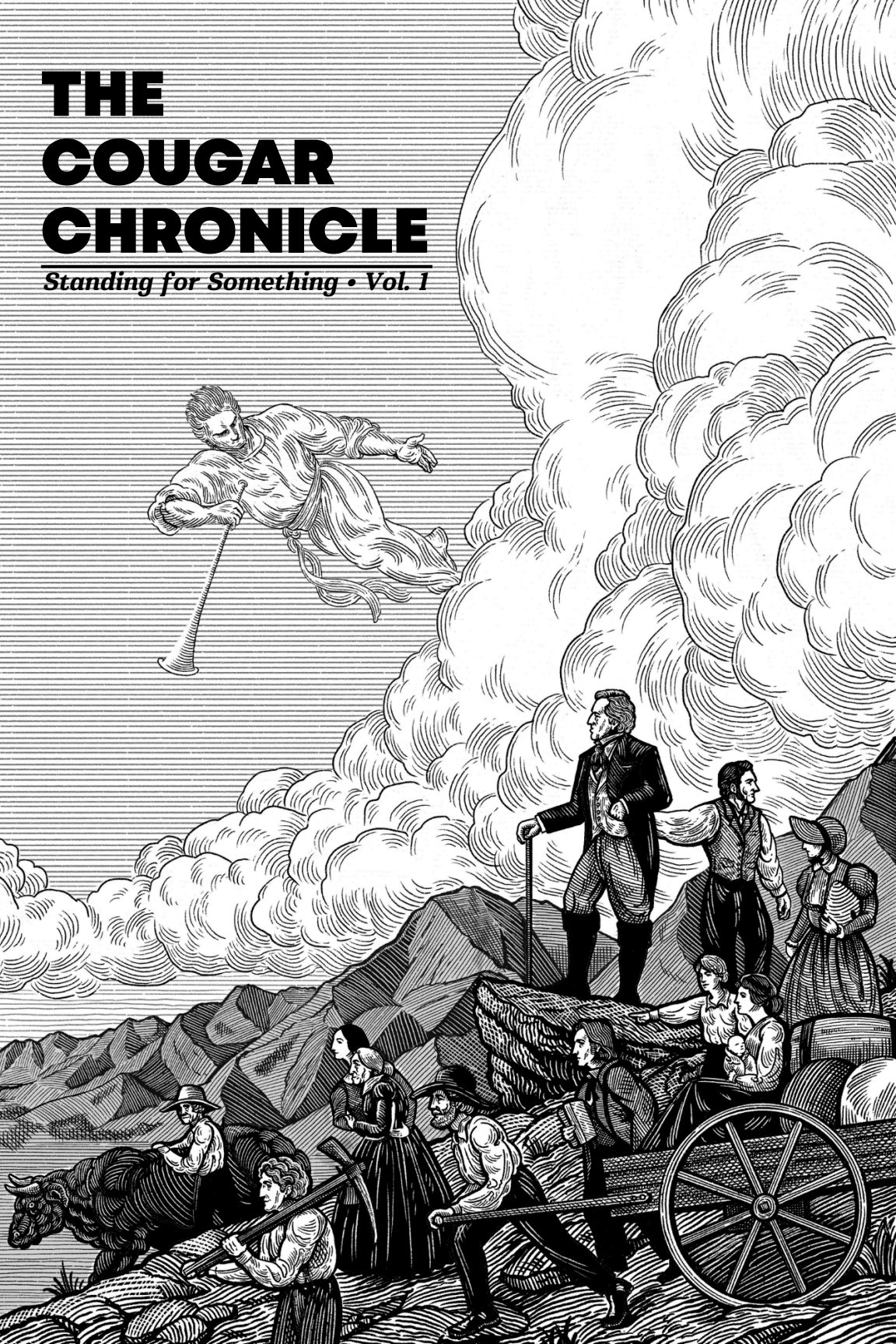


THE COUGAR CHRONICLE

Standing for Something • Vol. 1



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Editor's Note

This inaugural Print Edition is the result of The Cougar Chronicle's gradual, sometimes sudden, evolution over the last few years. It has been on the minds of its editors, past and present, to release a print edition, one that will set the tone and expectation for subsequent releases. At last, it is with excitement that we share this First Edition with our many readers and friends who have supported us from the beginning.

In it you will find a fascinating collection of essays written by students, alumni, guest writers, and a current BYU professor, covering a vast range of themes. Each article topic is of peculiar interest to its author and, as such, is unique in its own way.

The theme, "Standing for Something," is chosen after a book of President Gordon B. Hinckley by the same name. The mission of the Chronicle is to stand for and defend the sacred mission of Brigham Young University—to balance the dual claims of reason and revelation. As we have seen, the trend of American university pedagogy and culture is to abandon altogether the claims of revelation and the responsibility of reason in favor of a secular, godless form of "education."

Co-opted by activists advancing the march of social-justice and enabled by an academic class insistent on the separation between "facts" and "values," our institutions of higher education are underwhelming, to say the least. BYU, however, as manifest in Elder Holland's prophetic "The Second Half of the Second Century of Brigham Young University," is to stand above and distinct from the secular academic world; BYU is to stand for something.

What is BYU to stand for? A search to the beginning of an answer to this question is the purpose of this inaugural Print Edition.

As the Editor, I thank my fellow students, alumni, and guest writers, all of whom are my friends, for their sincere and ongoing effort in the production of this First Edition. Lynn, my father, gave countless hours to format and ensure this print be ready for publication; we give our heartfelt thanks to him. Likewise, our authors have poured hours of study and writing into their articles and I, along with them, am

proud to publish their work for you to read.

As I complete my final semester and now depart from the Chronicle, I express my gratitude for the many supporters, readers, friends, and family members who have and continue to support the work we do. It is from you, the reader, that we find fulfillment and pride in this cause.

We thank the *Intercollegiate Studies Institute* and our generous donors whose ongoing support makes our project possible, and Godwin, an artist of the highest order, for the beautiful and inspiring illustrations. Finally, we thank the many professors at BYU, gems of both spiritual and secular education, who have taught us to stand for something.

We dedicate this inaugural edition to Dr. Ralph Hancock, a man who has helped generations of students stand for Truth. In doing so, we let him lead with the first essay.

JACOB CHRISTENSEN, EDITOR

BYU Mission Alignment and Culture Wars

PROFESSOR RALPH HANCOCK

Ralph Hancock is a Professor of Political Science at BYU, where he teaches the tradition of political philosophy and contemporary political theory. He is the author of “Calvin and the Foundations of Modern Politics” and is the translator of various works, including Pierre Manent’s “Natural Law and Human Rights.” Dr. Hancock’s latest book, “Love and Virtue in a Secular Age,” is scheduled to be published in 2026 by the University of Notre Dame Press

EDITOR’S NOTE: The following article is an unreleased response to BYU-I Professor Jeffrey Thayne’s essay “On Confidence in BYU’s Mission and Potential,” initially published in *Public Square Magazine* in January 2024. In his essay, Thayne urges readers to approach concerns about Brigham Young University with “humility,” cautioning against public criticism of perceived secular or doctrinally misaligned occurrences on campus that may conflict with the university’s gospel-centered mission.

In a recent article, Jeff Thayne argued persuasively against undue alarm concerning BYU’s alignment with its distinctively religious as well as educational mission and counseled against excessive criticism of faculty and administrators at the Provo campus. It is certainly true that any justifiable disappointment and criticism needs to be tempered by appreciation for what the university has contributed to the LDS community and by patience and realistic expectations concerning changes that may be advisable. There is indeed no point in going about with our hair on fire, clamoring to burn the institution down every time another outrage of

the week is reported. It is well to be reminded that BYU is a very big institution, one that is always bound to disappoint various of its constituencies in various ways and one that we can't expect to change overnight. Most encouraging for those of us who indeed would wish for a stronger commitment at BYU to its distinctive educational mission is the obviously heightened emphasis on this mission by Church leaders such as Elders Holland and Gilbert. In addition to these examples of strong and clear counsel, one could cite other speeches by General Authorities (Oaks, Christofferson, Cook) and BYU administrators (President Shane Reese and Academic Vice President Justin Collings) as evidence that concerns about BYU's church mission alignment have been heard and that more accountability to Gospel principles is now being demanded from the highest levels of the University and the Church.

All this counsel is well-founded and well-taken. At the same time, we must beware of the danger opposite to that of alarm, that is, complacency. It is all too easy to underestimate the challenge facing BYU in doing justice to the two sides of its institutional mission, academic and religious. The most inspiring statements of BYU's mission call for an integration of these two missions is a focus on a "gospel methodology" that would apply across units and disciplines of the university. But this, to put it mildly, is much easier said than done, given the intellectual and professional facts on the ground or forces in play. Regarding the empirical studies cited by Thayne showing that BYU is less dominated by leftism than other universities, I will only say that I am neither surprised nor particularly comforted by such data. It is true that we are not as far gone as many institutions, but that is a rather low standard of evaluation: not many institutions have our mission and our source of support. Obviously, BYU is much less "liberal" or leftist or progressive or woke than the vast majority of academic institutions, but what counts as "liberal" or "conservative" is always relative to a prevailing spectrum of opinion, which can hardly be our final standard for determining fundamental principles that should animate teaching and research at BYU. It seems plausible that mainstream opinion at BYU generally lags a decade or two behind national

academic opinion in its leftward drift, but I don't see this as a great cause for celebration.

Much depends on how we diagnose BYU's illness and, thus, on what we think it would mean for it to be healthy. It is tempting and somewhat comforting to assume that the main problem at BYU is indicated by the outrage of the week: a Family Life teacher clearly undermining the Family Proclamation, an invited professor touting "iniquity" in the Book of Mormon as "inequity," a sociology professor assigning students to go seek out examples of the sin of "whiteness," or, more recently, a "therapist" enthusiastic about masturbation scheduled as a sponsored speaker by an official BYU student organization. Such outrages are far from trivial, of course, but suppressing them is a relatively realistic goal. Patently ideological agendas can be suppressed; a few really bad actors can be incentivized to keep their Woke radicalism to themselves or, in a few cases, to pursue their careers elsewhere. Probably under BYU's new regime, we can expect spectacular offenses against faithful LDS sensibilities to be significantly reduced. But what if such flagrant ideological performances are the tip of an iceberg of dominant opinion among some critical mass of BYU faculty?

It is tempting to avoid questions of "dominant opinion" in addressing the question of BYU's mission alignment. BYU is an institution of higher education that is distinctive in its commitment to educating the student as a whole person as understood in the light of the Restored Gospel. At least since Pres. Kimball's much-quoted "Second Century" address at BYU, we have been exhorted repeatedly to strive to be "bilingual," speaking both the language of scholarship and that of faith.

But, of course, this attractive formula of "bilingualism" assumes that these two languages are fundamentally compatible. Certainly, they should be: if scholarship and the gospel are both about truth, then these two approaches to the truth must ultimately be friends. But are our scholarly disciplines based firmly on the pursuit of truth? Anyone who pays attention to higher education in America well understood, even before the example of Claudine Gay at Harvard advertised the fact, that American universities have

massively turned their attention and their resources to supporting what are considered “progressive” political causes, nicely distilled in the acronym DEI: “diversity,” “equity,” and “inclusion” (Yes, I insist on the “square quotes” in all three cases). This activism is now what passes for or has simply replaced the pursuit of truth. But even if we set aside the pervasive influence of this ideologically activist model of higher education, we see that the disciplines are hopelessly fragmented and specialized in a way that all but effaces any recognizable pursuit of a “truth” relevant to us as human beings – as saints and as citizens, let’s say – rather than, for example, as technicians of human behavior or social movements or arcanelly subversive approaches to the humanities.

Already in 1988, in what is perhaps the boldest address by a BYU President to university employees and the most well-informed concerning the nature of the institutional obstacles the university faces in integrating faithful and intellectual approaches to the truth, Jeffrey R. Holland referred to “the perpetuation of dividedness, departmentalization, specialties, subspecialties, and subspecies of subspecialties” that has driven all “the great human questions ... [to] the bottom of an academic dumpster...” No one is getting paid to attend to what should be the university’s central (though, of course, not only) mission: “to love the truth and gather it, [and] to organize and integrate it as well.” No one is hired or incentivized to ask what might be meant by an “even-balanced soul.” Those with an interest in “general education” are left to cobble together some “interdisciplinary” conversation, which cannot be a very promising project as long as all the concerned disciplines more or less explicitly repudiate the very notion of a well-ordered soul as essential to the pursuit of an integral and humanly meaningful “truth.” Our efforts towards “bilingualism” are doomed by the fact that, as academics, we speak a thousand different languages that share nothing but indifference or, in more interesting cases, open hostility to the very idea, the classical and Christian idea, of a “soul.”

In sum, What if our two languages, those of “faith” and “scholarship,” are (owing to fundamental developments in moral “culture” or “worldview”) increasingly incompatible? And as we aspire

to ever greater professional influence and prestige, who do we think is training and determining the dominant tongue of the faculty we are now hiring, or, for that matter, the faculty we have been hiring for decades, at least? Who is setting the standards for prestigious research and publication by which we hire, promote, and reward faculty?

What if the myriad languages of the contemporary academy formally exclude any translation into a gospel vocabulary concerned with ultimate human purposes and the permanent features of the human condition? The days of a more or less comfortable “bilingualism” within the paradigms of academically dominant disciplines may well be gone. Any shared language that might result from an ongoing truce or compromise between the gospel and this academy will, in the long run, be a fool’s bargain for the religious junior partner, who will be left with a very impoverished vocabulary from a human and spiritual point of view, from which to draw.

To put the matter plainly: the contemporary academic enterprise (and this goes back decades at least) is, depending upon the discipline or subdiscipline, either clearly leftist (“progressive” when not “woke”) in its fundamental orientation or, it strives for scientific neutrality by refusing to address fundamental moral and philosophical questions, thus rendering itself vulnerable to the default setting of academic and other elites – that is, a leftist (broadly liberationist-egalitarian) setting. (Many of my more academically savvy readers, who may unhappily have read this far, will now be asking: what could possibly be wrong, morally and religiously, with the adoption of personal freedom and social equality as ultimate goals? You make my point.)

Inevitably, my attempt to assess the challenges facing BYU has led me onto political and ideological territory. I find myself (and not for the first time) open to the charge that I am fanning the flames of a “culture war.” It is common now to establish one’s good sense and moderation by deriding the term and the sensibility of the “culture warrior.” Who would want to be seen as tilting at the windmills of an imaginary conflict while serious people are calmly diagnosing circumscribed problems and recommending practical

solutions attractive to all people of goodwill? But what exactly is the argument against the language of “culture war”? That there is no such thing among us as a fundamental social and political division that turns on fundamental moral and religious questions? Or that there may once have been, when now old folks were young, such a division, a war, but that it’s over, “been there, done that” – over, no doubt, I suppose, because we’ve lost? That some who use the term are sometimes inarticulate in identifying what’s at stake and unrealistic in their cultural and political expectations? This last may certainly be conceded, but this concession does nothing to dispose of the more fundamental question: is our society divided? Over something(s) fundamental? Does what is at stake concern, or does it not concern, our religion? Our fundamental moral orientation? Our religious university? It is comforting to assume that the fundamental conflicts, the moral-political plate tectonics roiling our society, have little or nothing to do with how we understand what it means to follow Christ on the one hand or how we understand “scholarship” on the other. But in fact, the fundamental division at work in the world goes to the heart of both the life of faith and the rational pursuit of truth.

But dismissive language regarding a “culture war” does little to clarify what is at stake concerning BYU, its mission, or the dominant ideological orientation of its faculty. James Davison Hunter, who contributed most to the currency of the term “culture war,” saw rightly that the fundamental question in it concerns the standing of moral truth. Is there an abiding moral truth, or is moral truth a matter of social construction and “progressive” unfolding? Of course, an intelligent person can give due consideration to each of these poles of opinion and see some reason on both sides, but the question of fundamental orientation remains an important one, not only for individuals but for society, law, and politics. So anyone is free to propose another name for the basic question and the basic conflict, but these remain real, and dismissal of “culture wars” does nothing to clarify the matter. In fact, the derision of “culture warriors” has become a wearisome weapon of, yes, the culture warriors on the now winning, “progressive” side. We play into the hands

of the dominant, secular-progressive culture when we deride our friends for taking up the fight against the ruling worldview.

Prof. Thayne, in fact, helpfully limns what is at stake in the culture wars by identifying the problem of the growing dominance of “expressive individualism.” And in so doing, he takes a side – the right side, I dare say. *But it is a side.* And it’s a side in a polarity that, while it does not exactly map partisan political divisions in the United States, is far from unrelated to them. Prof. Thayne’s position is, happily, a conservative position. Would it please him if we spoke of “worldview wars” rather than “culture wars”? Whatever term we use, the conflict is there, and it is all-too-relevant at once to (1) the very way we understand our Christianity, (2) our most fundamental political divisions, and (3) the question of dominant opinion at BYU.

To be sure, BYU has an interest in keeping a low political profile, and the Church even more so. I am not arguing that we should deliberately position ourselves as part of a political movement or brandish the term “conservative” (a term whose meaning now is, to say the least, unstable). But striving at every turn to dissociate ourselves from anything that might smell “conservative,” much less “right-wing,” to the reigning arbiters of correct (or “moderate” or “neutral”) opinion is a fool’s errand.

I would not claim to give any snapshot of the current distribution of opinion on such a fundamental question among BYU faculty. No doubt many, perhaps most, would rather not be pressed at all on such a question. But pressed, I am willing to predict we will be. The question is not so much the current distribution of opinion or ideological orientation among BYU faculty. The question concerns rather the social plate tectonics that underly the whole academic enterprise. On the basis of a sensitivity to the most fundamental forces at work in society, I would expect a massive drift of BYU personnel towards ever more solidarity with the larger, “mainstream” secular intellectual and academic world to continue even accelerate – unless some equally massive change in incentive structure (which goes well beyond the most inspiring exhortation) is introduced into the institution.

The broadly left-progressive drift of BYU faculty can hardly be surprising if we step back and take a large view of BYU's place in the overall picture of American and Western education in light of the broadest social, political, and economic forces. BYU sees itself as grooming elite professionals to fill their roles in a global society of technology, commerce, and expertise. This is not in itself objectionable; this is what universities do. But the elite global class to whom our students – and, first of all, our faculty – aspire is not a neutral force, morally and politically. We are seeing Western societies divide increasingly between “anywheres” (global technical elites) and “somewheres” (people attached both economically and affectively to their countries and communities). Naturally, BYU aspires to be part of the global elite and to train students to be among the best and the brightest. But this elite tends to be as detached from traditional morality and religion as it is from country and family. To educate our students to be part of this elite is to accept the moral and intellectual formatting that necessarily accompanies membership in this international class. This formatting is essentially liberal-progressive and, of late, increasingly “woke,” touting engineered “diversity,” radical feminism & unlimited abortion, etc.

Of course, both of us are well acquainted from long experience with the social milieus of higher education and, more generally, with the leadership class in Western societies. Along with many others, we have navigated a path attempting to interact positively with mainstream elites while remaining true to our deepest convictions. We have practiced the “bilingualism” that Pres. Kimball recommended in 1975. There was nothing nefarious in this navigation. But as the global elite solidifies its ruling status and abandons moderating limitations on its ambitions, the navigation becomes more difficult, and eventually impossible. This seems to me to describe BYU's present or emerging situation. The two languages are diverging at an accelerating pace, and one is less and less translatable into the other. This presents a wrenching challenge to BYU, one that I think we can no longer defer without abandoning our fundamental loyalties.

Prof. Thayne has mentioned the need to avoid political contro-

versy. Of course, we need to stay above the fray of electoral politics, and we must always strive to increase the proportion of light to heat in our discussions. But neither the moral-political dimension of elite socialization nor that of our distinctive religious-educational mission will go away, however much we might want to avoid the conflict between them. The moral opinions and global ruling ambitions of the ascendant social class are connected with a vision of humanity that is simply incompatible with any serious understanding of the gospel. Global development is of a piece with rights of sexual liberation, abortion rights, and transgenderism, for example. It is becoming impossible to aspire to membership in this class without embracing or at least deferring to these opinions. To avoid the questions that are derisively dismissed as pertaining to a futile “culture war” is simply to ratify the victory of the established elites in this culture war. Naturally, those who think they have practically won are eager to convince us of the vanity of any further contestation.

For those candidates for elite recruitment who see themselves as religious, the worldview of a morally liberated and global (post-political) humanity offers itself in the form of a counter-religion. Christianity – very much including the Restoration, alas – is invited to reinterpret itself in terms of the elite vision of secular global progress. This vision is already the default setting of the educated class, not to mention PhDs. At BYU, there is a very prevalent tendency for all prophetic counsel to be filtered through this lens. While we can still benefit from skill in navigating different worlds, a stop-gap “bilingualism” will no longer suffice to keep peace with the academic mainstream.

I’ve been reading a remarkable book by Joseph Bottum: *An Anxious Age*. He describes how the Protestant elite became the Progressive elite and how a religious quest for purity and salvation was transformed into a secular agenda. I have to say that Bottum’s description is palpably recognizable in the now ascendant LDS professional sensibility; it is a massive presence, even, alas, the very air we breathe. Here is an excerpt:

“This is the final remnant of the Christianity of their ancestors,

the last enduring bit of their inheritance: a social gospel, without the gospel. For all of them, the sole proof of redemption is the holding of a proper sense of social ills. The only available confidence about their salvation, as something superadded to experience, is the self-esteem that comes with *feeling* that they oppose the social evils of bigotry and power and the groupthink of the mob.

Up in its thin air, such a social ethics touches only lightly on personal morality, and it does not reach down at all to the old, earthy stuff of life and death that religion once took as its deep concern. And that is precisely the problem.”

A suspicion of the alleged narrowness of traditional religion and a feeling of superiority to our religious tradition has become the very stuff of a new academic religion. The BYU community is all too eager to enjoy the symbolic and material rewards of membership in this new religion of the global elites. The self-esteem of those engaged in the academic enterprise is increasingly based on a feeling of superiority to those who remain attached to old teachings and old commandments. All counsel from Church and university leadership tends to be filtered from the standpoint of this supposed ethical and intellectual superiority.

I do not see how these strong tendencies to a new humanistic religion, deeply abetted as they are by broad economic and social forces in the contemporary world, can be countered without clearly naming them and warning against them. And I do not see how it will be possible to name and counter these forces without our being perceived to be in alliance with politically charged counter-tendencies in our society and in our polity. I see no way to counter this tendency that will not be labeled “political” and “conservative” by those who have a stake in membership in the secular elite. As Elder Christofferson said, we must never be contentious in spirit, but we cannot avoid contending for truth and against falsehood.

Is “gospel methodology” at BYU to be a serious religious-intellectual project? If so, we will by no means avoid intellectual and public conflict with the powers that be. This is why Pres. Kimball told us that “in its second century, BYU must become the last remaining bastion of resistance to the invading ideologies.” So,

do we recognize invading ideologies or not? Do we oppose them? Whether we like it or not, we are at war with powers and principalities. We must not relish a militant, unreasoned, and unreasonable posture. But neither must we concede the whole territory of fundamental assumptions to the secular mainstream.

Should we relax, therefore, and trust calmly in BYU's institutional soundness, as Prof. Thayne urges? Certain it is that we cannot expect such a big institution to turn on a dime. But shall we then just take a deep breath and squelch our indignation when we learn of yet another example of a secular-progressive-expressive- BYU professor proffering their wares with administrative support at our church institution? I will not try to prescribe just the right tone or vocabulary that ought to be used in addressing specific cases of ideological agendas incompatible with any serious commitment to the Church and the Gospel at BYU. Jeff has proposed Elder Maxwell as an example of a "bridge-building" and "non-adversarial" approach. I conclude, then, with this example of bridge-building from a BYU Devotional by the non-adversarial Elder Maxwell, October 10, 1978:

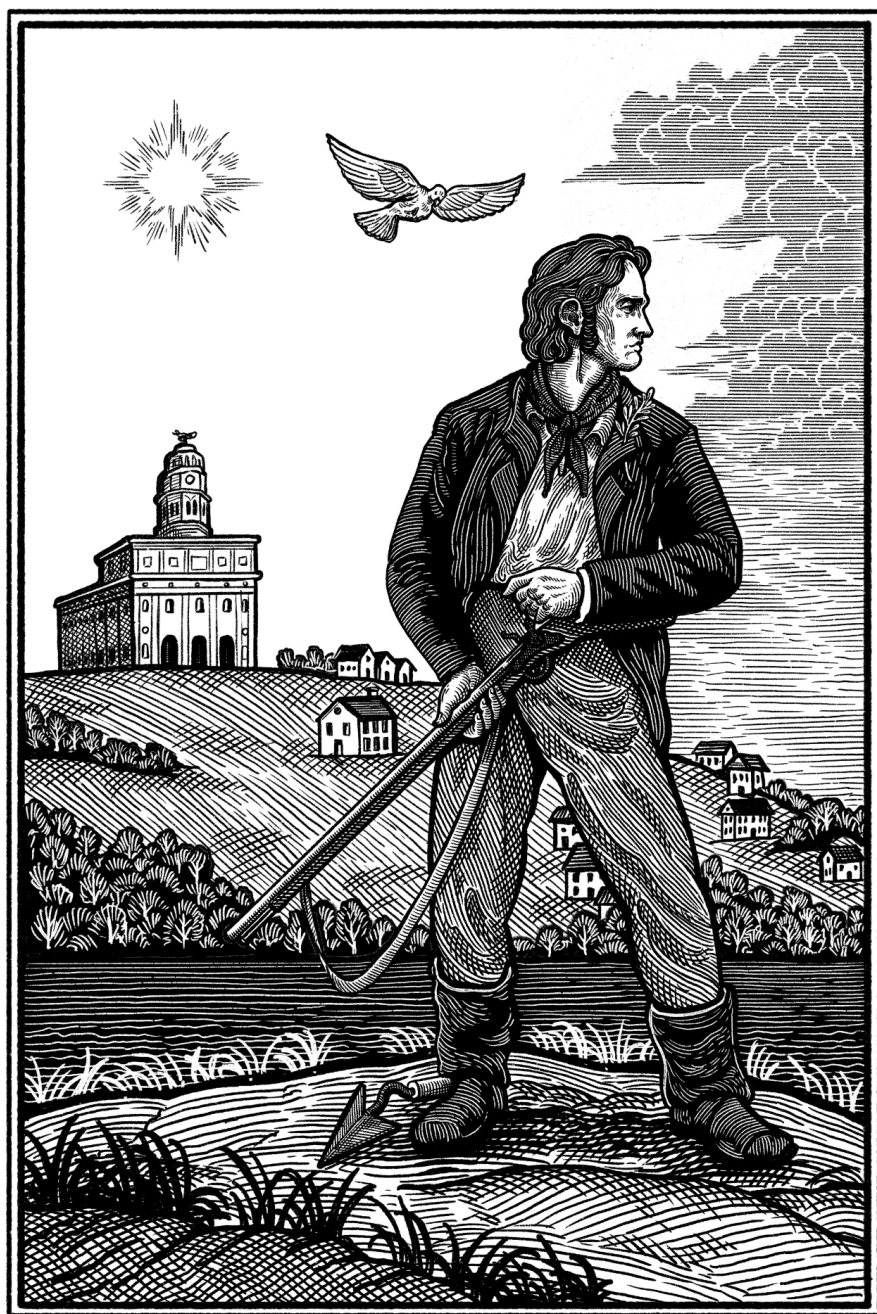
Your discipleship may see the time come when religious convictions are heavily discounted. M. J. Sobran also observed, "A religious conviction is now a second-class conviction, expected to step deferentially to the back of the secular bus, and not to get uppity about it." *This new irreligious imperialism seeks to disallow certain of people's opinions simply because those opinions grow out of religious convictions. Resistance to abortion will soon be seen as primitive. Concern over the institution of the family will be viewed as untrendy and unenlightened.*

In its mildest form, irreligion will merely be condescending toward those who hold to traditional Judeo-Christian values. *In its more harsh forms, as is always the case with those whose dogmatism is blinding, the secular church will do what it can to reduce the influence of those who still worry*

over standards such as those in the Ten Commandments.

It is always such an easy step from dogmatism to unfair play—especially so when the dogmatists believe themselves to be dealing with primitive people who do not know what is best for them. It is the secular bureaucrat's burden, you see.

(my emphasis – rch)



Embracing Our Particularity – Against the ‘Civility Trap’

JACOB CHRISTENSEN

Jacob recently graduated from Brigham Young University with a degree in Political Science. This fall, he will attend Baylor University’s PhD program in Political Philosophy to pursue his interests in classical political philosophy. He enjoys spending time outside with his wife and young daughter.

In March 2019, the current editor of *First Things* magazine, R. R. Reno, wrote a lucid piece titled “The Civility Trap.” The now-prevailing calls for “civility,” Reno explains, are an “admirable quality” for any well-functioning and cordial political discourse. The absence of the presence and promotion of those “habits and manners” that look to “build bridges” or mitigate “unnecessary clashes” quickly leads to “the naked struggle for wealth, power, and position.” However, Reno adds, “[C]alls for civility are rarely innocent.” The accomplished German sociologist Norbert Elias, Reno explains, “observed that ‘a strict code of manners’ has great importance for elites. It is ‘an instrument of prestige, but it is also... an instrument of power.’” Similarly, advocates of “civility” are prone to ideological capture, leading them to “marginalize” those whose unorthodox political opinions threaten the liberal order.

Absent any substantial moral content or grounding, the principle of civility, like its friend “tolerance,” is prone to ideological manipulation. This is accomplished first by identifying a set of abstract liberal ideals to whose adherence determines whether one is civil or uncivil; “equality,” “progress,” and “compromise” are these

typical liberal ideals, frequently co-opted by progressives to advance the “equal right to reproductive freedom” or to “compromise on the marriage question.” The second ideological move solidifies the subversion of civility by blanket-labeling any perceived opposition to these ideals as “uncivil” or “contentious,” creating an innocent/guilty dichotomy to use for political ends.

Publicly and proudly standing for the traditional family, for example, implies the inferiority of the same-sex union and the superiority of marriage between a man and a woman; this political view is inherently exclusionary (as the traditional family excludes other improper forms of sexual relationships) and thus runs the risk of being against “civility” (progressive equality). The “civil” alternative, then, is to relinquish the political sphere in favor of a liberated sexuality and to retreat to the private sphere and the churches to practice, silently and conveniently, your private, “uncivil” views. This is all done in hopes of “disagreeing better” and promoting and maintaining a pluralistic society—one that, unfortunately, can’t include your beliefs in the public morality.

I thus could not hold back a smile when I read the title of a letter by Jacob Hancey in *The Salt Lake Tribune*: “Civility gets us nowhere. It’s time for the kumbaya era of the left to end.” The author shared hearing calls for “civility” in a recent General Conference; Jacob, however, “disrespectfully disagree[d],” as “civility is why a convicted felon and rapist is at the height of power, again.” Jacob urged readers to manifest “more hatred” for political enemies and to “hate their ideologies and call them out for being anti-democratic.” “Civility,” Jacob concluded, “gets us nowhere.”

Of course, Jacob leans too far toward embracing hatred out of contempt for a truncated civility. Surely, blanket labeling our political foes as “anti-democratic,” which, for Jacob, merely means someone who doesn’t wholeheartedly embrace the liberal-progressive political agenda, is not a strong long-term political strategy; after all, the “anti-democratic” President Trump won with leaps and bounds— democratically! However, I partially sympathize with Jacob’s knee-jerk reaction to calls for civility. Politics, ultimately, is not just about civility; in politics, someone wins, and the rest

go home. As BYU Professor Ralph Hancock put it, “[W]ho wins matters— it matters for the kind of lives we live and, if we happen to choose to raise children, for the kind of life that they may hope to live.” For Jacob, who won mattered.

Jacob understands, perhaps unknowingly, what many advocates of civility do not: all political action is in favor of some conception of Good or Bad. There are no “morally neutral” political actions, but each is guided, as Leo Strauss put it, “by some thought of better or worse.” Political action is thus inherently *partisan*; it seeks to affirm one conception of the *bona vita*, the good life, over another. Civility’s imperative to “disagree better” with our political opponents, however, presumes that we haven’t lost something that we once agreed on, such as a common good, but, rather, that we have forgotten *how* to disagree; this takes any question of a common Truth out of the question. The losers of the game of civility, like Jacob, learn the hard way that every “compromise” or settlement in the “middle-ground” on political issues is ultimately a moral claim of Better or Worse; and when you’re the one compromising, you’re the one ceding ground to another’s conception of Better or Worse.

With this conception of political action in mind, I will provide a personal example of the “civility trap” and then discuss the moral-political implications of the ethic of civility.

This last Fall semester, my young family found ourselves living in Falls Church, Virginia, as I worked as an intern at the *National Right to Life*, the nation’s oldest pro-life organization. BYU’s *Washington Seminar* sends students each semester to the Washington, D.C. area to pursue a variety of internships, ranging from public policy to social work. While far from Utah, I felt at home amongst a small group of hard-working, Christian (mostly Catholic) coworkers who shared my zeal for political action as a believer. There, we shared prayers, meals, and the everyday work necessary to protect the lives of the unborn. Indeed, these faithful men and women will forever be an example of what it means to “stand for something.”

Part of this internship experience involved attending classes at BYU’s Barlow Center, located just a few blocks away from the Watergate Hotel. These class sessions included visits from guest lectur-

ers, including a former CIA agent, a former writer for Deseret News, Senator John Curtis, Senator Mitt Romney, and Judge Thomas Griffith. These names may be unfamiliar to non-Utah readers, but they are surely known to any current or former students of BYU. Judge Griffith, especially, frequents the *Washington Seminar* and has given multiple lectures and forums at BYU's Provo campus and Law School. Those who know Judge Griffith are also likely familiar with his central message, as he rarely deviates from his established theme; prior to hearing him lecture at the *Washington Seminar*, I heard the exact same forum at BYU just months earlier.

Judge Griffith's lectures typically begin with a statistic claiming that the current political polarization is similar to that at the time of the Civil War. This polarization, he argues, seeds unusual levels of contention and discontent among people who, in another, earlier political time, would have been cordial and friendly. Judge Griffith then contrasts this political polarization and tumult to that of the Founders at the Constitutional Convention of 1787, when they convened to ratify the Constitution. Despite their sincere differences and disagreements, the Founders, Griffith recounts, ate, partied, and even slept together (sometimes in shared beds) throughout the duration of the Convention. Using this historical example, Judge Griffith calls for a similar form of civility and unity to transform today's political Left and Right. Drawing from Elder Oak's 2021 General Conference talk on the Constitution, Judge Griffith argues that on contentious issues—those moral issues that divide us to the core like abortion or gay marriage—we should “moderate and compromise,” similar to how the Founders “moderated” and “compromised” on their competing conceptions of the Constitution.

Judge Griffith's “stay out of the culture war” rhetoric tends to make me roll my eyes, and it didn't help that, at the time, I was working for a pro-life organization on a key culture war issue: abortion. To drive his lecture home and to solidify my suspicions, Judge Griffith recounted a question posed by a young BYU Law student after he had given a similar presentation. The student, surely one of those uncivil culture warriors, raised his hand and asked, “What

about Captain Moroni or President Benson?" The student's question, sincere enough, cuts to the core of Judge Griffith's political posture: what about those courageous, virtuous leaders who boldly stood *for* something and, as such, stood *against* something? Are we to follow their more active political engagement, or are we to take a more prostrated, hands-off approach to pressing moral-political issues? Judge Griffith bluntly responded, "I don't remember sustaining Captain Moroni, or President Benson for that matter."

Come to think of it, I don't remember raising my hand and sustaining Captain Moroni or President Benson either (as if that were the issue). I do, however, remember sustaining the current First Presidency and Quorum of the Twelve as Prophets, Seers, and Revelators, who have reminded us of the dangers of moral relativism, the degradation of the family, the necessity of a moral and virtuous people, and the importance to "lift where we stand," including in the public-political sphere. Judge Griffith, like many others, falls into the trap of hyper-focusing on a single theme or talk in General Conference, such as President Nelson's call to be "Peacemakers," while staying silent on other themes that run contrary to his conception of civility. Indeed, the inverse mistake to conveniently ignore warnings against contention and alienating our neighbor is also common for those adamantly engaged in the culture war. I should emphasize, however, that the former mistake, the tendency to adopt a vacuous civility, dominates politics and culture at BYU.

The "civility trap" is seen as a higher, holier road of politics as it portends to remain aloof from the most contentious moral-political issues of our day. It can thus claim to be "politically neutral" or at least non-partisan in a way that appeals to BYU's status and professional culture of political neutrality. However, the problem is that compromising on fundamental moral-political issues is not merely a compromise in favor of civility, an agreement to "disagree better," or a step in pursuit of "liberal neutrality." Compromise, ultimately, is a deeply moral-political claim because the compromise is always in favor of one conception of Right and Wrong over another. Compromising in favor of gay marriage or enshrining the

“reproductive right” to murder one’s child is, effectually, conceding that such actions are morally permissible.

This civility trap is not new and, I argue, is merely another manifestation in a post-Christian world. Professor Daniel J. Mahoney’s brilliant *The Idol of Our Age* tracks how “humanitarianism,” itself a remnant of a perverted Christianity with parallels to the cult of civility, is “the single most powerful factor in the shaping of our public and private thoughts, feelings, and actions.” The great French political philosopher Pierre Manent, writing the foreword, encapsulates the humanitarian ethos in the following manner:

I would summarize it in the following way: Peace and unity belong to the natural condition of mankind; conversely, its fragmentation into separate political bodies solicitous of their independence is the toxic fountainhead of everything that is wrong in human circumstances. Thus the right thing to do, the worthy enterprise, is to bring about the pacification and unification of humanity through the erasing or weakening of borders, the acceleration of the circulation of goods, services, information, and human beings, the fostering of an ever stronger and wider fellow-feeling among countries and peoples.

Pierre Manent perceives the humanitarian urge on a universal stage, on the stage of “mankind” or “humanity”; this near-incomprehensible universality may differ slightly from our more localized talk at BYU of “civility.” The humanitarian impulse threatens the erasure of concrete “political bodies,” such as the nation-state or the community, in favor of a worldwide humanity. This erasure is necessary as the humanitarian ethos, like the cult of civility, forbids any strict or enforced exclusivity or particularity. The perspective of the nation “is intrinsically wrong because it amounts to turning one’s back on the rest of mankind.” While the perspective of a worldwide humanity “is intrinsically right and ‘progressive.’”

The political-moral consequences of the humanitarian ethos from the perspective of a shared humanity are drastic. Any attachment to one’s nation or community is seen as exclusionary and

“against humanity”; the claim that “my country is better than their country” or is “more preferable for me” is not “loving” and does not exemplify humanitarian “openness.” Like the cult of civility, this radical humanitarian openness relativizes the political sphere:

Under the guise of a seductive impartiality or universality, this ‘humanitarianism’ involves a general scrambling of the reference points from which human beings... take their bearings. If we find less and less to love and admire, even to understand, in the human associations to which we belong and from which we draw the greatest part of our moral and intellectual resources, and instead entertain a principled preference for what is foreign, far off, in general, ‘other’... then what Professor Mahoney calls our ‘moral cognition’ is impaired, indeed gravely warped.

This impairment is due to the generalization and erasure of national and cultural borders; as each culture, irrespective of its content, is now rendered equally worthy of recognition and dignity, there is no room to discern between “good and evil, right and wrong.” Such a discrimination, as exemplified in Leo Strauss’ definition of political action, is “*the* theme of practical life.” While the claims of civility and secular humanitarianism may differ, their effects are the same: the generalization and liberalization of the political sphere in favor of an abstract ideal, paired with a new ideological vocabulary that easily distinguishes the innocent from the guilty (civil/uncivil, for humanity/against humanity). Any potentially exclusionary or isolating political position, then, becomes the enemy of “civility.”

With delicacy, I now turn to an example at Brigham Young University to further interrogate the homogenizing effects of the “civility trap” and the secular-humanitarian ethos at BYU. As I intend to show, adopting these leveling forces in pursuit of “inclusivity” or “belonging” risks undermining the particularity of our unique Gospel message.

BYU’s Office of Civic Engagement intends to “provide students and faculty with the appropriate skills and meaningful opportuni-

ties to become engaged in their respective communities.” In doing so, the office provides “specific training in leadership and organizational skills” and “hands-on activities.” On January 16th, 2024, the office hosted a “Catholic Mass Celebration,” featuring the “first-ever Catholic Mass on BYU campus.” This event intended to represent “a significant step in fostering interfaith relations and building bridges of understanding.” One of the featured photos from the mass displayed a large, packed room of students with the priest preparing the Eucharist. Another similar event called “Worship Night,” hosted by BYU’s Office of Belonging, featured pastors and band members from *Mosaic Church*, located in Provo. According to the church’s “About” page, *Mosaic* was founded to evangelize the “less than 0.5% of Provo professing faith in the biblical Jesus.” Their location in Provo is described as “intentional” so that the “power of the Gospel” could “transform the most *unchurched* city in North America”—this, despite the fact that Provo was considered by *Gallup* as the “most religious metropolitan region in the United States.”

We are to understand from the statement from *Mosaic Church* that their theological claims view us Latter-day Saints as non-Christian; this type of rhetoric is not new coming from evangelicals and protestants. We can say, also, that the confessions of the Catholic faith do not mesh well with the doctrines of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, the nature of God being the fundamental disagreement. In saying this, I do not mean to come out as “against” all forms of interfaith work. I do, however, wonder whether inviting churches with beliefs and sacraments that fundamentally differ from our own to hold services on our consecrated campus is a prudent decision. It is no secret that Latter-day Saint young adults are struggling in their faith as the trends of our sexualized and secularized society entice us to relinquish our unpopular beliefs. Is it truly a good decision, then, to provide students with an alternative religious service, right here on campus?

This confusion brings to mind a story recounted by Joseph Fielding McConkie in the biography of his father, the doctrinal giant, Elder Bruce R. McConkie. In the spring of 1984, Elder McConkie

was tasked to counsel faculty at BYU who were preparing to teach the Book of Mormon in the upcoming fall. At the beginning of the meeting, Elder McConkie pulled a paper out of his briefcase that “about bowled him over” when he first saw it. The paper contained “results of a testimony survey” given at the Provo MTC; the survey contained a list of ten statements to which the participants were supposed to respond in one of four ways:

- A. I know this to be true because I have received a spiritual witness of its truthfulness.
- B. I believe this to be true, but I have not received a spiritual witness.
- C. I do not know whether this is true.
- D. I doubt whether this is true.

Elder McConkie then asked the faculty, “Would you be interested in knowing which of these [ten statements] was the lowest in terms of testimony?” The results found that the lowest areas of testimony across elders, sisters, and couples were the following:

Joseph Smith is a prophet of God.

The Book of Mormon is the word of God.

The shock amongst the faculty was palpable. Taking a second to think about the matter, Elder McConkie rose to his feet and said, boldly:

Maybe in our efforts as a Church to ensure that everyone knows we're Christian, we have gone too far. A while back we changed our missionary discussions to make our first discussion a message about Christ. It seemed at the time a good thing to do, given that Jesus is the Head of the Church. But what was the result? A decrease in convert baptisms and a decrease in the number of copies of the Book of Mormon placed by full-time missionaries... We are not teaching the Restoration as we ought to.

Then, most pertinent to us, Elder McConkie added the following:

We will never achieve the quantity and quality of converts that President Kimball and the Lord have envisioned as long as we continue to stress the similarities between us and those of other faiths. It is only when we stress the differences that we are able to make our distinctive contribution in the world and thus make our influence felt.

My concern is not whether the Church generally is abandoning the unique message of the restoration. Rather, it is whether BYU, in its hopes to appear inclusive, accepting, and in favor of “belonging,” is running the risk of downplaying the particularity of the message of the restored Gospel. Likewise, as we continue to bring secular scholars on campus, such as the openly gay and self-described “life-long atheist” Johnathan Rauch, who commend us for our “openness,” we downplay the holy demands of our religious beliefs. In our attempts to show that we are just as “Christian” as any other sectarian faith, and by inviting other churches with their sacraments and doctrines to perform services on our campus, we relinquish the claims of our unique message of a restored gospel—the one and only *true* gospel. Is it too far to hope that when a member of another faith, whether clergy or congregant, visits our campus, they feel and engage directly with our particular Gospel message? Surely, when the protestant pastor and the Catholic priest came and performed their services on our campus, they, too, had the hope that their particular message would reach the souls of our students.

In opposition to the leveling of the political sphere from the cult of civility and secular humanitarianism, it is time we, political animals and Christian believers, embrace that political action is guided by an idea of Good and Bad. Calls for civility, albeit useful for a cordial political discourse, contain no moral content, no inherent conception of Good or Bad, and are thus easily wielded by progressive liberals in favor of a political order that undermines our very conception of what is Good. Civility can only go so far when an unborn baby’s life is on the table or when the nature of marriage, the foundational unit of society, is up for radical redefinition. Calls

for humanitarian openness and inclusivity must also have a limit to their extension. A sane political order cannot maintain the security, prosperity, and common good of her citizens without sovereign borders; human beings are not merely “transferable” from one state to another, but each brings his or her own political, cultural, and religious claims—claims that may very well conflict with our own! It is, then, our prejudice and prerogative as American citizens to determine the standards of entry and assimilation into *our* country. In short, it is our political imperative to embrace our particularity in light of the globalizing and leveling effect of the cult of civility and the secular-humanitarian urge.

In opposition to the threat to the unique message of the restored Gospel, it is time that we, as members of the Lord’s living Church, boldly embrace the particularity of our faith. This does not require any loss of the universality of our message that all are called to partake of the Divine word. Rather, it is a call to emphasize, when necessary, our differences with our sectarian Christian brothers and sisters and, furthermore, with our increasingly secular world. Such an emphasis, or embrace of our particularity, would include having the courage to put our message first: to prioritize members of our faith in the hiring of faculty and our guest devotional and forum speakers. It would include the bravery to reject the ill-conceived idea that we must receive affirmation from the secular, scholarly world to “keep on pace” with other universities.

This bravery is perhaps illustrated best by yet another personal story of Elder Bruce McConkie. As Elder McConkie was preparing to write his comprehensive *Messiah* series, he “made it a point to read everything that Elder James E. Talmage had read on the subject.” Included in one of the books was a certain anecdote from a “sectarian scholar that harmonized perfectly with the restored gospel.” Out of excitement over his find, Elder McConkie approached Elder Marion G. Romney and shared the anecdote. Responding, President Romney shared his own discovery of a similar gospel-affirming secular anecdote which he had previously discussed with Elder J. Reuben Clark. Elder Clark counseled Elder Romney as such: “Look, Marion, when you read things from the great scholars

of the world and they don't agree with us, so what? And when you read something like that and you find they are right on the mark and they agree with us, so what?"

If we risk hearing less from secular Ivy League devotional speakers by prioritizing faithful members of our faith, so what? If we, in promoting interfaith work, host religious activities with explicit messages of the restoration and run the risk of putting off other believers, so what? And, if we, in defending the sanctity of the family and opposing the sexual liberationist agenda, are labeled as "uncivil" and lose some support from the world, so what? Let us prudently, cautiously, and with good aim, take up our muskets and defend the particularity of our gospel message in the public sphere.

*Let us all press on in the work of the Lord,
That when life is o'er we may gain a reward;
In the fight for right let us wield a sword,
The mighty sword of truth.*

*Fear not, though the enemy deride;
Courage, for the Lord is on our side.
We will heed not what the wicked may say,
But the Lord alone we will obey.*

Authentic Propaganda

JAX MCKINNEY

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All media is propaganda. From the morning news on your television to the tweets, TikToks, and Instagram posts you scroll through during the day, every piece of media you consume carries an intention. People seek out news, influencers, documentaries, and viral content for both entertainment and information. Yet, behind every post, every news segment, and every film, there are creators making deliberate choices. These choices are shaped by the creator's own biases, values, and beliefs, whether consciously or unconsciously. The term "propaganda" may traditionally carry negative connotations—images of wartime posters or government brainwashing—but at its core, propaganda is simply media crafted to persuade, influence, or emotionally move its audience. In this sense, the very fabric of our media landscape is built on propaganda.

When an Instagram influencer shares an emotionally charged post about a social cause, they are engaging in propaganda. When a news organization determines which stories deserve airtime and which do not, they are curating a narrative. When a documentary filmmaker selects certain facts to highlight and others to omit for the sake of a two-hour runtime, they are shaping a message. No matter how noble or well-intentioned the motive, all media is inherently subjective: there is no purely "objective" news, documentary, or social media post. Every act of curation is also an act of influence.

Increasingly, audiences seem aware that they are being sold a narrative rather than presented with a neutral depiction of reality. Institutions that were once deemed trustworthy—legacy media, academic experts, peer-reviewed studies—are now met with growing skepticism. This erosion of trust can be attributed in part to instances where these sources have clung to narratives despite overwhelming evidence to the contrary. Topics like transgender ideology, media portrayals of crime, and politicized science have accelerated this trend. People can sense when they are being manipulated, and the result is widespread cynicism toward traditional authorities.

An illuminating example of media bias comes from a 2022 investigation by the *Washington Free Beacon*. The outlet conducted a review of approximately 1,100 articles published between 2019 and 2021 by major newspapers such as the *New York Times*, *Chicago Tribune*, and *Los Angeles Times*, seeking to determine whether the race of offenders affected the way homicide stories were reported. The findings were stark: when the perpetrator was white, newspapers were three to four times more likely to mention race early in the article compared to when the perpetrator was non-white. In many cases, the race of non-white offenders was omitted altogether or mentioned far later in the piece. The disparity widened notably after the death of George Floyd in 2020, suggesting a shift in editorial priorities.

Even if individual journalists did not explicitly set out to alter their coverage based on the race of the subject, the collective editorial decisions of these publications pushed a clear narrative. What is purported to be “objective” reporting already has subjective bias baked into its foundation. Thus any news that claims to be entirely impartial must be treated with skepticism because total objectivity is impossible.

Conservative-leaning outlets like *The Cougar Chronicle*, *Daily Wire*, or *Fox News* often present stories through a right-leaning lens, just as left-leaning platforms like *CNN*, *Huffington Post*, and *MSNBC* reflect progressive priorities. This is not necessarily a flaw, but a reflection of how media functions: every outlet serves

a particular audience and makes editorial choices based on what it deems relevant or important. What distinguishes these platforms is not only how they report, but also what they choose to report. This act of selection—deciding which stories to highlight and which to omit—is a natural part of storytelling and is inevitably shaped by perspective. There are, of course, practical constraints: only so many stories can be covered in a 24-hour news cycle. Still, the criteria used to make these decisions offers insight into a publication's broader priorities. Over time, these choices reveal the ideological angle, even if a publication denies having one. In today's decentralized media environment, audiences are more increasingly active participants. Viewers, readers, and listeners now scrutinize their sources more carefully, and the subtle manipulations that once went unnoticed are often called out in real time.

This growing awareness brings us to a critical question: in a world saturated with propaganda, what do people truly desire from their media sources? The answer is authenticity.

I used to believe that I should only trust sources that told the absolute truth—sources that never lied, never made mistakes, and never contradicted themselves. In my mind, a single error was enough to discredit an entire organization. But over time, I've come to recognize that this standard is impossible. Humans are fallible, and mistakes—whether by omission or oversight—are inevitable. What I now realize, and what I believe many others instinctively understand, is that perfection is not the goal. Instead of demanding flawless neutrality, it's more reasonable to acknowledge that all media contributes to shaping a narrative. What we truly seek are sources that strive for honesty, acknowledge their limitations, and come across as sincere.

This represents a fundamental shift in how younger generations engage with information compared to older generations. Where older audiences might have valued the polished authority of the evening news or the invulnerability of academic studies, younger audiences crave rawness and vulnerability. They don't expect influencers or podcasters to be infallible experts. Instead, they value people who are willing to share their immediate, unfiltered thoughts

and to publicly revise their opinions as they learn.

Figures like Joe Rogan and Theo Von, both of whom host massively popular podcasts, embody this new ideal. They openly admit their lack of expertise in many subjects. They ask naive questions. They change their minds. Their popularity does not stem from their authority but from their perceived authenticity. Audiences feel that they are getting real, unscripted conversations rather than carefully curated narratives. This messiness is precisely what many find so appealing. What people desire is “authentic propaganda.”

But even authenticity is not immune to manipulation. In the current media environment, authenticity itself has become a branding strategy. Brands, politicians, and influencers curate a façade of authenticity to build trust and engagement. A politician who speaks in slang or a corporation that posts memes may be participating in the strategic deployment of “realness.” This manufactured authenticity is no less propaganda than a wartime poster; it is simply more sophisticated, harder to detect.

Thus, we do not live in a post-propaganda world; we live in a post-illusion world. The real question is not whether we are being influenced—we undoubtedly are—but how transparently that influence is packaged. “Authentic propaganda” may seem like a paradox, but it is, in fact, the future of persuasion.

Consider how authenticity is weaponized in political discourse. Politicians who appear to speak “off the cuff” are often meticulously coached to seem spontaneous. A candidate’s gaffe may even be tolerated—or subtly encouraged—because it humanizes them. Meanwhile, a flawlessly delivered speech is now viewed with suspicion: “too polished” implies “too fake.” Authenticity has become the currency of credibility, even if that authenticity is itself an act.

The same trend is visible in brand marketing. Companies like *Wendy’s* and *Duolingo* have garnered massive followings on social media by posting in a tone that mimics the chaotic, self-aware humor of ordinary users. Their marketing departments understand that traditional corporate messaging is distrusted. By pretending to “be themselves,” these brands build parasocial relationships with their audiences, forging loyalty not through the quality of their

products but through emotional resonance.

Fake authenticity can quickly turn audiences against a brand or public figure. A prime example of this backlash is the “Silence, Brand” meme—a popular image of a crab with glowing red laser eyes firing beams, captioned with the phrase “silence, brand.” This meme emerged as a satirical response to companies that push too hard to appear relatable to younger generations. Examples abound: *Wendy’s* released a *Spotify* “mixtape” to reinforce its snarky online persona, *Steak-Umms* posted an introspective thread dissecting the Millennial and Gen Z experience, and *SunnyD* famously tweeted about struggling with depression. While these efforts initially sparked interest, many consumers quickly recognized them for what they were—calculated attempts at emotional influence. In response, users began flooding the comment sections of such posts with the “Silence, Brand” meme, exposing and ridiculing the brands’ transparent efforts to appear authentic.

This paradox—where authenticity can be both sincere and contrived—underscores the complexity of media consumption today. Critical thinking is more essential than ever. Audiences must learn to appreciate genuine authenticity when they find it, while also remaining skeptical of authenticity used as a marketing tactic.

All media is propaganda, but not all propaganda is malicious. In fact, propaganda, when delivered authentically, can foster genuine connections and a more honest public discourse. What people crave is not a fantasy of perfect, unbiased truth-telling, but a reality where their sources are willing to admit their own limitations. “Authentic propaganda” acknowledges its own agenda and invites the audience to think critically rather than passively absorb information. This is the new standard for credibility in the information age. The future belongs to those who can blend honesty with influence—to those who can persuade not by pretending to be objective, but by being transparent about their subjectivity.



False Compromise: Liberalism's Broken Understanding of Religious Freedom

JAMES HAYMORE

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I. Political Contention and Religious Freedom

How far can liberalism push religion before they come into conflict? Religion and liberalism have both served as staples of democracy in America, but what happens when the equilibrium between them gets out of balance? On one side of this debate lie those who land on the side of classical liberalism. These would argue that the United States has its origins as a great liberal experiment. Their narrative holds that America is an inherently secular nation that allows for complete freedom of thought and religious practice while remaining neutral. Liberal thinkers see America as a nation based on the moral idea of equal human dignity. Classical liberalism equates autonomy with dignity, claiming that to be able to act freely is the basis of dignity, and thus a government that maximizes freedom to act is maximizing dignity. With this conception of equal human

dignity, liberal thinkers see the U.S. Constitution as revolutionary because of the freedom it provides.

On the other side of this debate are the religious conservatives who understand the founding in a very different way. They see America not as revolutionary because it was liberal, but because it found a way to make liberalism work. The founders established a liberal society where freedom of speech and religion were allowed, but in moderation. What this side sees emerging from the founding is a liberal democracy that is moderated by conservatism and morality. The religious conservatives act within a moral framework based on Christian, traditional morality. Christian ideals serve to temper and moderate liberalism, which, if left unchecked, would be self-destructive.

What emerges from the debate of these two viewpoints is a key question with profound implications for religion and for the meaning of liberalism. It is no secret that American religious participation has been in decline in recent years. The fact that America is at an all-time religious low, paired with the contentious state of modern conservatism, has led many scholars to posit theories about how religion should find its place in the modern political world. Some would have it completely excluded, while others want a religious and moral replacement for liberalism. All of this is enough to leave one wondering what the future holds for religious freedom. At the end of the day, the fate of religion is deeply tied to that of liberalism. For religious freedom to survive, a system of liberalism moderated by conservatism is needed, and religion is essential to that moderating force.

II. Fukuyama and the Liberal viewpoint

The idea that liberalism needs to be moderated for religious freedom to survive may seem counterintuitive at first. After all, liberalism is the champion of free thinking and expression. In his book *Liberalism and Its Discontents*, Francis Fukuyama, a professor at Stanford, writes about how embracing liberalism to its fullest extent, or what could be deemed “pure liberalism,” is the way for America to overcome its current political and cultural strife. He

advocates for a society that more fully embraces free speech and individual autonomy while at the same time being very socially and community-minded. Fukuyama writes, “[A] liberal society protects human dignity by granting citizens an equal right to autonomy... It is this freedom that gives human beings dignity...” Fukuyama’s liberal society would maximize his conception of equal human dignity by maximizing autonomy. It is important to note that Fukuyama does believe in a moderate, practical liberalism and is not a libertarian. This is seen in his argument on free speech. He writes, “A third general liberal principle that needs to be followed is the need to protect freedom of speech, with an appropriate understanding of the limits of free speech.” Here we see a defense of freedom and autonomy, with a reliance on government to moderate that freedom. Fukuyama says that this is necessary as, “While liberal societies will disagree on final ends, they cannot function if they fail to agree on the basic facts” and “classical liberals need to acknowledge the need for government.” Fukuyama wants a society where there is trust in an impersonal government that treats all as equals. His argument largely centers on accepting government restrictions for the sake of the community. Fukuyama writes, “The distribution of that growth, and the maintenance of a degree of income and wealth equality, is important... all modern states redistribute resources to greater or lesser degrees.” This part of his argument is focused more on overcoming neoliberalism by embracing a more socialist economic plan. Fukuyama believes that equality and freedom go hand in hand, and thus a government that promotes economic equality promotes autonomy, and by extension, human dignity. This shows how Fukuyama ties questions of morality and dignity to the issue of economics.

On the subject of morality, Fukuyama would argue that this pure liberal system will allow religious freedom to flourish as the system is based on equal human dignity and pluralism. He writes, “Successful liberal societies have their own culture and understanding of the good life, even if that vision may be thinner than those offered by societies bound by a single religious doctrine.” Fukuyama lumps religious freedom in with free thought and expression by

taking the position that equal human dignity can serve as the basis for society. In his eyes, religious and non-religious thought are equal. He would see this as a neutral approach, according to which everyone can live in alignment with their own ideas of morality, with these ideas clashing only if respect for equal human dignity is jeopardized. Fukuyama sees this system as great, as it helps sustain his end goal of a more liberal society.

Fukuyama also directly addresses religion, though it is not a significant focus of his book. Understanding that some liberal thinkers find religion antiquated and harmful, he states that one of the key ideas that liberal societies must keep in mind is that “Human Autonomy is not unlimited.” In a pure liberal society, just as religion is no more valuable than any secular way of thinking, secularism is not more valuable than religion. Fukuyama encourages liberals to accept the fact that some may choose to give up some degree of freedom to religion. As valuable as choice is on the basis of equal human dignity, protecting choice requires allowing people to give it up.

That being said, Fukuyama inadvertently sets up a disagreement between religion and liberalism. He has set up a theory where a pure liberal system is the way to strengthen democracy and to create a stable society. This pure liberal society is all about freedom and choice. It is also about accepting others’ free thinking without embracing a firm standard to judge the value of those ideas. To surrender any degree of freedom, as Fukuyama claims religious persons are doing, would be a cardinal sin against liberalism. Fukuyama writes that, “[P]ersonal autonomy is the source of an individual’s fulfillment” and that “it is this freedom that gives human beings dignity.” It should be noted that Fukuyama does note that, “[This] does not mean that unlimited freedom and the constant disrupting of constraints will make a person more fulfilled.” It is unclear, however, if other liberals will embrace moderation as Fukuyama has. As will be seen in Daniel Mahoney’s discussion of the “Woke” movement and other radical liberal movements throughout history, moderation is necessary. Religion also inherently casts moral judgments upon events. Thus, in a pure liberal society it will always be

seen as critical of others and their ways of thinking. Religion does not conform to equal human dignity as it is seen by Fukuyama: a secular and allegedly neutral acceptance of all ideas.

III. Jonathan Rauch: Where Liberalism and Religion Meet

While Fukuyama sets forth the basis of the liberal viewpoint, he does not directly address religion and religious freedom. To better understand how liberalism and religion see one another, we turn to Jonathan Rauch's *Cross Purposes: Christianity's Broken Bargain with Democracy*. Rauch, like Fukuyama, is arguing for a more liberal society. As his argument is analyzed, it becomes clear that he believes that as religion becomes more liberal, American democracy is protected. This is similar to Fukuyama's argument that by embracing liberal principles, the U.S. will become more democratic. What Rauch is doing is applying the expansion of liberalism that Fukuyama calls for to the inherent balance in America between secularism and religion.

To understand the similarities between Rauch and Fukuyama, and more importantly, to analyze the pure liberal's opinion of religion, we must first analyze Rauch's argument. Jonathan Rauch is a journalist and a senior fellow at the Brookings Institute. He has published a number of books on subjects such as LGBTQ rights, American democracy, and public policy. In *Cross Purposes*, Rauch begins by looking at the decline of religion in America. He notes how our nation is less religious than ever, and how some backlash to this has arisen. This is seen to post liberals, some of whom argue for the creation of a religious state. He also points to how Christians largely support the MAGA movement. Rauch says that these actions show that Christianity is "thinning out" or reducing its beliefs to conservative talking points. This thinning will become problematic later in Rauch's analysis. Having thus set the stage for the current state of Christianity, Rauch then explores how it is necessary for American democracy.

Rauch begins his analysis of Christianity and democracy by noting that both secularism and Christianity are needed to allow lib-

eral democracy to flourish in America. According to Rauch, there are four fundamental questions that each society must be able to answer: mortality, morality, murder, and miracles. Rauch assigns Christianity the responsibility for answering the first two, while secularism has the responsibility for the latter two. Christianity can address fears that life has no meaning as it ends in death. After all, one of the key messages of Christianity is that life has a purpose and that death is not the end. Christianity can also address the problem of morality in a way that secularism cannot. Christianity has a unified system of morals that does not change and that is rooted in something substantial. Rauch finds secularism to be insufficient to completely answer these questions, as it inherently has no ties to anything outside this life. However, there are other questions that Rauch says secularism can uniquely answer.

Rauch states that secularism alone can answer questions of murder and miracles, while religion cannot do so satisfactorily. Rauch would argue that religion fails to answer why bad things happen in this world, or why a loving God would not prevent murder. He also claims that whereas Christianity must attribute the miraculous to an act of God for want of a more in-depth explanation, secularism and its ties to science can explain how the miraculous occurs. Thus, Rauch shows that a good democracy needs both religion and secular thought. If both sides are allowed to think and express themselves as they wish, they will balance out, compromise, and create a pure liberal society where democracy can flourish alongside choice and thought. The problem that Rauch then lays out is that Christianity is failing to uphold its end of the bargain. By thinning out and sharpening, Christianity has lost its ability to answer questions of mortality and morality in a way that is suitable to liberalism.

The first problem Rauch notices is the emergence of “thin Christianity.” Rauch argues that by aligning themselves with Trump and the America First movement, Christians and especially Evangelicals have sacrificed some of their beliefs in order to conform to conservative politics. To explain this phenomenon, Rauch quotes Utah governor Spencer Cox, who said, “[F]ar too often we’re replacing those connections with politics. Politics becomes our reli-

gion in many cases.” Rauch believes that Christians have hypocritically given themselves over to follow Trump, a man who does not embody their values.

The second problem that Rauch identifies is one of sharpness. He argues that Christianity has become too contentious and has forgotten its three key tenets, which, according to Catholic priest James Alison, are 1. Don’t be afraid 2. Imitate Jesus and 3. Forgive others. Rauch argues that out of fear of growing secularism, along with close pairing with a political party, Christianity has become afraid of those who believe differently. Rauch also argues that Christianity has lost the grace that is central to its moral code. Rauch describes his understanding of grace and why it stands out to him:

I understood that building an entire moral system on forgiveness — on undeserved forgiveness, what Christians call grace — was a radical, visionary, transformational idea. Liberalism has core ideas which, while not the same as forgiveness and grace, map onto them: forbearance, civility, and compromise.

In this quote, we see how Rauch makes a connection between liberalism and religion. He connects the idea of forgiving others to liberal ideas of compromise and allowing others to believe what they want to believe. This lays the foundation for how Rauch will describe the solution to the thinning and sharpening of Christianity.

To provide a solution to the problem of religions’ compromise with liberalism, Rauch points to The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. In 2015, The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints worked with LGBTQ+ advocacy groups and legislators to pass a law in Utah that both protected LGBTQ+ rights and religious freedom. This became known as the “Utah Compromise,” which inspired Rauch to look into the church as a potential source of a solution to the religious question. His studies led him to propose a solution of compromise as the goal when religion and secularism clash.

Rauch further argues that religion must be thicker, or true to its beliefs. Rauch looks at The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints' unique view on agency and the Constitution as part of this argument. He states, "The church is not compromising or deforming its doctrines to conform with contemporary exigencies; rather, it is teaching and modeling core doctrines which serve God and help us live together." Rauch believes that mainstream Christianity can do the same thing. At the end of the day, Rauch argues that the solution to Christianity's problems is for them to lean more into the liberal principles that are at the heart of America.

IV. Problems with the Liberal Viewpoint

What appears to be Rauch's end goal on the surface seems nice and peaceful. It is a world of compromise where religious and non-religious people compromise thanks to the guidance of liberalism. However, a misunderstanding of Christianity and a reliance upon a pure liberal system alone led to serious problems with Rauch's proposed solution and the conclusions he draws.

The first problem we run against is the way that the likes of Rauch and Fukuyama regard Christians and religious people in general. These two both argue for the persistence of religion in society and, in the case of Rauch, claim that it is necessary. Despite the fact that they are pro-religion secular liberals, they still dismiss the threat liberalism poses to religious freedom. Rauch and Fukuyama miss how the systems they propose will favor anti-religion secular liberals while hurting religious freedom. To understand why this is the case, we look at Fukuyama's argument for a pure liberal system where freedom is what matters most. This is supported by his statement that "Liberal societies assume an equality of human dignity, a dignity that is rooted in an individual's ability to make choices." Within this moral framework, religion, by giving up some degree of autonomy, is surrendering its dignity. How can religion be expected to have a voice if they are immediately dismissed for not accepting human autonomy as the root of all that is good? Fukuyama clearly sees the threat that an autonomy-based system poses to religion as he insists that liberals must accept that "autonomy... is

not the sole human good” and that “successful liberal societies... need to prioritize public-spiritedness, tolerance, open-mindedness, and active engagement in public affairs...” Fukuyama is making an attempt to bridge the gap between the fundamental values of pure liberalism and religion, but misses how dangerous liberalism can be to those who disagree with its fundamental tenets. Liberalism, when taken to an extreme, is so bent on progress that it feels the need to eliminate any ideology or group that would value something over human autonomy. This idea will be further explored later on with an analysis of Daniel Mahoney’s *The Persistence of the Ideological Lie*, but it is also seen in the examples of the French and Russian revolutions.

To demonstrate the dangers and the tyranny inherent in radical liberalism, we look at the French Revolution. In the French Revolution, radical liberal elites called for revolution to bring about liberal reform and to weaken the aristocracy. This revolution turned violent, however, as these elites pushed for the complete destruction of the old system of government. This is seen in the example of Robespierre, the leader of the French Revolution. Speaking of him, Mahoney writes,

His full embrace of fanaticism in the name of virtue and revolutionary principle reached a morally insane apex in his infamous speech of February 5, 1794. There, he announced that the revolution was endangered by ‘depraved men’ who regarded it ‘as a trade and the Republic as a spoil.’ L’Incorruptible had declared war on everyone and everything in the name of an impossible purity.

The pursuit of liberal principles can lead radicals to act in a way that is shockingly illiberal by declaring war on anything that they do not see as in alignment with their pure liberal principles. This is seen in the modern “woke” movement that, for all its talk of inclusion, is very unwilling to accept religious and conservative viewpoints. Fukuyama does call upon liberals to be more accepting of religion, but he misses how tyrannical liberal attitudes, like those present in Robespierre, are a natural offshoot of a liberal system

without moderation. Fukuyama may be in favor of religion, but by ignoring the threat pure liberalism poses to religion and calling for a system separated from religious morality, he dismisses religion.

Rauch further dismisses religion in his discussion of the four key questions that must be answered. In the middle of his discussion of the importance of both religion and secularism, he notes a caveat that not only supports his position as an atheist but also casts religion in a negative light. This caveat is his statement that not everyone may find answers to the questions of morality and mortality that religion addresses to be necessary. Rauch states that he does not care about his mortality, and he has an idea of what is moral that is sufficient for him. To justify this, Rauch quotes Richard Feynman, who said, "I think it is much more interesting to live not knowing than to have answers which might be wrong...." Rauch continues that on the issue of morality, "I do not believe religions actually answer that question. Instead, they rely on a cheat, which they call God." These quotes demonstrate that Rauch acknowledges a need for religion, but begrudgingly so. When we see the way he dismisses religion and the claims it makes, it makes one wonder how other secular liberals (especially ones who do not believe religion to be essential to democracy) will treat religion as it poses answers to morality and mortality. Religion is being assigned a place in a key balance, but in the same breath, its contribution is dismissed as false. How can religion come to the table with secular liberals to compromise when it is seen in such an uncharitable light? It is also important to note that as he raises the questions that secularism can answer, no admission is made that these answers may not be necessary for all. Religion is being portrayed as a crutch for the weak who cannot accept uncertainty, while secularism is handling the world as it really is. Religion is clearly not portrayed as on equal footing with secularism.

Rauch further adds to this problem of negative perceptions of religion. Rauch refers to religion's polarization as an "unforced error." He writes that, "One might be inclined to blame the secular culture for white evangelicalism's embrace of political partisanship... [but] the idea of a relentless legal attack on Christianity

is fanciful.” Rauch rejects the notion that Christianity could be responding to secularism on a couple of bases. First, he says that there is no legal attack being made against Christians. They are still a protected group in the United States. Next, he addresses concerns that the general public or elites may be against Christians. Rauch bats down these theories on the grounds that “Never before in American history have the law and the Supreme Court been as protective of religious liberty as they are right now “and that elites are not the problem because, “To the extent that the progressive cultural establishment abhors conservative evangelicals, it does so mainly because of their conservatism, not their Christianity.”

Rauch is quite frankly incorrect both about the current state of religious freedom law and the danger that elites pose to Christianity entirely. Later analysis of Stephen Smith’s *The Rise and Decline of American Religious Freedom* will address the first point, so for now, let us address the problem of elites. Intellectual elites are not some isolated and unimportant group. Their ideas permeate society and affect government officials. This misunderstanding leads Rauch to peg the blame solely on Christians, while ignoring the real cultural factors driving them to radicalize. Rauch claims that elites hate Christianity’s turn to conservatism, but he misses that many conservative beliefs originally come from Christianity. Conservatives’ moral beliefs on issues like gay marriage, abortion, and drug use come from Christianity. The elites who hate conservatism hate Christianity too, and this group is very influential and loud. Like Rauch and Fukuyama, they will place the burden of change completely on religion, though they will not assign it an essential place in society like Rauch does.

Both Rauch and Fukuyama fail to apply their own counsel and compromise when it comes to addressing the reason for current political discontent and religious struggles. This is seen in their lumping all of the blame and need for change squarely upon the shoulders of religion. Religion needs to change and compromise, but liberalism and secularism can keep doing what they are doing. After all, they allow all ways of thinking (or at least the ones not harmful to liberalism), and the emphasis on a secular government

leads to neutrality about who is right. Everyone is allowed to act as they wish as long as they do no harm (a rather arbitrary concept) to others. This is first seen in Fukuyama's brief call for liberals to accept religious freedom. Speaking of religion, and how liberals should not be so critical of it, he says, "[M]any people are happy to limit their freedom of choice by accepting religious and moral frameworks...." As previously discussed, this is phrased in such a way as to show the clear disconnect between liberal free thinkers and religious people. Few religious people would see their devotion as limiting their freedom. Joining a church does not make it impossible for you to sin; you simply are committed not to. Furthermore, many religious people may say that a moral life gives freedom by protecting them from addiction. The real key problem here, however, is that religion is being portrayed as completely countercultural to liberalism, the ideology that will save our democracy.

If religion and conservatism are to blame, then how can we really expect pure liberals to agree to compromise with religion? Liberalism and secularism are coming to the table as the saviors of democracy, while religion is tolerated only because it's necessary. As is seen in Rauch's treatment of religion's part in the balance of upholding democracy, secular liberals are generally dismissive of religion's contribution. Religion is necessary, but never right in the answers it gives. The compromise that ensues will not be equal, as religion will have to atone for its alleged radicalization. On top of this, its points can be dismissed as being built on false foundations. The prevailing cultural thought is already against religion and would be even more so if Rauch's ideas were universalized.

V. Rauch's Misunderstanding of LDS Theology

Another big problem with Rauch's analysis is that he misunderstands both Christianity as a whole and the position of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. Through his study of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, Rauch came to two conclusions on how Christianity can again fulfill its commitment to democracy and liberalism. Rauch argues that compromise is the way forward, a position he believes the Church supports.

He quotes Dallin H. Oaks, the second most senior leader in the church, who said in a speech at the University of Virginia while speaking of religion and political contention, “We need to work for a better way— a way to resolve differences without compromising core values.” From this statement as well as the actions of the Church regarding the Utah compromise, Rauch supports his argument that, “the first order of the day is not to claim supremacy for either religious or secular law... but to look— together— for ways to mitigate conflict.” Rauch proposes a solution where compromise is the goal when religion and secularism clash.

Rauch further argues that religion must be thicker, or truer to its beliefs. Rauch looks at The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints’ unique view on agency and the Constitution as part of this argument. He states, “The church is not compromising or deforming its doctrines to conform with contemporary exigencies; rather, it is teaching and modeling core doctrines which serve God *and* help us live together.” Rauch believes that mainstream Christianity can do the same thing. At the end of the day, Rauch argues that the solution to Christianity’s problems is for them to accept agency and America’s liberal roots.

Where Rauch goes wrong in terms of understanding religion is that his definition of a thick faith seems to be one that is simply useful to liberalism. He begins by misunderstanding the message of President Oaks as well as the Church’s position on agency. Rauch’s misunderstanding of what is core to Christianity is the cause of this. His interpretation of an already questionable list of core tenets of Christianity led him to reduce it to forgiveness and love for others. He sees grace as forgiveness alone, forgetting how it changes man to better align his actions with God. He sees agency as allowing all to act as they please, forgetting Christianity’s call on all men to live better and more moral lives. Rauch has reduced Christian belief to something that will allow all to act as they please, and in particular, those who identify as LGBTQ+. Rauch does not know where the line that Christianity cannot cross is. He wants it to be drawn arbitrarily to accommodate any system of belief. This amounts to Rauch asking religion to thin out again, but in reverse. Rather than

letting politics hold such sway in its churches, Christianity should care more about agency and forgiveness than anything else (Which is really just a shift towards liberal politics).

Rauch would be well served by looking at the context in which Latter-day Saints perceive agency. Promoting agency and being willing to compromise does not mean that anything goes. In the Book of Mormon, we see a government that is big on emphasizing freedom, with multiple wars being fought on that issue. That emphasis on freedom, however, did not limit their governments from regulating morality. This belief in both morality and agency was well explained by the Book of Mormon prophet Lehi, who said:

Wherefore, men are free according to the flesh; and all things are given them which are expedient unto man. And they are free to choose liberty and eternal life, through the great Mediator of all men, or to choose captivity and death, according to the captivity and power of the devil; for he seeketh that all men might be miserable like unto himself.

Here the LDS idea of moral agency is laid out. Agency and choice are key, but they serve a specific purpose. Instead of a baseless idea of freedom, moral agency as explained here exists so that we can choose to do what is right and choose eternal life, as opposed to it being forced on us. Rauch separates the moral element from agency, focusing just on our freedom to choose. This separation leads Rauch to misunderstand Christian theology and what it will not sacrifice.

If Rauch thinks that, because of Supreme Court cases like *Obergefell v. Hodges* or *Roe v. Wade*, Christianity is suddenly no longer allowed to take a stand on the moral issues they cover, he is mistaken. Christianity need not thin itself out on the side of liberalism by abandoning these issues. Rather, we see churches like The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints taking actions to ensure that they can continue to uphold their religious beliefs, as they did in the Utah compromise. In fact, mainstream Christianity's alliance with conservatism on issues like gay marriage and abortion is not thinning nor blindly adopting Republican rhetoric. Rauch

should not forget that it was Christianity and its beliefs that led conservatives to take a stand on these moral issues, not the other way around. Rauch cannot expect Christianity or religion as a whole to abandon its beliefs just so that they can be more useful to a pure liberal society.

One final problem with Rauch's desire for religion to adopt agency and forgiveness as its highest values is that Christianity is not the only religion. Even if we accept Rauch's argument that a radical view of agency is compatible with Christianity, what of other faiths? To be fair to Rauch, his work is focused on Christianity, given its key spot in our nation's history. Nonetheless, this is a serious hurdle that needs to be jumped. What if there is a religion that does not value liberal principles as much as Latter-Day Saints do, according to his interpretation? Do they deserve the same level of protection? When religion is reduced to being useful to liberalism as opposed to what it really is (an organized way for man to connect with God, the author of truth and the highest good), serious questions of the continued existence of religious freedom arise.

VI. Mahoney and the Threat of Radical Liberalism

Rauch and Fukuyama are both thinkers who are committed to the further development of democracy and religion's continued place in America. That being said, their basic assumptions lead them to create arguments that inadvertently pose a danger to religious freedom in America. Daniel Mahoney, a professor emeritus at Assumption University, and Stephen D. Smith, a law professor at the University of San Diego, can shed some light on the issue of liberalism and religious freedom. In their respective books, *The Persistence of the Ideological Lie* and *The Rise and Decline of American Religious Freedom*, they shed further light on problems in the liberal argument as presented by Fukuyama and Rauch and offer a way forward that preserves both the best parts of liberalism and religious freedom.

The first problem to be addressed is that of blame, or negative views of religion on the part of liberalism. Blaming religion and asking it to conform to pure liberalism is a problem, as is seen in

Daniel Mahoney's *The Persistence of the Ideological Lie*. In his book, Mahoney looks at how liberalism has become increasingly more radical with modern movements arguing for more of a belief in pure autonomy. By analyzing both Robespierre and Dostoevsky's *Demons*, Mahoney draws parallels between the flawed mentalities that brought about the French and Russian revolutions and the modern radical liberal movement in America, demonstrating that the seed of tyranny exists in liberalism. Mahoney argues that just as *Deamons* points out, there is a nihilistic element to pure liberal movements. When liberalism is taken to an extreme, it calls for a complete upheaval of old ways of thinking and old systems of government. Describing a section of Dostoevsky's writing, Mahoney describes Russian liberals as:

[C]hildren who have been taught by their teachers to laugh at God, lawyers who shamelessly defend the deeds of murderers for fear of being insufficiently progressive, school boys who kill "just to see how it feels," If religious academics who defend murder as either a sign of insanity or material necessity, but never of evil. They are "ours," he proclaims, fellow travelers and even unbeknownst foot soldiers of the party of nihilism. Many are "drunk" with ideology; many more will "get themselves even drunker" inebriated by the cult of revolution, "half-science," angry atheism, and contempt for all permanent standards and solid foundations for the indispensable distinction between good and evil.

Many parallels can be seen between those described in the above quote and the beliefs of radical liberal elites in America. Secular liberals have no moral basis, and so they defend that which is wrong while decrying the institutions and moral beliefs that have made our country what it is. One modern example of this that Mahoney gives is that of Marxism and its implementation in Russia and China. Speaking of their tendency to tear down the existing system and its moral code, he writes, "How does one abolish the moral contents of life without an unprecedented project of tyranny, terror, and centralization?" These societies completely destroyed old

systems of government, economics, morality, and religion in the name of establishing their version of Marxism. Some may feel that modern liberalism, as it exists in the U.S. today, is far removed from these communist regimes. However, the emphasis on autonomy and a desire to progress at the expense of old systems can lead to similar outcomes if left unmoderated. These groups call for revolution and for a complete overhaul of the system. Like the teachers in *Deamons*, teach us to laugh at God and to see religion as a cause of oppression, as opposed to a potential solution.

Rauch and Fukuyama blatantly ignore the dangers of radical liberalism in their calls for a pure and unmoderated liberal system. Each of them does make a halfhearted appeal to liberal thinkers to be kinder to religion, yet they fail to address the root of the issue. To draw a parallel to the thinking of the French Revolution, religion is a part of the aristocracy, and it must be completely eradicated in the name of freedom. While this is certainly not something that Fukuyama and Rauch believe, they miss the danger and radicalization that their ideas will cause. While they may have a moderated idea of liberalism, they fail to address how they will keep their more radical counterparts in check. These radical liberal thinkers could aptly be described as “clever but shameful apologists for revolutionary tyranny and terror, ‘Divine Violence’.” There is a real danger to religious freedom in a system of unchecked liberalism. History shows that when radical liberals go unchecked, as they would in a pure liberal system, they seek to destroy the whole system. Religion and religious freedom may have survived in the past where they were mainstream. But as religion becomes a minority, will religious freedom survive a complete upheaval of the old ways?

VII. Stephen Smith and the Way Forward for Religious Freedom

As has been shown above, religious freedom is not compatible with the pure liberal system that Fukuyama and Rauch prefer. The question becomes, what is the way forward for religious freedom? The answer can be found in University of San Diego law professor Stephen Smith’s discussion of religious freedom in his book, *The*

Rise and Decline of American Religious Freedom.

In this book, Smith discusses how the narrative that America was founded as a great liberal experiment that was dedicated to a secular and therefore neutral government is not accurate. Rather, “[T]he religious clauses of the First Amendment were understood at the time as doing nothing especially noteworthy....” The First Amendment upheld the status quo, stating that the religious question belonged to the states. It also rejected the idea that religious freedom was the same as free speech or expression. These were later secular inventions that are a modern development. Smith argues that secularism is not inherently neutral, nor must the government reject any attempt to touch religion or morality. Smith argues that the modern secular mindset is a revised and false story of history with dangerous implications:

In the revised story, by contrast, religious freedom is being subverted by... religious freedom itself (as currently understood), which through its commitments to equality and neutrality and secular government has effectively deprived itself of its historical reasons for being. Thus enfeebled and faced with being flattened by the juggernaut of “equality,” religious freedom’s long-term chances do not look promising.

The question arises, then, if the secular narrative is incorrect, what does religious freedom mean for how government and religion can mix? Smith explains how at America’s founding there were competing viewpoints: the providentialist viewpoint and the secular viewpoint. However, the religious and moral underpinnings of those on both sides allowed them to come to a way of navigating the separation of church and state without an expressly secular government.

The agreement that these sides came to was one of a “soft constitution.” As Smith puts it, “During the nineteenth century, it seems, Americans preferred a soft constitution...Under that soft constitution, constitutional questions could be argued, and different states and localities could reach their own conclusions. Thus, school prayer or Bible readings might be practiced in some states

or school districts and eschewed in others.” This system of a soft constitution was superior to the secular mindset we have today, as it does not try and pretend to be neutral like a secular government. A secular government is a settlement that Smith argues is disliked by all. Religious people dislike the removal of faith, while secular people feel it does not go far enough. After all, if the government is truly secular, why does our money say, “In God we Trust”? The better way is to return to the “American Settlement.” Let local governments work out what the people want through soft processes, as opposed to the Supreme Court rigidly demanding that the government stay secular, thinking that will make them neutral.

Smith also argues against the current status of religious freedom law in America. By arguing against the current legal rules shaping religious freedom decisions, Smith counters Rauch’s claim that Christianity is the most legally protected group of any in history and that there is no reason for Christians to worry about religious freedom law as it currently exists. Smith looks at the way Establishment Clause jurisprudence has developed since the key religious freedom cases of the 1960s and how that has degraded the American Settlement and religious freedom. Analyzing Justice Clark’s decision in *Abington School District v. Schempp*, a prayer in school case, he writes:

Clark announced a constitutional ‘test.’ [T]o withstand the strictures of the Establishment Clause’, his opinion for the Court declared, ‘there must be a secular legislative purpose and a primary effect that neither advances nor inhibits religion.’ Both themes—neutrality and governmental secularism— were destined to have long and influential constitutional careers.

Here, Smith introduces the first two pillars of modern religious freedom law, secularism and neutrality. Smith introduces the third key pillar with his discussion of the case *Lemon v. Kurtzman*. “ [I]n *Lemon v. Kurtzman*, the Court added a third requirement: a challenged law or program must not foster ‘excessive entanglement’ between government and religion.” Having thus laid out the three

main pillars of modern Establishment Clause law, Smith then turns to problems with it. The problem of the point of neutrality has already been discussed, causing dissatisfaction for all parties. Smith then gets to the issue of a law being secular by looking at the Establishment Clause's original intent. He writes, "[T]he original purpose of the establishment clause was not to constitutionalize any general principle, whether of no aid, secularism, or neutrality. Its purpose was simply to preclude the creation of a national church and, a bit more broadly, to leave the support or regulation of churches to the states." The key to the Establishment Clause is that decisions of religion were left up to the states. This allowed the American Settlement to flourish for most of our history. By reinterpreting this clause, however, religious freedom is endangered. Whereas before the state could choose to regulate or not regulate religion, to fund it or not to fund it, now the state's hands are completely tied when it comes to religion. It must be secular, which has been shown not to be neutral but rather opposed to religion. Religious freedom and democracy are both better served by the original understanding behind the American Settlement as opposed to a strict adherence to unmoderated liberal principles (such as secularism and neutrality).

In the American Settlement, religion acts as the moderating force that Mahoney calls for. Mahoney ends his book with a call for a new kind of liberalism. He writes:

To truly love liberty, ordered liberty, is to be a liberal of sorts, but not the kind who sees 'no enemies to the Left,' or who turns a blind eye to the totalitarian temptation with its cruel impulse to localize evil in suspects groups who are guilty less for what they have done than who they are. My qualified, if real and subordinate, liberalism is thus anti-totalitarian to the core.

What Mahoney is calling for is a type of liberalism that is moderated by conservatism. Progress that is restrained by morality will not go too far, nor run into the problems of radical liberalism described previously. And if we look at religion and the settlement

that existed for most of America's history, we can see that it is possible to have a moderated approach to religious freedom that is not secular, nor falsely neutral. The problem of blame can be solved as the American people work out a balance, just as we have throughout our history.

Adopting something closer to the American Settlement can also help to resolve the problem of misunderstanding religion. To begin with, a truly moderated liberalism will lead to negotiation and compromise as equals. In this environment, there will be no pressure on religion to thin out in the direction of liberalism. Religion will be allowed to truly promote what it believes without being decried as overly political or being reduced to forgiveness and free choice. This will allow religions to truly voice their beliefs and be understood.

The inherently local nature of the American Settlement will further allow for a true understanding of religion. The American Settlement mostly handled issues of religion locally, with different parts of the country coming to differing solutions. Smith clarifies this when he talks about the meaning of the religion clauses in the Bill of Rights, "As initially understood, the religion clauses were nothing especially grand or ambitious; they were simply a reaffirmation of the jurisdictional arrangement under which religion was within the jurisdiction of the states, not the national government." By breaking the question of religious freedom into many small agreements between religion and secularism, religion is better understood and protected. At the local level, people are conversing and understanding each other's situations and beliefs better. The beliefs of religious people as well as of secularists will be better respected as a specific plan for that area can be implemented as opposed to trying to create a blanket rule for the entirety of the Country. This settlement further allows people to be more able to address grievances, and if they dislike the settlement in one area, they are free to go somewhere else where things are different. As Smith puts it, "The distinctively American collaboration of the providential and the secular provided the nurturing substance from which arose some of the nation's most visionary political leaders"

The local nature of the American Settlement leads to more understanding of religion, more religious freedom, and more opportunities for redress and change in each community, based on its needs.

VIII. Conclusion

By merging the ideas of Mahoney and Smith, an idea of a moderated liberalism emerges that contrasts with the pure liberalism of Fukuyama and Rauch. Fukuyama and Rauch believe that more devotion to liberal principles of autonomy and pluralism, paired with compromise, can create a better, more democratic society. However, they miss how this framework leads to a one-sided compromise where religion is not an equal. By contrast, the moderated liberalism of Mahoney and Smith will allow for true compromise. Within their framework, conservatism and religious morality check liberalism's more radical tendencies. This allows for progress, but not to the point of tearing down the original system that allowed for that progress. Mahoney and Smith would have the people decide the question of the balance between religion and secularism. In each community, people can truly negotiate and compromise as opposed to having blanket restrictions put on them that don't allow them to even touch these issues. This type of society realizes that religious freedom requires freedom to resolve these issues as opposed to mandated detachment and secularism. Religious freedom will be bolstered as it is handled on a case-by-case, smaller level as opposed to blanket regulations for the whole country.

Religious freedom cannot survive without liberalism, but too much of a good thing can be a problem. A pure liberal system like the one Rauch and Fukuyama describe will have unintended consequences for religious freedom. It will create an environment where religion is forced into a one-sided compromise with secular liberals, with religion being cast in a negative light. Instead, what is needed is a moderated liberalism. Religion can serve as the moderating force via the traditional morality and conservatism that guided the American Settlement. In this way, religious freedom will be preserved and kept in its place as a fundamental liberty of the American people.

Defying The Spiral Of Silence

GREG MATSEN

Greg is the founder of Cwic Media and the host of the Cwic Show, available on YouTube and major podcast platforms. He is also the editor of the Substack newsletter “Alive and Intelligent.” Greg explores a wide range of topics, with a primary focus on the contrast between modern secular ideologies (“Philosophies of Men”) and eternal gospel truths, including insights into the temple. In addition to his media work, Greg leads educational gospel tours to Egypt and other locations throughout the ancient Near East and biblical world.

Standing for Something in an Age of Silence

The Spiral of Silence isn't just a clever academic theory, it's a mirror. And if we're honest, it reflects a lot more of our own hesitation than we'd like to admit. I've spoken for years about the problem of the Spiral of Silence within the church culture.

Let me give you the short version upfront: the Spiral of Silence isn't just some footnote in a dusty political science textbook, it's alive, well, and thriving in boardrooms, classrooms, churches, and even family group chats. This concept, first proposed by German political scientist Elisabeth Noelle-Neumann, explains why so many people stay silent in public discourse. According to her theory, individuals are far less likely to express their views when they believe they're in the minority. They retreat inward, afraid that speaking up might cost them socially. And in today's ideological minefield, it often does.

But there is a terrible twist. The perception of being in the minority is often just that, a perception. It's not rooted in reality. Most

of the time, the loudest voices aren't the most numerous. They're just, -loud. And coordinated. And persistent. They dominate the airwaves, the tweets, the staff meetings, and sometimes even the Relief Society lesson. What we mistake for consensus is often just a case of well-amplified intimidation.

This phenomenon has real consequences. It means that truth gets drowned out not by argument, but by volume. As in, the loudest voices, not the number of voices. It means people second-guess what they know to be right because they fear being shamed, canceled, or labeled. And if we don't address this spiral, if we don't each commit to standing for something, then we risk watching a lot of what we value quietly slip away. Not in some dramatic cultural collapse, but through the slow erosion of silence.

The Spiral in Action: From the Academy to the Chapel

Let's bring this down to where we live. Picture BYU. Or a faculty meeting. Or even your ward council. People sit on their hands not because they don't have opinions, but because they fear the fallout. What if I say something and it's not received well? What if I'm branded as the troublemaker, the zealot, the un-nice one?

Here's the uncomfortable truth: Conflict avoidance has become a Latter-day Saint pastime. We have equated niceness with righteousness, and politeness with spiritual maturity. Now, kindness is a fruit of the Spirit. But niceness? That's often fear in a cardigan. And fear, last time I checked, is not a spiritual gift. The Lord said to be peacemakers, not peacekeepers who never ruffle feathers. We can "walk the edge of the sword," the narrow walkway of charity and truth. Of mercy and judgment.

We see the spiral everywhere. At work, you know better than to push back against the latest DEI seminar. In schools, your kids are taught ideas you don't agree with, but you keep your head down. In the Church, you hear things that contradict doctrine and the scriptures, but you don't want to offend. So we say nothing. And nothing. And nothing. Until silence becomes habit. And habit becomes culture. And then the culture doesn't reflect truth, it reflects those loud voices, and cowardice.

Let me offer a few real-world snapshots. A Young Women's president I know taught a lesson on chastity and was gently but firmly rebuked afterward for being too "traditional." She didn't say anything unkind. She simply quoted the *For the Strength of Youth* booklet. But someone in the room was uncomfortable, so the quiet consensus became, "Maybe we don't bring that up again."

In another case, a seminary student asked a teacher why biological sex was being described as "assigned at birth" in a Church-run mental health training video. The teacher agreed it was confusing, but didn't feel safe clarifying publicly. "I'll talk to you about that later," he whispered, hoping no one else would hear.

This is precisely what Noelle-Neumann was getting at. Our perception of public opinion alters our behavior. We assume we're alone, so we sit down. But the math often betrays that assumption. You are not alone. You're just quieter than those who are wrong. As long as that is the case, the spiral keeps spinning and the Religion of Academia continues its long march.

A Latter-day Saint Variation: Spiritual Welfare

Now, I'll address something very specific to our Latter-day Saint culture. I call it Spiritual Welfare. It's the belief that unless the Prophet has spoken explicitly on a subject, we're off the hook. We can coast. We don't need to engage. After all, "We follow the Prophet," right? Well, yes. But also: no.

Doctrine and Covenants 58 is clear: "It is not meet that I should command in all things." Waiting around for top-down directives on every issue is not discipleship. It's dependency. And dependency weakens both individuals and communities. Just as welfare can erode initiative in temporal matters, spiritual welfare erodes our courage and agency.

We are not meant to be ecclesiastical infants forever, spoon-fed every decision. God expects us to grow up spiritually. And that means learning to act, not only to be "acted upon." Agency, like muscle, strengthens with use. When we hand over our responsibility to "those in charge," what we're really doing is abdicating the stewardship God placed in our hands.

I get this all the time: “Greg, why are you talking about Critical Theory, or BYU, or Church culture? Have the Brethren said anything about that?” If we only speak when we’ve been directly commanded to do so, we’re not disciples, we’re drones. The Lord has given us minds, hearts, and a whole lot of scriptural precedent for standing up when something is wrong. We don’t need a press release to exercise spiritual common sense. We don’t need ecclesiastical permission to act righteously. The power is in us. God put it there.

And let’s look at truth in its face: many of us aren’t actually afraid the Brethren haven’t said something, we’re afraid they have, and we’ll be responsible to act on it. Silence is easier than discipleship. Sustaining the Brethren doesn’t mean checking your brain at the chapel door. Your own initiative isn’t just allowed, it’s expected. The idea that following prophetic counsel requires spiritual autopilot is nowhere in the scriptures and certainly not in apostolic talks. In fact, if you’re doing it right, personal initiative and sustaining the Brethren go hand-in-hand like peanut butter and revelation.

That’s the real danger of Spiritual Welfare, it’s not that we don’t know what to do. It’s that we pretend not to, so we don’t have to. We sometimes adopt this passive posture as if obedience means paralysis. But the early Saints didn’t wait for a Church handbook before building temples or establishing communities. Joseph Smith didn’t wait for a committee before standing before mobs. And pioneers didn’t wait for church-wide announcements before crossing rivers and mountains. They moved. They built. They acted. They lifted where they stood.

To be anxiously engaged means to initiate righteous action. You’re not a policy memo recipient, you’re a covenant bearer. Don’t confuse inspiration with automation. God didn’t send you here to click “I agree” and log off. In short: stop waiting. Start building. God trusts you more than you think.

The Loud Minority vs. the Silent Majority OR The Violence of “Muskets” vs. Truth

Here’s what you need to know: most people agree with you.

Yes, you. You're not crazy. You're not extreme. You're not alone. The problem is that a small group of highly vocal individuals, both in and out of the Church, disproportionately shapes our conversations and policies. And everyone else is just... nodding quietly.

And it's not just happening in secular spaces. There are activist ideologies on all sides that demand conformity, and they know how to use shame as a tool. A bishop once told me about a situation where a member shared a carefully worded, gospel-aligned opinion in a fifth-Sunday meeting. Nothing harsh. Nothing political. Just a call for balance and discernment. By that evening, the bishop had three emails and two texts demanding disciplinary action. It's not that the member was wrong, it's that the crowd had been conditioned to believe disagreement equals harm.

This is what makes the Spiral of Silence so dangerous. It creates a false consensus. When enough good people stay silent, it starts to feel like everyone agrees with the loud voices. They don't. But perception becomes reality, and pretty soon the mists of darkness penetrate through an open Overton Window, and what used to be obvious gospel truth suddenly sounds controversial.

We're living in a time when saying "children need a mother and a father" or "biological sex is real" is enough to get you branded as dangerous. And yet, these are doctrines that come straight from the Family Proclamation. We're not drifting from the truth, the truth is being drowned out.

Back to BYU. Elder Holland's now-famous "musket fire" talk wasn't a call to arms, it was a plea for courage. He was practically begging the university to hold the line, to defend doctrine boldly. And yet, even after that talk, how many faculty members have truly taken up the charge? How many have gone silent instead of going forward? I've spoken to many of them. The numbers are not good.

And outside academia? Look at corporate settings where people are fired, disciplined, or socially exiled for expressing basic truths about biology, marriage, or parental rights. The lesson? Keep your head down, or else. But friends, we are not commanded to be covert Christians. We're commanded to be witnesses of Christ at all times, in all things, and in all places. And yes, that includes the

workplace, Sunday School, Elders Quorum, Relief Society, and even Young Women, it's even in their theme.

So here's the charge: Don't confuse the appearance of being outnumbered with being wrong. Don't mistake silence for consensus. Don't let the noise convince you that truth has changed. The loudest voices may get the spotlight, but the still, small voice carries eternity in it. And it only takes one voice to break the spiral. It only takes one voice to say, "The Emperor has no clothes!" Be that voice.

Lift Where You Stand

I saw Elder Craig C. Christensen lay this out clearly at a FAIR Conference a few years ago. He explained that Church leadership can only contribute about 10-15% of the effort needed to defend truth online. The other 85-90%? That's supposed to come from you. From members. From covenant-keeping, laptop-holding, gospel-defending Latter-day Saints who are willing to use their agency.

You are not a spectator in Zion. You are a participant. That is the Father's Plan. That is one of the distinct differences between the Restored Gospel and mainstream Christianity. We have a laser focus on participating with the Father in "bringing to pass the immortality and eternal life of man." Stop outsourcing your voice. Lift where you stand.

Of course, Standing For Something does not mean being loud, obnoxious, or combative. It means being clear, anchored, and charitable. Zion is not built on niceness. It's built on truth, and truth sometimes needs defenders who are willing to sweat a little. Your influence doesn't come from holding a title. It comes from holding the line. You don't need to have a podcast, a pulpit, or a following to be effective. You just need to be faithful and vocal.

Because once you do speak, you'll discover something remarkable: others were waiting for someone else to go first. And when you lift where you stand, you often inspire someone else to do the same. And of course, our influence doesn't come from titles or platforms, it comes from moral clarity. From the courage to speak even when your voice shakes. From the decision to prioritize principle over praise. It comes from choosing to speak even if you're the

only one standing. Because chances are, once you speak, you'll find you're not alone.

There Is No Neutral Ground

Elder Jörg Klebingat has been a breath of fresh doctrinal air in recent years. He reminds us that there was no neutrality in the premortal realm. You either defended the plan of salvation, or you didn't. There was no middle ground then, and there isn't now.

We sometimes forget this as we try to navigate complex social spaces. We think that by remaining silent we are preserving relationships, avoiding contention, or keeping the peace. But spiritual neutrality is a myth. Inaction is not innocent, it's an endorsement of the prevailing narrative. As President Oaks has said, "Truth and tolerance are not opposites."

And let's be clear: neutrality doesn't mean fairness, it means abdication. The adversary doesn't need you to be evil. He just needs you to be quiet. He doesn't need you to speak falsehoods. He just needs you to withhold the truth. This spiritual war of attrition that we're in isn't going to be won by fence-sitters. Neutrality is a myth. Silence is a position. And today, more than ever, choosing to remain silent is often indistinguishable from consent.

We often hear the phrase "choose your battles." And that's wise counsel, except when it becomes a way of choosing no battles at all. Not every disagreement requires confrontation, but moral clarity requires action. Courage doesn't always roar, it often whispers, "Do the right thing," even when the room is silent. But make no mistake, as the world drifts toward Babylon and you choose to hold your ground, there will be conflict. There doesn't have to be contention, but conflict is sometimes inevitable.

So yes, get involved. Yes, share truth. Yes, risk the awkward conversation. People are waiting for permission to speak truth. Be the one who gives it to them. Be the spark that breaks someone else's spiral of silence. The gospel has never been advanced by the comfortable or the cowardly. It has been moved forward by the brave and the faithful, by those who understand that standing for something usually means standing against something else. In the words

of Elder Holland, “You cannot sleep through this storm.” History honors those who stood for truth in times of confusion. We are writing history now. What will it say about us?

Doctrine & Covenants 58, Revisited

Let’s revisit D&C 58:26–29. It doesn’t mince words:

For behold, it is not meet that I should command in all things; for he that is compelled in all things, the same is a slothful and not a wise servant... Verily I say, men should be anxiously engaged in a good cause, and do many things of their own free will.

Translation? Quit waiting. Start doing. Strike your own match. Use your agency. That’s what it’s for. And yet how often do we wait for everything to be spelled out? We want every action to be “approved” and every stance to be endorsed before we move. But the Lord clearly says that being commanded in all things is not the mark of a wise servant... It’s the mark of a slothful one. Strong language. And it’s meant to shake us out of complacency.

We cannot outsource courage. We cannot schedule integrity. The gospel demands initiative. It expects action. Zion isn’t built by passive bystanders. It’s built by those willing to step forward in faith, even when the path isn’t fully mapped out.

Consider the early Saints. They didn’t have manuals or streamlined correlation. They had grit and revelation. They acted boldly, not because they had all the answers, but because they had all the faith.

This section of scripture reminds us that God expects us to make righteous decisions without always needing a nudge. He has given us the Light of Christ, the Holy Ghost, the scriptures, modern prophets, and the common sense that often comes with discipleship. When we ignore all that and still say, “I’ll wait until I’m told,” we are not showing faith; we are showing fear.

Agency is not a decorative doctrine; it’s the cornerstone of our spiritual identity. And we are meant to exercise it boldly, wisely, and faithfully. We are not robots in a moral simulation or simply

a body resting in the cocoons of the Matrix. We are agents unto ourselves, empowered by the Spirit to discern truth and act accordingly. Let's not be the generation that knew better but did nothing. Let's be anxiously engaged and joyfully responsible. Let's be wise, not slothful, servants. Where will we invest our pieces of silver? Where does our spiritual capital go?

Standing For Something in an Age That Stands for Nothing

Conviction isn't trendy, but it's vital.

Standing for something is wildly out of fashion these days, like rotary phones or modesty. In the age of chronic offense and curated feelings, conviction is treated more like a character flaw than a virtue. We're told to follow our hearts, even if our hearts are clearly intoxicated and driving blindfolded. Judgments and behavior, once anchored to values, are now tethered to vibes. And of course, vibes don't build character, families, or civilizations.

Despite all the affirmations and postmodern "you do you" mantras, something's off. We know from study and experience that behavior driven solely by emotion and self-interest doesn't exactly lead to human flourishing, it leads to fragility. It leads to spiritual vertigo. What we need is a modern upgrade of Thoreau's advice: "Don't just feel good. Feel good for something." Or better yet: Stand for something, before you fall for absolutely everything, including your own nonsense.

When we ignore deeper values, truth, duty, covenant loyalty, we become easier to rattle. Guilt creeps in. Shame tags along. Anxiety takes the wheel. And eventually, we start doubting ourselves not because we're humble, but because deep down, we suspect we're faking it. Worse still, we grow hypersensitive to the slightest slight against us, while blind to the damage we dish out in return. We weaponize outrage and call it righteousness. The result? More anger, less clarity. More posturing, less peace.

Back in the year 2000, when flip phones still roamed the earth, President Gordon B. Hinckley wrote *Standing for Something*. It wasn't just a nostalgic throwback to old-school values. It was a ral-

lying cry. He hoped to reach not only Latter-day Saints, but those “who may not be interested in our theology” yet care deeply about values that uplift individuals, communities, and nations. In his words, these are “values of everlasting benefit.” Meaning they work in 30 A.D., 1776, and yes, even in 2025.

The values President Hinckley called us to defend, honesty, integrity, civility, fidelity, tethered empathy and Christ-like compassion, are not optional accessories for the spiritually stylish. They’re bedrock. And they are, at their core, gospel values, not some generic “be nice” ethic, but truths revealed, restored, and designed to bind us to each other and to God.

So yes, standing for something may cost us likes, followers, and polite applause from the ever-evolving zeitgeist of the age. But in return, we gain something rare: the ability to look ourselves in the mirror and know we’re not just reacting—we’re rooted. We’re not just drifting, we’re anchored. We’re not just feeling good. We’re good for something.

Final Thoughts: The Tree of Life and the Pointing Fingers

Lehi’s vision in 1 Nephi is more relevant today than ever. There you are, holding to the iron rod, feasting on the love of God. But what’s happening off to the side? The Great and Spacious Building is full of people laughing, mocking, and pointing fingers. And some of those partaking of the fruit, some who should know better, look over at the mocking crowd, feel the shame, and fall away.

That’s the Spiral of Silence in a nutshell. The shame is real. The mocking is loud. But you must keep eating. You must keep holding on. You must be willing to stand out even if that means standing alone. We live in an era of spiritual gaslighting, where those who dare to hold fast to moral absolutes are labeled the extremists. And yet, it’s always been that way. Truth, especially eternal truth, doesn’t tend to win popularity contests. But it always holds up in the long run.

The temptation to blend in, to keep our heads down, to avoid being labeled. That temptation is real. But we weren’t sent here

to blend. We were sent to shine. Salt doesn't season by keeping to itself, nor by morphing into the flavor of the meal. Light doesn't do much good under a bushel. And covenant discipleship doesn't flourish in a culture of quietism.

When we choose silence over truth, we forfeit influence. Think about that! When we wait for permission to speak, we give away the authority God already gave us. When we mute our convictions for fear of being controversial, we become complicit in the very cultural drift we claim to oppose.

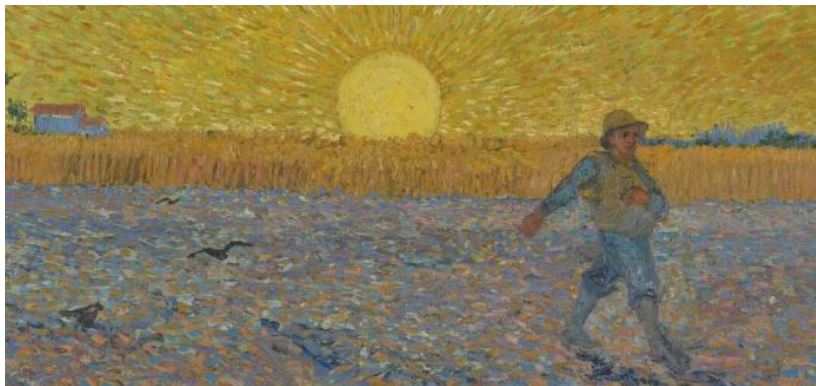
Let's be horribly honest. The Latter-day Saint community is experiencing a tension, a cultural tug-of-war between a commitment to revealed truth and a desire to blend into mainstream acceptability. One path leads to covenant keeping and eternal purpose. The other leads to moral drift and spiritual confusion. The choice isn't always easy, but it is always ours.

This isn't just about social issues or culture wars. It's about testimony. It's about the courage to say, "I know." It's about the faith to declare, "I will not move." As members of Christ's restored Church, we have a sacred responsibility to speak truth clearly and compassionately. We are not called to be invisible. We are not saved in silence. We are called to be "a light unto the world," not flickering candles under a bushel.

We will make mistakes. We will be misunderstood. But we are not meant to be neutral. We are meant to be engaged. The Book of Mormon reminds us that "the power is in [us]," and modern prophets have echoed the same. The Lord does not micromanage Zion. He expects us to lift where we stand, to step into the arena, and to own our role in the unfolding work of salvation.

So when the mocking fingers start pointing, and they will, hold the rod tighter. When someone rolls their eyes or questions your convictions, smile and stand taller. And when others begin to waver, let your example be a steady light. Lift where you stand. Speak while you still can. And trust that in doing so, you are not only defending the truth, you are living it. Because silence, left unchecked, becomes surrender. And we weren't restored to this latter-day cause to sit on the sidelines.

We were born for this!



The Plague of Systemic Mediocrity

LOGAN R. SPEARS

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Several years ago, a close friend shared a quote from Theodore Roosevelt's *Citizenship in a Republic* with me:

It is not the critic who counts; not the man who points out how the strong man stumbles, or where the doer of deeds could have done them better. The credit belongs to the man who is actually in the arena, whose face is marred by dust and sweat and blood; who strives valiantly; who errs, who comes short again and again, because there is no effort without error and shortcoming; but who does actually strive to do the deeds; who knows the great enthusiasms, the great

devotions; who spends himself in a worthy cause; who at the best knows in the end the triumph of high achievement, and who at the worst, if he fails, at least fails while daring greatly, so that his place shall never be with those cold and timid souls who neither know victory nor defeat.

I would be dishonest not to admit the impact this quote had on me—it dwells with me nearly four years after I first heard it and has become a cornerstone to how I tackle the challenges life throws my way. It enabled me to recognize and diagnose a fear of failure that stifled my growth and encouraged me to withdraw from worthy causes. I am not alone in this. Countless of my peers suffer from growing trends of anxiety that stifle their ability to achieve. A correct understanding of my situation was the pivotal factor in overcoming my fear of defeat and developing a mindset of high achievement.

Why did I lack so much confidence? Growing up in a system that lost its anchor in true Christian ideas of merit based on enabling grace was a large factor in my adoption of this mindset. Particularly, misinterpretation of scripture, such as the cheap grace philosophy, has led to things such as grade inflation and a “you do you” culture, ruining the confidence of entire generations. This fear was not just mine—it is a symptom of a deeper drift, where even sacred teachings are twisted to excuse apathy, leaving a generation unmoored like sand in the wind.

Misinterpretation 1: Cheap Grace

Anyone who has been to the beach knows that small particles of sand tend to move with even the smallest shifts in the elements. We learn from the Lord in Matthew 7:24-29 that when the winds, rains, and floods come, those who have not built themselves upon the teachings of Jesus Christ will fall. This is because the teachings of Jesus Christ, and Christ Himself, are a rock that can anchor us. These teachings are eternal and will remain valid through the end of time. Perhaps one of the teachings most under attack is the validity of hard work. Colossians 3:23-24 and Doctrine and

Covenants 64:34 affirm that Savior requires our effort. This is not because we can achieve all on our own but because our striving is like raising the sail on a boat. Our endeavor allows us to catch the wind that is the Savior's grace, allowing us to arrive at the higher and holier place the Redeemer would have us be.

The loss of a real understanding of diligence, work, and excellence reflects a core human trait. This trait is evident in both Christian and non-Christian perspectives. The height of Plato's metaphorical republic was led by a philosopher king. The purpose of the philosopher king was to orient the citizens to a higher way of thinking and acting as a community—toward the Good. This common, higher orientation would lead the republic to flourish. Millennia ago, Moses was taught that the goal of God the Father and His Son Jesus Christ is "to bring to pass the immortality and eternal life of man." Both philosophically serious and divine sources agree on a principle: for individuals and civilizations to thrive, they must pursue becoming, achieving, and doing more than their current circumstances allow. There is no stationary ground to stand on. At the individual and societal level, any degree of growth must occur to thrive—stagnation is decline.

As comforting as it is to know that I am not the only one who has or is suffering from hesitation in pursuing their goals, it is alarming to see that many in the BYU community and members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints have this illness. The illness is a direct attack from the adversary and one that I and much of Christendom have already suffered from.

This plague is mediocrity: an unwillingness to attempt, strive, or encourage themselves or others to live in a higher way. Christians are too willing to say, "You do you," discouraging attempts at personal growth. Conniving social media influencers and others with authority exploit, manipulate, and twist Christ's commandments as a way to eliminate the need for prudential self-growth. They practice a perverse sense of love that is not close to charity, the pure love of Christ. They refuse to inspire their brothers and sisters to live higher and holier, instead advocating a form of unconditional love that is un-Christlike. It embraces a sinful and stagnant state

of being.

To our friends and loved ones, on BYU campus and in Sunday schools alike, we must be careful not to invoke “love” or “non-judgment” in an attempt to stifle honesty and directness. Stifling these elements may preserve a comfortable but stagnant mediocrity. This does not mean tolerating rudeness and disallowing nuance. It means to glory, as Nephi did, in plainness. Love, non-judgment, and dishonesty to avoid uncomfortable conversations are all covers for slow inertia and avoiding aiding others in their quests for high achievement.

Many of these often well-intentioned but incorrect attempts at loving our neighbor stem from misinterpretations of the word of God. A common misunderstanding of grace leaves all types of Christians susceptible to this plague of complacency by diminishing effort. Dietrich Bonhoeffer coined this fallacy as “cheap grace.” When repentance is abstracted from works, such as confession or baptism, it no longer allows one to become perfect, as commanded by the Lord in Matthew 5:48. The necessity of our effort is true for all attempts to improve, whether explicitly religious or not. If we desire our metaphorical ship to arrive at a destination greater than we are now, how can we expect to get there without at least raising the sails?

Pierre Manent, in a foreword to Daniel Mahoney’s *The Idol of Our Age*, addressed a principle. It reveals how stagnation emerges when cheap grace governs our decision-making nexus:

Once the Christian God is no longer the keystone of the sacredness of the common, mankind itself is fated to become God—not in a metaphorical or loose sense, but in a politically relevant one: humankind is the only great thing that citizens can spontaneously and sincerely consider great than themselves, the true Grand-Être.

While generally speaking about the perversion of humanitarianism in Western society, a new meaning is brought to light in our specific application. When neglecting to help ourselves and those around us orient to a higher way of living, the implicit claim is that

our mere mortal state is “the true Grand-Être.” In so doing, we have made God in our own image and have lost the compass that orientates us to the Good. One of the most quoted lines in Dante’s *Inferno* reads “Abandon all hope, ye who enter here.” Certainly this line rings true for those who have made God after their own image—for if God is as they are, who is to aid or motivate them to repent of their sins?



*Dante and Virgil at the Gates
of Hell, William Blake,
Illustrations to Dante - The
Divine Comedy.*

As a note, we do not have the right to make the Final Judgment, but we must recognize sin and point the unrepentant to the Redeemer. This means that we strive to become and that we direct others to do the same. We must reject the tendency to be carnal and selfishly minded. This cheapening of grace not only undermines effort but also distorts love, the very heart of Christ’s commandments, leading us to another perilous misunderstanding.

Misinterpretation 2: The Two Great Commandments

Religion calls us to rise above our natural selves, to reach for a higher state—salvation, exaltation, enlightenment, or something more. Understanding how to get there matters deeply. It is at the core of Christ’s teachings, guiding us toward what we are meant to become.

Christians are given very forward direction in how to be oriented towards salvation.

Christ taught: “Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. This is the first and great commandment. And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets.”

Countless sermons and devotionals have been given on this subject, yet we still mix up the meaning of these commandments. We are to love God unconditionally, without reserve or question. Loving God involves living the Gospel of Jesus Christ which includes faith, repentance, baptism, receiving the gift of the Holy Ghost, and living all other commandments that the Lord would give unto us.

An example is portrayed in the Gospels and in the Book of Mormon:

Matthew 16 explains the Savior’s teachings that we must deny ourselves and take up the cross and follow Him. However, similar teachings in 3 Nephi 12 are more explicit, explaining that it is best that we should deny ourselves our sinful desires and this is how we take up our cross:

29 Behold, I give unto you a commandment, that ye suffer none of these things to enter into your heart; 30 For it is better that ye should deny yourselves of these things, wherein ye will take up your cross, than that ye should be cast into hell.

It is clear that loving God implies a level of respect shown through our striving to be obedient. As for the second commandment, love for ourselves is implied. Loving ourselves and our neighbor does not mean obeying our feelings or preserving comfort. It means obeying the Lord’s commandments, repenting with a broken heart and contrite spirit, and encouraging others to follow suit. This is true love for ourselves and our neighbor. Inherent in love is an effort to come unto Christ. The balance between the first and second commandments is crucial in our discipleship and has been frequently taught.

Elder D. Todd Christofferson, in his BYU Devotional titled “The First Commandment First” wrote, “Keeping the first com-

mandment also means promoting the Lord's cause in the earth, helping bring to pass the eternal life of our Father's children."

President Nelson, in a 2019 devotional, stated:

[S]ometimes we are accused of being uncaring as we teach the Father's requirements for exaltation in the celestial kingdom. But wouldn't it be far more uncaring for us not to tell the truth—not to teach what God has revealed?

It is precisely because we do care deeply about all of God's children that we proclaim His truth. We may not always tell people what they want to hear. Prophets are rarely popular. But we will always teach the truth!

And Elder Dallin H. Oaks, in the October 2019 General Conference, proclaimed:

Meanwhile, we must try to keep both of the great commandments. To do so, we walk a fine line between law and love—keeping the commandments and walking the covenant path, while loving our neighbors along the way. This walk requires us to seek divine inspiration on what to support and what to oppose and how to love and listen respectfully and teach in the process. Our walk demands that we not compromise on commandments but show forth a full measure of understanding and love... Our walk opposes recruitment away from the covenant path, and it denies support to any who lead people away from the Lord. In all of this we remember that God promises hope and ultimate joy and blessings for all who keep His commandments.

Accurate application of the duality between these two commandments is necessary if we are to attempt to follow in the footsteps of Christ. Instead of loving God and loving our neighbor as two separate actions, we would do well to ask ourselves: "how does this thought, action, or desire show God my commitment to Him and His laws and to express my love for my neighbor?" Elder Holland characterized this as "[administering] grace and [insisting]

on truth at the same time.” Thoughtfully tailoring our everything to these principles will answer the question without any if, and, or buts. We realize that there is no contradiction in these commandments. As we have misread these commandments, the fallout has not just been spiritual—it has rippled into our schools and systems, inflating merit until effort itself is hollowed out.

The Inflation of Merit

The consequences of cheap grace and a flawed definition of living the two great commandments are ingrained and disseminated among the rising generation through a variety of school and extra-curricular activities.

“Grade inflation” has, undeservingly, been a minor topic in social discourse. For those unfamiliar, grade inflation is the tendency of grade point averages to increase over time, but the quality of work to stay the same. Studies theorize that grade inflation initially started in the Vietnam era to keep students from failing out of high school and being drafted into the war. As well-intentioned as this effort may have been, the effects were lasting. As the educational narrative pivoted students, parents, and the workforce began demanding four-year college degrees. Research by Stuart Rojstaczer proposes that in order to meet these demands secondary schools began awarding higher grades. Others argue that it may also be due to the ease given to teachers by providing higher grades as it minimizes the effort needed in the grading process. Tim Donahue, writing in the *New York Times*, proposes that despite the reasoning for issuing higher grades, students are not learning the true meaning behind critical education material and missing out on lessons of resiliency and effort.

In *The Sports Journal*, Matthew J Williams wrote that grade inflation is often tied to participation trophies—and for good reason. Both attempt to achieve the end goal without valuing the effort that it takes to achieve those goals.

The idea was if we give kids trophies, if we tell them they're wonderful, if we tell them they're special, they'll sort of de-

velop a sense of fearlessness and then they'll actually be more willing to do difficult things, and actually we now have about 20 years of research that shows that's not true.

The youth of today look for ways to achieve something by contributing nothing, likely because important metrics and goals, such as grades, competitions, and similar measures are being handed out to people who do not originally qualify for them. This is a lie that young people can easily see through. Hoping the educational system has not completely failed, a math illustration makes this poignantly clear.

This pervasive distortion of effort and reward breeds a crippling uncertainty by destroying the calculus of decision making. Humans naturally assess costs and benefits to understand a goal's requirements. Yet when the scales are skewed—when constants like metrics or honest standards dissolve—solving for the effort required becomes impossible. Without a clear measure, we are left adrift, unable to gauge what it takes to succeed. It is no wonder, then, that anxieties increase and the will to strive falters. Logic dictates that a generation-handed sham victories, removed from the rigor of true achievement, would shrink from challenges that are impossible to know. This plague of lethargy swells—not from a lack of potential but from a system that obscures the path to realizing it.

This is deeper than grades and trophies. The plague of mediocrity is an infection eating at essential characteristics that are a part of our eternal identity. This is the opposite of what The West, and all of Christendom, has been based upon.

In a 2012 BYU devotional, Elder Tad R. Callister taught:

In contrast to the vast majority of mankind who wander in the wastelands of life seeking an identity through fame, power, or pleasure, we have a sure beacon that directs us to our divine destiny. That beacon is the restored gospel of Jesus Christ, which teaches us who we are and who we may become. It teaches us that character is the fabric of inner strength and conviction woven from countless righteous decisions, and that such character is not given but earned.

His words echo the Savior's call to build on rock, not sand. Character—our eternal currency—emerges not from handouts but from effort, refined and perfected by reliance on the Savior. A popular song from 2009, “The Climb”, reflects the yearning for our journey to mean something in and of itself:

*There's always gonna be another mountain
I'm always gonna wanna make it move
Always gonna be an uphill battle
Sometimes I'm gonna have to lose
Ain't about how fast I get there
Ain't about what's waiting on the other side
It's the climb*

The desire expressed in this song was a key component in its popularity. It speaks of a character who perseveres in a worthwhile cause. When we hand out rewards without effort, we dilute what merit means, letting complacency take root, and eliminate any chance that we can develop that character in ourselves. Basic economics shows it: value comes from scarcity and demand. Offer the prize without the work, and we rob ourselves of something deeper.

President David O. McKay once stated, “Character is the aim of true education; and science, history, and literature are but means used to accomplish this end. Character is not a gift—it is an achievement.”

This is the key: if we only value experiences that bring quick rewards and instant gratification, effort loses its meaning, and our character never develops. The Latter-day Saint view pushes back against this. Our life here matters in itself—it is a journey to draw us closer to Christ. There is value in trying. Through His endless power and sacrifice, Jesus lifts us past our weaknesses, helping those who strive to rely on His grace. He shapes willing hearts into what He knows we can become, even as we stumble, as long as we keep pressing forward.

The rapid inflation of merit has crushed the man in the arena.

His character and effort no longer hold valor, as the outcome is assured, favoring worldly gain over the process of becoming. This

breeds further symptoms. When effort and growth lose value, we are left unable to handle shortcomings, gaining nothing without the final prize. Defeat, once a chance to learn and push forward, now looms as a crushing barrier and a measure of worth.

Conclusion and Prescription

The answer to understanding and conceptualizing our strivings is one that requires commitment from both the individual and the collective effort. A story from a cherished source comes to mind, showing honesty and effort in lifting others higher, much like Christ urges us to do—a remedy worth sharing.

It was likely the game's final at-bat: two outs, bases loaded, down by one. A single would extend the inning; a double would clinch our little-league softball title. Cheers rang from the stands, urging me on. After a tense few pitches, I faced a full count—a walk could save us. I stepped up, swung, and struck out. Devastated, I walked to the car with my mom and said, "Mom, I think I lost us the game. I really sucked." She replied, "Yeah, you did." Mom then gave me a big hug and we loaded up the car.

My younger sister shared this tale. My mother could have softened the blow, praising my sister's effort to shield her eleven-year-old from pain. Instead, she chose to love how Christ loves by being a listening ear and being honest. This consistent blend of grace and truth has shaped my sister, my siblings, and me in two ways. First, we know where we stand and can improve from a clear starting point. Second, praise feels warranted, not hollow, because it is not something given cheaply.

That sister shone in high school sports, thriving under pressure; rejecting mediocrity still defines her. My mother's commitment to honest and constructive dialogue and my sister's humility in accepting it are a powerful prescription for the plague of mediocrity. Christians must resist excusing striving in themselves and others—it defies the Lord's teachings and mission. It is self-worship and dims hope for a better life and world. Embrace failure as a step, not

a stop. Value effort, be honest, aim high, see failure's beauty, and build real character.

Who at the worst, if he fails, at least fails while daring greatly, so that his place shall never be with those cold and timid souls who neither know victory nor defeat.



BYU's Tempest-Tossed Men And How To Rescue Them

KIMBALL CALL

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The young men of my generation are in serious trouble. I saw it in high school and on my mission, but it became most apparent when I was called to be an Elders Quorum president in my YSA ward. The so-called “epidemic of loneliness” is talked about in abstract terms, but up-close it was appalling. I watched helplessly as it ripped through my quorum, shredding self-esteem, stalling out ambition, and wrecking dreams. Women were affected by it too, but I envied how adept they were at addressing it. I once heard a sister say it was annoying how often Relief Society lessons focused on their intrinsic worth and God’s love for them. I silently wished my quorum had such a good problem.

Unfortunately, it’s not just my quorum. Young men all around the country – the entire Western world, in fact – appear to be in

troubled waters. In his book “Of Boys and Men,” Richard Reeves shows how men are falling behind in education, employment, and dating. Male college enrollment is down, unemployment is rising, and shifting social norms are leaving young men lonelier than ever. A 2022 Pew study found that half of single men are seeking relationships, compared to just 35% of women. With more men competing for fewer interested women, dating has become more difficult, adding to the crisis of isolation. Most alarmingly, rising depression, addiction, and suicide rates are hitting young men particularly hard. In 1991, men and women had similar rates of “deaths of despair” (suicides and overdoses), but today, men die from them at nearly three times the rate of women.

I don’t intend to depict young men as victims or cast blame. This is reality, which I’ve experienced firsthand in my Elders Quorum and among friends. As degrees, jobs, and partners feel increasingly scarce, they withdraw into video game addictions, pornography habits, or other obsessions, procrastinating essential life steps due to low confidence and self-esteem. Meanwhile, society amplifies female empowerment while branding men as toxic or privileged. My male peers grow bitter, feeling punished for sins they didn’t commit, suspicious of the system that isn’t working for them, and entirely unsure of what to do about it.

One day, while thinking about these problems, a sign on the wall of the JKB caught my attention. It listed student resources, which I scanned with a mix of hope and desperation. It included International Student Services, the Student Health Center, the University Accessibility Center, and at the end, Women’s Services and Resources.

A wave of disappointment hit me. BYU had an entire office for women’s services but nothing for struggling men. Obviously, I understood the context and why such a disparity would be justifiable to most people. But at that moment, it didn’t feel justified. The message was clear: women’s struggles deserved help; men’s issues were either not as bad or could just be figured out alone.

I didn’t resent women for having dedicated resources. Instead, I directed my thoughts towards the university, wishing only to see

something added to the list for men. Why should these problems be laid solely on the overburdened shoulders of young Elder's Quorum presidents? Our young men are suffering in silence because they've been taught their whole lives that their needs will always be second to somebody else's. I believe BYU should take action to change this, and it seems appropriate for it to begin by establishing an office of Men's Services and Resources to work in unity with the existing office of Women's Services and Resources.

A Simple Proposal

Some might find this proposal weak or even offensive, and I understand why. Many people have a mental gag reflex whenever they hear sympathy expressed towards men, immediately supposing the person expressing sympathy is opposed to women's rights and progress. Discussing men's issues often gets one labeled as "redpilled," misogynistic, or sexist, as if feeling compassion towards men is a trade-off, and the cost is hating women. I reject the premise that helping men and helping women are mutually exclusive. This mindset bears partial blame for fueling the crisis in young men. Ignoring their plight longer will have worse ramifications than violating the precepts of political correctness.

It's true that women have historically been on the losing end of the societal contract, but eventually we need to recognize the incredible successes of the feminist movement in correcting this. They've been so successful, in fact, that Women's BA degree share rose from 43% in 1979 to 58% in 2020, which means men are further behind women today than women were behind men 50 years ago. And since 1979, women's inflation-adjusted median wage has increased 29%, while men's has dropped by 3%, with poorer men hit hardest. Those who celebrate the male decline risk violating the promise of gender equality that the original feminists envisioned. If such disparities back then were indicators that women needed targeted help in education and the workplace, is it a stretch to suggest men need help when the disparities now affect them? It's for this reason I'm arguing for a paradigm shift. When women were behind, institutions stepped in to help them. Now men are behind,

and institutions should be equally proactive to prevent their crisis from worsening further.

Moreover, BYU is the institution uniquely positioned to lead out on this issue. No other university is built on a better foundation to heal divides between the sexes than one built on the doctrine of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, which teaches that an essential qualifier for eternal life is harmonious and synergistic cooperation between men and women. As I will describe, an office at BYU dedicated to helping men would be a fulfillment of both BYU's mission and its prophetic mandates. Women's progress would not be hampered, in fact, they would benefit greatly from it. Lastly, it would be a vital lifeline, a source of help and hope to the young men who are left to face the intense tempests of our time largely alone.

Rejecting the Premise

In 1871, early feminist icons Susan B. Anthony and Elizabeth Stanton made a visit to Salt Lake City. They were greeted by women and leaders from the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, including General Relief Society President Eliza R. Snow. The two spent time in the Utah territory praising Latter-day Saint women for making great progress for themselves, especially in earning the right to vote. But they also had some pointed critiques, particularly of the Church, its traditions, and its male leaders. They condemned not only the concept of the priesthood but also the practice of marrying young and having many children, which they argued benefited men over women. Elizabeth Stanton even called for women to establish their own religious creeds so they wouldn't be dependent on men for religious observance, while Susan B. Anthony said a church governed by revelation to men alone could never satisfy her.

A month later, President Eliza R. Snow wrote a speech to help the Church parse the praise and criticism. Supportive of the world's movement towards women's equality but alarmed by Stanton and Anthony's attacks on her faith, Snow wrote, "In the Church and Kingdom of God, the interests of men and women are the same; man has no interests separate from that of women, however it may

be in the outside world, our interests are all united.”

Today, Snow’s words stand out against a backdrop of social and gender division. How can men and women be united when the world insists there are only so many slices of “equality pie” to go around? Anthony and Stanton’s critiques are echoed by modern voices telling us men have too much of the pie – a concept known colloquially as “the patriarchy” – and women should upend the status quo to seize a bigger share. There’s also a growing reactionary movement among men, known by some as the “incel” or “ultra-masculinity” movement, who argue men should defend their slice of the pie and reject women’s gains. The fatal flaw in both arguments is their belief that it’s a zero-sum game, and this perception has filtered into the public consciousness, even in the church.

As I said earlier, I’m well aware people may have an instinctual negative reaction when they hear me expressing sympathy for men and may assume I’m opposed to women’s rights or women’s progress. On the contrary, I believe it’s possible and important to help both equally, and I argue helping our young men can lead to many benefits for women, specifically by providing them safer and better peers and, most importantly, more valuable and reliable partners.

Eliza R. Snow understood this concept of mutual benefit, arguing that it would be counterproductive for women to tear down men in the pursuit of equality and pointing out men only stood to gain from the increased capacity of women as they became educated, organized, and empowered. In one Relief Society meeting, the minutes record President Snow preaching to the sisters, “I feel happy to see so many of my brethren present. It strengthens me to have them know what we are teaching their wives and daughters. The outside world [is] continually clashing, but we like the assistance of our husbands in our organized state. We stand as [helpmeets] to our husbands.”

To Snow, there were no limited resources. Not only was there enough pie to go around, there was a way to make more for everyone. If we accept this as true for today, as she believed it was in 1871, we open the door to finding win-win solutions to the problem, something not possible in the world’s framework.

Our Legacy and Mandate

The legacy we inherit from predecessors like Snow also equips the Church and BYU to handle controversies that result when we reject the world's assumptions. In his 1975 speech *The Second Century of Brigham Young University*, President Spencer W. Kimball reinforced this legacy with a prophetic charge: “[W]e must be willing to break with the educational establishment (not foolishly or cavalierly, but thoughtfully and for good reason) in order to find gospel ways to help mankind. Gospel methodology, concepts, and insights can help us to do what the world cannot do in its own frame of reference.” President Shane Reese reiterated this charge for today’s generation in his 2023 inaugural address, saying, “BYU will realize President Kimball’s vision ‘only to the degree it embraces its uniqueness, its singularity . . . We must have the will to be different and to stand alone, if necessary . . .’” President Reese leads by example, and I hope we can answer the call he has reiterated many times. I believe helping young men is one way BYU can “[become] the BYU of prophecy.”

Currently, BYU places in the middle of the pack in how it addresses men’s and women’s issues. Most schools have resources for women, and any who have them for men almost always clarify that they exist only for men with diverse racial, ethnic, or sexual orientation backgrounds, not men as a whole. To have an office that exists to uplift men generally, without any further qualifiers, would be unique. The only one like this I’ve been able to find was founded recently, in 2024, when the University of Tennessee partnered with the American Institute for Men and Boys (AIBM) with the goal of addressing declining male enrollment rates. The opportunity is still wide open for BYU to assume moral leadership in the cause of seeking to elevate men and women with equal vigor.

In addition to our history and prophetic leadership, we should consider how the gospel of Jesus Christ empowers us to take action. Fundamental to our doctrine is the belief that within each man and woman are the seeds of godhood, which can only blossom in the context of co-equal and co-eternal union with one another. With

this at its heart, the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, and certainly its schools, has the best doctrinal vantage point to help both young men and young women fulfill their potential. We are unhindered by the false doctrine that says women and men can't or shouldn't be helped at the same time. As we embrace our history, our prophetic mandates, and our doctrine, we can be examples to the world of the truth: that the salvation of the human family depends on men and women loving and supporting each other, now and forever.

Now, let's take a closer look at what's happening on the ground. What is actually causing men to struggle so much, and what can BYU do to help? While trying to understand the difficulties of modern gender dynamics, I spoke with Jenet Erickson from Religious Education at BYU. She was able to connect my personal experiences to the wider conversation happening in the academic world. I'll attempt to distill a few key facts to explain the situation, what we can do about it, and why everyone stands to benefit from taking action. To do this, I want to focus on two main problems I believe an office for men could be effective at addressing: one, the problem of loneliness, and two, the problem of identity.

The Problem of Loneliness

The first problem we need to understand is how society's shifting standards around sex, marriage, and dating have derailed the social development of men and contributed to an epidemic of loneliness. One might think society's views of sex wouldn't greatly affect the culture of the Church or the culture at BYU, where abstinence until marriage is still the norm. Sadly, the body of the Church is not perfectly inoculated from the culture it exists in. If America catches a cold, the Church will cough too. This is why many of the issues I'm about to discuss are just as relevant to Provo men as they are to the rest of the country.

It began with the sexual revolution of the '60s and '70s, which upended American courtship norms by decoupling sex from marriage. Sociologist Mark Regnerus, author of *Cheap Sex*, argues this shift stripped boys of a key incentive to mature into men, who

now have access to sex and romance without needing to pay the traditional economic ‘costs’ like commitment and stability. Unfortunately, despite their gains in education and the workplace, women still generally want the ‘whole package’ from men: good genes, good money, and good behavior. In fact, women still desire to “marry up” in all three aspects. Both of these factors mean the pool of “marriageable men” is dwindling.

This contributes to the phenomenon encountered in studies on dating apps, where researchers find “the bottom 80% of men (in terms of attractiveness) are competing for the bottom 22% of women, and the top 78% of women are competing for the top 20% of men.” One data analyst evaluated a variety of such studies on dating behaviors. He said, “It seems hard to avoid a basic conclusion: that the majority of women find the majority of men unattractive and not worth engaging with romantically, while the reverse is not true.” Add this to the fact that 50% of men are in the dating market, as opposed to only 35% of women, and we can see just how dismal men’s chances really are.

So, in summary, a minority of high-value men enjoy a monopoly on romantic and sexual experiences with women, but the destruction of marriage has removed their incentive to offer commitment and mature into adulthood. The remaining men are frustrated both sexually and romantically, contributing to the loneliness epidemic they face today. This opens the door to coping mechanisms like pornography, drugs, and other distractions that stunt progress romantically, spiritually, educationally, and economically. Meanwhile, women are more educated and financially well off but continue to look for men who will offer stability and who are better off than they are—a demand increasingly harder for men to fulfill. Understandably, they are frustrated with the shortage of these men and put off by the surplus of juvenile, non-committal, poorly behaved men. Some women don’t even feel safe anymore, with the American Survey Center reporting that more than one in three single women believe that most men or all men would take sexual advantage of a woman if given the opportunity. Some of this trepidation is also affecting BYU, where women report being more

wary of dating and marriage than men.

It's a sad fact that men make up 7 in 10 Americans who say they have been rejected in courtship many times, nearly every time, or every time, and as an Elders Quorum president, this certainly held true in my quorum. Interviews and conversations consisted of reassuring members of my quorum of their value, reminding them they were needed, reassuring them it all would work out, and discussing with them the difficulties of being alone. This is where pornography habits, addictions, and other distractions wrought the most havoc. I often found myself wishing there was more I could do to get these young men help.

I know myself and many others in that situation—Bishoprics, young quorum presidencies, ministering brothers—would welcome BYU's institutional might as a godsend. With so many young men in one place, I'm not sure if there is another opportunity to do so much good for so many people at so little cost. If BYU had an office of men's resources and services, it could address loneliness by creating opportunities for young men to foster relationships with each other. It could address hardships in dating by providing resources such as mentoring or seminars aimed at helping men develop self-mastery, learn good behavior, and develop proactive patience. It could address procrastination and stagnation by advocating for men to work on their passions and could offer resources and networking for them to get started. It could also campaign against video-game addiction and other distractions and offer support to those dealing with hopelessness. Lastly, an office for men could address perhaps the biggest factor feeding into loneliness and stalled development: pornography.

In 2007, a study done at BYU found that 48% of male students view pornography at least once a week, with 3% of women reporting the same. 1 in 5 men even reported viewing it nearly once a day. These numbers align with national averages from the last few years, so it's likely they are roughly the same today (if not much higher). Using these numbers, there are likely more than 10,000 young men in Provo struggling with a pornography habit right now. This can be overwhelming to the ward and stake leaders, who

often serve as the only institutional line of defense. With so many resources at its disposal, BYU has a great opportunity to launch a positive, healthy, and gospel-centered attack on the pornography problem young men in the church face, and an office of men's resources and services, working in tandem with BYU Counseling and Psychological Services, could be the tip of the spear. There are many ways this could be done, but one I propose would be to host monthly live-streamed seminars, which could be joined both anonymously and in person, to educate men about the psychology of their pornography habits, provide strategies for quitting, offer help rebuilding self-esteem, and coach them on how to get back on their feet. As someone on the front lines with struggling men, I believe a recurring service matching this description would be well-attended every month if properly advertised.

The possible ways the loneliness crisis among men could be helped by a dedicated institutional resource at BYU are plentiful, and there are more areas to explore. For instance, it could address the aforementioned fact that the broken dating market is partially a result of men's overall decline in educational and career success compared to women. Perhaps, to help solve this, more needs to be done to offer men scholarships to graduate programs or advancement opportunities in certain fields, such as nursing or education. Perhaps we need to look at the rate of men dropping out of school. Perhaps we need to do more to foster networking and mentorship among male students. Much remains to be investigated, but as of right now, no effort to move in the direction of helping young men find connection would be wasted.

The Problem of Identity

The second problem is that young men haven't been properly taught who they are. When it comes to understanding what masculinity is, how it should be channeled, and if it's even a good thing or not, they are at a complete loss. This lack of identity comes down to a series of widespread societal failures in how we have educated and communicated with our young men for the past several decades. We can even see a side-effect of this here on campus.

If you google “men’s resources at BYU,” the current top result is, no joke, a page from the BYU Women’s Services and Resources website (WSR). It offers three paragraphs for men, inviting them to all activities hosted by WSR. On a couple of other web pages and in some of their advertising, WSR tries to appear as if it exists to help both “women and men.” Yet, their ‘About Page’ lists their goals as “[to] provide opportunities for women to help, befriend, and network with other women” and “[to] develop women as future leaders in their families, communities, and worldwide.”

Co-opting WSR to also be BYU’s main resource for male students (considering the lack of any others) creates more problems than it solves. First, and I say this respectfully, the language in the website comes across as insincere, hollow, and semi-disrespectful, as if men were an afterthought. It feels like a group of children reluctantly including a younger child in activities after being scolded. Second, Women’s Services and Resources has a right to be just for women and shouldn’t need to include men. Women are entitled to spaces for themselves. Third, men generally don’t react the same to messaging geared towards women, so communication to struggling young men coming from the women’s office will likely go unheeded. Finally, men and women have a variety of different problems, and they tend to solve problems differently, such as in relationship formation and responding to stress. This means a single office splitting its focus is inefficient; a better system would be two specialized offices united in an overarching purpose to serve the student body of BYU.

Unfortunately, BYU’s lack of an effective way to communicate with men is a microcosm of a complex problem permeating society, where a systemic lack of productive messaging on the issue of masculinity has exacerbated the crisis. This includes the shortage of male teachers in public education, the collapse of male-centric institutions such as the Boy Scouts of America, the cultural neglect of male achievement in favor of promoting female advancement, and the demonization of men by Hollywood, pundits, and politicians. Many underestimate how harmful this has been to boys. For instance, the idea that masculinity is “toxic” has done real harm to

how young boys think of themselves. This modern notion, an invention of high-minded academics, has even undermined the feminist movement, with 24% of women now saying that “feminists are anti-men.” Richard Reeves argues, “In the rush to condemn the dark side of masculine traits, [progressives] are in grave danger of pathologizing the traits themselves ... And to the boy or man who feels lusty or restless, the message, implicit or explicit, is all too often, there is something wrong with you.”

Similarly, the idea that men exist in a “patriarchy” and have “male privilege” has been damaging to young men’s sense of worth. These concepts are often used to justify discriminatory practices against men. Over 50% of young men in America say they face discrimination because of their gender, and a majority of Gen-Z men report they don’t identify as “feminist.” In laying the supposed sins of their forefathers at the feet of our newest generation of young men and refusing them atonement, we have sown the seeds of resentment, distrust, and pessimism in our next cohort of fathers, builders, creatives, and leaders.

By putting up artificial barriers around masculinity, important questions such as ‘what does a good man act like?’ or ‘how should I channel my masculine tendencies?’ are hard to answer, so young men are turning elsewhere for help. This has led to the creation of the ‘manosphere’, the overlapping collection of online men’s support communities which attempt to fill the gaps young men have been left with. Researchers Eva Bujalka and Ben Rich explain that “the ‘manosphere’ appeals to its audience because it speaks to the very real lives of young men [experiencing] romantic rejection, alienation, economic failure, loneliness, and a dim vision of the future.” The popularity of Andrew Tate, who attracts lost men with some sensible ideas before introducing them to his abhorrent and amoral view of the world, stands as a warning to parents and institutions everywhere that if we don’t raise our young men well, someone worse will do it for us. And while there are some very good voices out there that many young men are heeding (I would argue Jordan Peterson and Richard Reeves are among these), we are essentially leaving the development of our young men entirely

up to chance – unless we start taking a stand in the cultural mainstream.

At BYU, the social haze around masculinity serves as a weakening force on campus. Men are falling victim to voices in the manosphere, adopting views and behavior unbecoming of Latter-day Saints. Others adopt a victim mentality, reinforced by the internet, and blame women or other cultural forces for their problems. Most commonly, I see men accepting what they hear online so they have excuses to check-out from reality, procrastinate important life steps, or prolong childish behavior. It's no wonder women are noticing a painful shortage of mature, eligible men, the existing incentive structure has made every force acting on men a downward one.

The solution, of course, is to start filling the vacuum with something better. Rather than telling men their masculinity is toxic, we should help men understand the truth: that masculinity is a complex basket of natural and neutral characteristics and tendencies which can be used for good or for evil. We then teach them that 'healthy' or 'mature' masculinity is the careful channeling of these base elements towards honorable pursuits, such as education, talents, providing for a family, and serving God. As Richard Reeves put it, "It is one thing to point out that there are aspects of masculinity that in an immature or extreme expression can be deeply harmful, quite another to suggest that a naturally occurring trait in boys and men is intrinsically bad." This approach, rather than blaming young men for being men, seeks to educate men about who they are while encouraging them to be the best version of themselves.

An office for men at BYU would be an effective way to communicate this to the young men on campus, acting as a filter for negative messaging about masculinity while promoting the important virtues we need our young men to value and uphold. I don't know which methods would be best, but I can imagine a wide variety of ways to achieve this. There are many qualified guests who could be invited to speak on the classical virtues men should aspire to. Essay competitions could be organized, similar to existing ones focused on women, challenging students to write about the virtues

of inspiring men like Joseph Smith or Abraham Lincoln. Staff and alumni could be invited to share lectures on leadership principles, fatherhood, or Jesus Christ's attributes. In conjunction with the Veterans of Foreign Wars and other organizations, events could be held to honor men's contributions to history and introduce students to male leaders in the community. A men's office could even work in cooperation with Women's Resources and Services to foster more cooperative and harmonious dialogue on the many gender issues that exist today.

Ultimately, solving the problem of identity comes down to two things: first, adopting a view of masculinity that inspires men to "be yourself, but always your best self," as Karl G. Maeser said; and second, communicating that view of masculinity through authoritative sources to prevent young men from needing to look elsewhere. Using Women's Services and Resources to communicate to young men at BYU has not been an effective way to do this, which is why creating a companion office to it, and allowing both offices to be specialized, is important to help our male students answer the question of who they are. Armed with that knowledge, they will be more prepared as they "go forth to serve."

Conclusion

While sharing early drafts of this essay with friends, peers, and professors, I knew I was heading in a good direction when many of them expressed positive feedback and excitement. What I didn't anticipate was the number of women who said something like, "I didn't realize how much I cared about this." If I have one takeaway from this experience, it's that these issues are affecting everyone, often more than they realize. While there may be some who believe men's issues aren't pressing or are justified by past injustices, most women sincerely want men to be successful and happy, and they recognize how the decline in young men threatens their own well-being. Contention only seems to occur when helping men is seen as incompatible with helping women. Hopefully I've helped dispel that myth.

Another thing I heard repeatedly when talking about this pa-

per was, “I know exactly what you’re talking about; here’s what happened to me,” followed by anecdotes supporting the statistics, research, and conclusions I’ve discussed. This makes clear that these issues aren’t simmering under the surface anymore, they are manifesting in people’s lives in real ways. These accounts have largely come from BYU alumni, staff, and students, demonstrating just how relevant the broader conversation is, even here in our little church bubble. My experiences, those of my friends, and those of my quorum are not unique, men are having a rough time. As you read this quote from Jonathan Haidt, author of *The Anxious Generation*, think of the boys or men in your life, perhaps a friend, roommate, cousin, nephew, son, grandson, or neighbor. “Boys are in trouble. Many have withdrawn from the real world, where they could develop the skills needed to become competent, successful, and loving men. Instead, many have been lured into an ever more appealing virtual world in which desires for adventure and for sex can be satisfied, at least superficially, without doing anything that would prepare them for later success in work, love, and marriage.”

In my mind, I picture a lonely young freshman who grew up without good male role-models and doesn’t know how to fit in, so he turns to videogames and TV to numb the pain of being disconnected, wasting his potential on meaningless endeavors. Or I think of a returned missionary who finds himself unsuccessful in dating because he’s prideful and immature, so to cope he relapses into a pornography habit which dampens his testimony and destroys his self-worth. Or I consider a brother in a YSA ward who’s about to age out and feels like a failure to his family and his church because he’s still single. So, thinking himself unworthy of love and success, he purposefully holds himself back from achieving things elsewhere in life. These individuals are real people, and there are thousands like them within reach.

We have an opportunity to do something of life-changing proportions, but we can’t do so meaningfully without being backed by our institutions, which is why BYU, built on a legacy of leadership and service, is desperately needed. On behalf of the young, suffering men, I ask that we see this as a chance to fulfill the purpose for

which our university has been so carefully crafted by living prophets. And while I acknowledge that BYU is unable to solve every problem, I believe it is perfectly capable of making a big difference. By creating an official resource on campus to address men's issues, lives will be changed, courses will be rerouted, divisions will be healed, the culture will be strengthened, and our struggling, tempest-tossed young men will finally see the flickering light of hope across the waves.



The Hollowness of ‘Free Choice’: Why Modern Womanhood Needs Tradition

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What does it mean to be a woman? This question is hardly worth asking among young people, especially young women, because the answer is obvious: a woman is whatever she wants to be; let her decide. To ask the question is to suggest some possible alternative. By suppressing the question, the dominant narrative suppresses that alternative. This paper aims to reanimate deliberation about what it means to be a woman and to consider which party to this deliberation deserves more support in America today. I find there are three main answers to the woman question and trace the effects of these answers on the individual, society, and the

culmination of the two, love.

Conceptions of Womanhood: Justification and Current Status

The three main views of womanhood are traditional, radical, and neutral. The traditional view says the sexes are different at a deep level beyond the physical. Men and women have different natural capacities and tendencies that complement each other and make each other better together. Women, designed to be the primary caretakers of the children and home, are irreplaceable in their special, esteemed role. The radical view says women must reject the stereotypical division of labor that confines women to the home. Traditional marriage and family get in the way of women's ability to define themselves and their purposes. Rather, women will find true freedom, meaning, and love through their pursuit of personal projects. The neutral view tries to hold both the traditional and radical options open by saying women should be respected no matter which choice they make. Whether a woman chooses to dedicate herself to the raising of her children or an intellectually enriching career, both women should be celebrated as long as they choose their life paths freely.

I discovered these categories through my observation of the kinds of reactions pro-tradition content on social media provokes. For example, a woman may post a video of herself saying she is glad she gave up her career to be a wife and mother. Responses to something like this tend to fall into one of the three proposed categories. Traditionalists react with a feeling of validation in a modern world that they feel is leaving them behind. Radicals see this post as an unfortunate lack of consciousness about what it means to be a liberated woman and condemn her for shaming career women. Those who do not lean very hard one way or the other, those who are neutral, chastise the radicals for not respecting the woman's choice to live a traditional lifestyle. They say feminism is about respecting a woman's choice, whether that choice is to be a wife and mother or to be an independent career woman. Each type of response reveals unique assumptions about what real womanhood is all about.

It is difficult to pinpoint the precise level of support each of these perspectives enjoys in America today, but we can make some sketchy observations. Many women and men seem to fall into the neutral category that empowers women to do whatever they see fit. The *Pew Research Center* finds that 78% of US adults supported the ERA in 2020. The ERA aims to eliminate distinctions based on sex. This could be used as a rough proxy for support for the neutral conception because eliminating sex distinctions frees women up to choose what is best for them, free from the interference of gendered laws and cultural expectations.

As the neutral conception has become mainstream, the radical conception has gained popularity. Though women do not feel nearly as much pressure to conform to conventional gender roles as before, most believe the goals of feminism have not been accomplished yet. Perhaps a lack of pressure to conform is not enough. Pressure to go against the grain of conventionality may be required of a truly just society. We see potential evidence for this mindset when we look at data about views of women's opportunities today. A majority of adults (57%) agree with the statement that the country has not gone far enough "when it comes to giving women equal rights with men," according to *Pew*. Even though there has never been a better time to be a woman, *Gallup* researchers find that women report more discrimination now than they did a generation ago. This suggests that it is not enough to be neutral about gender roles. Society must actively discourage them.

Despite these growing trends, the traditional view still exerts a lot of influence today. When *Pew* asked if different family arrangements are acceptable (e.g. husband and wife with no kids, unmarried homosexual couple raising kids, etc.), the husband and wife raising children option enjoyed the most approval, with 90% calling it "completely acceptable." It takes more radicality than most Americans are prepared to embrace to say the traditional family structure is unacceptable.

In sum, most Americans try not to take sides in whether a woman should primarily concern herself with her family or her individual projects. Her femaleness or the freeness of her choices should be

celebrated largely without regard for the substance of her choices.

Philosophical Foundations

Each of these perspectives has unique philosophical underpinnings. In summarizing these perspectives, I will choose a main author and present some of their arguments. I will have to ignore much of the variety within each category and only communicate the main thrusts of each perspective.

The Traditional View

I propose Alexis de Tocqueville as a representative of the traditional view. In his second volume of *Democracy in America*, Tocqueville describes the status of American women in the 1830s. Though America is founded upon radical ideas of equality, the family in practice preserves much of the hierarchical structure inherited from the Old World. America is singular in counterbalancing theoretically radical ideals with pre-liberal practices. America's democratic politics permeate even the inner lives of the citizenry's families: "A species of equality prevails around the domestic hearth." Most obviously, children become more equal to their siblings and parents. The husband-wife relationship is also liberalized but maintains strict gender roles.

This democratization of the family is most obvious in a woman's life in her youth. Girls are raised much like their brothers. Unlike the cloistered education of girls of the Old World, "the great scene of the world is constantly open to her view." Her self-reliance is encouraged so that she can arm herself with reason against incursions on her virtue. Thanks to the equality of conditions, men and women marry for love rather than for status or material security. When marriages are arranged by others or based on economic interests, the union of husband and wife is tenuous and frequently violated. American girls' season of independence and the equality of conditions make them well prepared to enter marriage with a fuller understanding. In evaluating this democratization, Tocqueville writes, "I know not, upon the whole, whether society loses by the change, but I am inclined to believe that man individually is a

gainer by it.” The individual gains because the radical ideals of democracy make more room for individual projects and identity, but society may lose because the proposition that an individual must sacrifice his freedom for a higher good beyond a social contract is put into question at the outset under democracy.

This individual gain seems to be mostly reserved for men, as he observes women willingly support their husbands’ pursuits. Almost overnight, the girl leaves behind her independence, and the married woman enters the strict confines of domesticity. “It may be said that she has learned by the use of her independence to surrender it without a struggle and without a murmur when the time comes for making the sacrifice.” Though pressure from society may reinforce the decision to marry, women marry voluntarily, and the most virtuous do so with pride. Tocqueville reasoned that marriage requires more sacrifice of pleasure to duty for women because of “religious opinions” and “trading habits.” A combination of God and the law of comparative advantage backs up beliefs that women are designed for the sacred work that is done in the home. It is not only right but also more efficient for men and women to fulfill the roles for which they are naturally suited.

As the makers of morals, women inoculate families against the leveling effects of democracy. Wives encourage their husbands to broaden their interests beyond a single-minded focus on money-making, a powerful temptation in liberal democracy. This mindset of “the most virtuous women” in America at the time acts as a crucial bulwark against the lure of materialism that undermines political liberty. Mothers also defend against democratic tyranny by teaching their children the art of republican liberty. The passion for equality suppresses deliberation about what is good and right. Mothers raise their children to rule themselves and devote themselves to things higher than pure, abstract equality and bodily comfort. Thus, mothers act as anchors among democratic currents that threaten to sweep the people away from any shared, meaningful way of life. This requires a high devotion from women. The cost is best exemplified by the women Tocqueville observed on the frontier who gave up the comforts of their city life. They are at

once worn out and resolute, yet they do not regret giving their all to their family. One may wonder if this asks too much of women, however.

We need not exaggerate the differences between men and women or the discontinuity between life as a single woman and life as a married woman. Men and women are both expected to live virtuously and exercise their intellect, for women have “the hearts and minds of men.” A woman may change her habits once she gets married, but she still maintains her same essential character. Men and women ought to live the same virtues, but the very same virtues are expressed differently according to one’s sex. Though men and women ought to be equally esteemed in their roles, they should not try to collapse sexual differences. If women “[trample] on their holiest of duties” for outward pursuits better suited to men, it will undermine the basis of American greatness.

The Radical View

The radical view, or feminism, rose as an alternative to the traditional view. Though feminists frequently disagree on the implications of a rejection of the traditional view, they share in common a critique of the sexual division of labor that says women should primarily devote themselves to family and home. Traditional gender roles crush the individual, especially women, under their weight. Though resistance to the traditional view was not new, historians credit the Seneca Falls Convention of 1848 for the beginnings of an organized women’s movement in America. This “first wave” of feminism focused on political and civil equality and subsided once the right to vote in 1920 was secured. Betty Friedan reignited feminism in a second wave with her publication of *The Feminine Mystique* in 1963. Beyond political equality, second-wave feminists focused on social and economic equality. A conservative resurgence in the 1980s separated the second and third waves. In the 1990s, third-wave feminists continued to fight for more female representation in positions of power but made a point of being more inclusive. Kimberle Crenshaw made a splash during this wave with her theory of intersectionality that spotlights how identifying with

multiple marginalized categories (e.g., female, black, hispanic, homosexual) compounds the oppression one faces. Some contend whether the present-day fourth wave exists or is just a continuation of the third wave. Present-day feminism continues to emphasize inclusivity, but it has been influenced by the #MeToo movement, which seeks to hold powerful men accountable for sexual misconduct.

Simone de Beauvoir represents the radical view well because of her massive influence and fundamental agreement with the ideas undergirding multiple waves of feminism. *The Second Sex*, among other writings, propelled Beauvoir to the status of a feminist icon. Beauvoir inspired Betty Friedan's founding text for the second wave and remains a cornerstone of feminist thought today. Simone de Beauvoir was born in 1908 to a French bourgeois family. As a teenager, she became disillusioned with bourgeois values and set out to make an independent living through teaching philosophy and writing. She became acquainted with her lifelong romantic and intellectual partner, John Paul Sartre, while studying philosophy in Paris.

Many of her assumptions come from Sartre's existentialism. Sartre coined the term "existence before essence," meaning that individuals define their own meaning and purpose. Freedom has no predetermined end. We see Beauvoir echo Sartre's existentialism in the introduction of her seminal book *The Second Sex*:

Every subject posits itself as a transcendence concretely, through projects; it accomplishes its freedom only by perpetual surpassing toward other freedoms; there is no other justification for present existence than its expansion toward an indefinitely open future. Every time transcendence lapses into immanence, there is degradation of existence into "in-itself," of freedom into facticity; this fall is a moral fault if the subject consents to it; if this fall is inflicted on the subject, it takes the form of frustration and oppression; in both cases it is an absolute evil.

The introduction to *The Second Sex* outlines how dominant

conceptions of womanhood have dehumanized women. The traditionalists say, "Femininity is in jeopardy." They urge, "Be women, stay women, become women." According to Beauvoir, traditionalists' very insecurity about women points towards the truth that the traditional conception of womanhood is a social construction vulnerable to alteration. If people born female have to be told to be women, perhaps they would become something other than women if they were told to be themselves. Men telling women to be women exemplifies man as Subject, positing himself as the One and woman as the Other. Men want women to wallow in alterity because their submission allows men to more freely pursue their personal projects. Beauvoir writes, "humanity is male, and man defines woman, not in herself, but in relation to himself; she is not considered an autonomous being." Man is essential. Woman is inessential.

Men justify women's necessary dependence on and devotion to men by pointing to the current state of affairs without acknowledging that men created the state of affairs. The same argument is used to justify racism towards blacks: "The white American relegates the black to the rank of shoe-shine boy, and then concludes that blacks are only good for shining shoes." The fact that so few women occupy positions of power is not proof that women belong elsewhere but is proof of the effectiveness of man's subjugation of woman. To escape subjugation requires positing "oneself as unique and absolute Subject." Positing oneself as Subject requires more of women than men for several reasons: "because she lacks the concrete means, because she senses the necessary link connecting her to man without posting its reciprocity, and because she often derives satisfaction from her role as *Other*."

In liberating women, Beauvoir cannot be neutral towards the choice to be a traditionalist. Once we move beyond her introductory philosophy of womanhood, we see what Beauvoir sees as the logical implications of such a view of womanhood. Of marriage, she writes later in *The Second Sex*, "it mutilates [the woman]; it dooms her to repetition and routine." Of motherhood, she says in a 1975 interview with Betty Friedan, "No woman should be

authorized to stay at home and raise her children. Society should be totally different. Women should not have that choice, precisely because if there is such a choice, too many women will make that one." Being a woman is not balancing work and family, for this "constant tension" holds her back according to *The Second Sex*. Rather, being a truly human woman means fleeing her biological role in reproduction and entering the workforce.

The Neutral View

The neutral view of womanhood is that of the moderate feminist. It says that societal pressures, cultural expectations, and the law should not play any part in how a woman decides to live her life. What matters is a woman's ability to freely choose, just as men are already free to choose. Another way of understanding the neutral view is articulated by political philosopher Harvey Mansfield in his book *Manliness*: "A radical feminist attacks the family; a moderate one accepts (though probably doesn't defend it)." In my introductory example of the different views of womanhood, the moderate feminist defends the woman's *choice* to stay at home, not the institution of the traditional family itself.

Susan Moller Okin argues in favor of a gender-neutral society in *Justice, Gender, and the Family*. A Stanford professor of Ethics from 1990 to 2004, Okin saw prevailing theories of justice, even liberal ones, as inadequate in their treatment of women. Liberal theorists made the mistake of taking the traditional family for granted, thereby implying that the gendered family was just. Okin argues in *Justice, Gender, and the Family* that such theorists assume the traditional family when they begin with a state of nature composed of "mature, independent human beings... without any mention of how they got that way." They would have no subjects to talk about if it were not for women who rear and raise children. Yet, women and family structures fall outside of the purview of whatever standard of justice is arrived at.

Women can only be made equal to men socially if the same principles of justice and fairness that apply to the state apply to the family as well. Since a sense of justice that recognizes the equality

of all is fundamental to a just society, children need to be raised in just, gender-neutral families. There must be congruence between the justice of our public institutions and the justice of private life in the family. Children will best learn the fundamental equality of the sexes if their parents equally share rather than divide productive and reproductive labor. Even a society that affords women the same opportunities as men in theory will not afford them in practice if children continue to be nurtured by mothers who depend on the male head of household. Children raised in such families will be conditioned to “choose” traditional roles that reinforce patriarchy and make women vulnerable.

A just family will cultivate real choice. Parents avoid the risk of biasing their children’s life choices if parents show an equal devotion to parenthood and work outside the home. That way, girls who want to be homemakers and caretakers will have chosen it because they want to, not because that is what they mistakenly learned they are supposed to do. Okin writes, “The structure and practices of families must give women the same opportunities as men to develop their capacities, to participate in political power and influence social choices, and to be economically secure.” Equal proportions of women and men in positions of power outside of the home would be an indicator that the family is just.

In many passages, Okin represents the neutral position well by respecting a woman’s choice to live a more traditional lifestyle. She seems neutral about the content of women’s choices as long as they are freely chosen. We see evidence of this view when she proposes legislation to protect stay-at-home mothers. To overcome the economic dependence brought on by the traditional division of labor, Okin recommends that employers equally divide wage checks “between the earner and the partner who provides all or most of his or her unpaid domestic services.” That way, the equal respect to which women are entitled will be reflected economically even if she does not participate in the workforce.

Okin sees herself between substantive and procedural liberalism. Okin, at times, limits herself to setting the rules of the game with room for players to make their own substantive choices. She

writes that we must “design institutions and practices acceptable to those with more traditional beliefs” despite her substantive vision of the ideal society being quite different from and, at times, opposed to a more traditional vision. Okin’s egalitarian society would somehow allow individuals to maintain traditional gender norms within their families alongside the hope that these individual choices become less and less common.

Criteria For A Good Conception

In deciding which conception of womanhood needs more support today on a societal level, we should consider it a matter of equilibrium. A healthy equilibrium would properly balance the good of the individual and the good of the community and, thus, uphold a view of love conducive to human flourishing. The conception of womanhood that best contributes to this equilibrium should be the most influential. In evaluating the three views of womanhood, the criteria will be: (1) it makes room for individual fulfillment, (2) it is beneficial for society, and (3) it honors a truly human love. If the conception that meets these criteria best is not the most influential one, then it needs more cultural and institutional support. As discussed in an earlier section, the most influential conception seems to be the neutral one.

Why Neutrality Is Not A Viable Option

Okin helps us understand how the neutral view is vulnerable to slippage towards the radical view. We can narrow down our options to traditionalism or radicalism by noticing this tendency. To be neutral means to decline making a choice. This becomes an unstable position when the options are mutually exclusive. Either there is something enduring and good about traditional gender roles, or there is not. At first, Okin and Beauvoir both seem to leave these options unchosen, but further investigation reveals an inherent resistance to traditionalism.

Okin appears accepting of the traditional family when she says there are “irreducible biological differences between the sexes.” Not only are these differences ingrained in the physical constitution of

the human female and male, but these differences are also “socially relevant.” Being born a woman appears to provide some guidance for life plans for Okin. Simone de Beauvoir starts in a similarly open place when she admits the physical differences between men and women. Women should be free to have children; they should just have control over their reproductive process and make the endeavor entirely voluntary. “The relation of parents to children, like that of spouses, must be freely chosen,” Beauvoir writes in *The Second Sex*. Women are free to choose a more traditional lifestyle as long as it is freely chosen. What it means to “freely choose” will determine whether traditionalism is a legitimate choice.

It does not take long for these authors to show their cards and reveal that true freedom is biased against if not exclusionary towards certain options. Despite attempts to temper the presentation of her ideology and get some traction with a more moderate audience, Okin ends up in much the same place as Beauvoir. Far from respecting the choice to live a traditional lifestyle, Okin hopes this choice shrinks in probability into oblivion someday. She writes, “marriage and family, as currently practiced in our society, are unjust institutions” because they render women asymmetrically vulnerable. Okin attempts to signal her tolerance, writing, “public policies must respect people’s views and choices.” But, there are limits to this respect. Differing viewpoints can only be tolerated “insofar as it can be assured that these choices do not result, as they do now, in the vulnerability of women.” These choices that render women vulnerable are “marriage and family, as currently practiced in our society.” She, in effect, places traditional marriage and family outside the limits of tolerance. It is at this point that it becomes difficult to distinguish between Okin and Beauvoir when Beauvoir says that, in an ideal society, women should not have the choice to stay home and raise their children.

Okin begins by saying women possess some socially relevant biological differences and ends by saying men and women must share equally the responsibilities associated with home and family and must achieve at the highest level of public affairs in roughly the same numbers. Beauvoir begins by saying human freedom has no

predetermined end and ends by saying human freedom precludes traditional marriage and family. If these are not contradictions, they are at least unstable tensions that are inadequately addressed. Perhaps, there is a truly neutral position available to us that Okin fails to represent. In the end, though, any position that treats everything as a matter of choice will, like Okin and Beauvoir, fail to honor the traditional family. Neutrality has a valence, and it is not favorable towards traditionalism.

The neutral conception appears to be the most tolerant and pluralistic of the three. The idea that all options are equally valid seems even-handed on its face. Neutrality is another way of saying free choice is a chief value in itself. If there is any conception of womanhood we should promote it seems difficult to oppose this one because it is based upon the only premises Americans seem to agree upon: equality and the ability to construct your own pursuit of happiness.

Though claiming to be neutral, a naked, subjective conception of freedom is the very same freedom that the radical view is based upon. The neutral conception is a repackaging of the radical conception that conceals from itself its inherent radicality. If the end of freedom is purely self-determined, then intrusions on this freedom, such as gender norms, must be rooted out. One can never be quite sure if a woman who lives a traditional life is truly free or if she has accepted a predetermined mold. Was she unconsciously coerced into this lifestyle? If free choice is all there is, she must have been coerced to have chosen to constrain her future opportunities in such a permanent, narrow way. Because traditional gender norms exert so much influence and we can never be sure if a traditional woman is truly free, it is not enough for the state and social norms to be neutral. The state and society need to counteract the influence of unjust power structures through active intervention. Though the purpose of such intervention seems neutral in that it can operate under the cover of freedom and equal opportunity for all, it is certainly not neutral towards the traditional family

Seeing that neutrality has an affinity for the radical conception of womanhood, we are left with two practical options: more tra-

ditionalism or more radicalism. Does the idea that gender roles are a harmful social construction need to be counterbalanced or emphasized?

Less Radicalism

The way forward now is not more radicalism because it is already beginning to cause more harm than benefits. But, that is not to say that there have been no benefits. The radical view of womanhood has done a lot of real good by putting faith and tradition at the tribunal of reason and lived experience. The radical view puts personal projects, self-improvement, and individual identity above all else. This speaks to women who need to put themselves first at times, such as in the case of abuse. Not all just reasons for divorce are provable before the law. Such an emphasis on the individual makes more space for appreciating women who cannot or do not want to have children. For these reasons, the radical view does well in explicitly addressing the first criterion of a good conception, individual women's fulfillment. However, it is so direct in aiming for this goal that it misses the big picture: individual fulfillment is tied up in our relationships with others. It could be said that the feminist quest for fulfillment is, as Leo Strauss says, a "joyless quest for joy."

All the criteria are intertwined, so failing to account for any will degrade the others. The radical conception is wholly addressed to the first criterion but fails to meet the second and third criteria, being beneficial for society and honoring a truly human love. The radical view is purely individualistic and corrosive of social bonds. It says the continual pursuit of personal projects defines the purpose of life. The content of these projects is left blank because the essential part of human meaning is the self-directedness of personal projects. The common good or a natural good above society has no legitimate claim on the individual. Not even the claim children have on their parents to take care of them can be said to originate in nature. It is all a matter of consent. There are no natural bonds to others because bonds are just that—bonds that restrict the free exercise of freedom. This view promotes atomization, and this im-

pairs society, love, and individual fulfillment.

Loneliness stands out as a major crisis for the rising generation. Individuals are unfulfilled, and social bonds are being forged less and less. “Forty-four percent (44%) of young adults reported a sense of not mattering to others and 34% reported loneliness,” according to a 2023 Harvard report. The view that humanity is a sea of atomized individuals does not create favorable conditions for mattering to each other. Small communities, beginning with the family, provide the environment for being known. More or less assigned roles help members know how to contribute and, therefore, feel proud of their contributions. The same report finds that “nearly 3 in 5 young adults (58%) reported that they lacked ‘meaning or purpose’ in their lives in the previous month, [and] half of young adults reported that their mental health was negatively influenced by ‘not knowing what to do with my life.’” Young people are being told that they are free to do whatever they want with their lives. Because men and women have no natural ends, individuals are free to choose how to maximize their utility in whatever way they see fit without infringing on others’ pursuits. Parents and mentors have to be neutral because to provide direction would be to narrow what should be an unlimited view of future pursuits. Young people are faced with so many options that they struggle to choose any of them. They are told to spin meaning out of their own lives by shutting out external forces as if human meaning were a wholly individual matter. The radical view cannot be said to provide any concrete, positive direction for making a meaningful life because it only says what it is against, traditionalism. Though the radical view of womanhood may not account for all of these effects, it certainly does not contribute to social cohesion.

Finally, the radical conception fails to foster a truly human love, which encompasses individual fulfillment and public harmony. It is in favor of free love. Free love is truer than the more traditional version, it is argued, because people come together out of pure love for each other, unadulterated by external pressures. Brandon Dabbling in *A New Birth of Marriage* summarizes, “Basing marriage on [free] love require[s] stripping marriage of coercive communal

elements that assume marital permanence.” Public concerns, or “coercive communal elements,” should not intrude on matters as private and spiritual as love. Further, assuming marital permanence gets in the way of pure love. Easy divorce allows people to escape marriages that rely on supports other than pure love or internal attraction, like material benefits, social acceptability, or legal barriers. These external supports of marriage permanence serve only to make marriage a deadening contract rather than a loving union based on continuous consent.

Tocqueville’s articulation of traditionalism answers concerns about traditional marriage being based on mere external pressures. He says conditions are equal enough for people to marry for love rather than for economic reasons. He is not in favor of forcing people to marry, though it is good to encourage it. The women he observes in America are not merely responding to social pressure. They freely choose to marry. In reality, the radical view hollows out marriage and love. In free love, the relationship between two (or more?) individuals is based on free choice. Since freedom is defined by its lack of definition by anything outside the subjective individual, to accept any reason for uniting originating outside of oneself would be to let coercive communal elements choose for you.

In answering the question, “Why do you love him?” if this love is to be radically free, the answer must boil down to one of two unsatisfying options: either rationalistic determinism or arbitrary self-assertion. Either she loves him for what he can do for her in satisfying her wants, or she loves him just because she can. The first case is of reason reduced to base self-interest. The second is a mere exercise in free will that is inaccessible to reason. Any move beyond these options having to do with shoulds and oughts, for example, would require accepting a moral framework that exists outside of individual human construction. It would require freedom having some guidance in nature.

Free love is based on continuous consent rather than enduring consent. Any party to a free love relationship may say they love their partner today, but they don’t know about tomorrow because consent can be withdrawn at any time for any reason. Because part-

ners can leave whenever they want, participants must withhold a part of themselves just in case they are abandoned. This leads to a flimsy, ephemeral love devoid of the vulnerability that makes it meaningful. It is radically free in that nothing is preventing relationships from dissipating as soon as love gets in the way of the individual and her subjectively defined interests.

More Traditionalism

Even within a utilitarian framework, society should honor the traditional view if only for its beneficial effects (criterion two). Free love undermines marital unity and stability. Children do best when raised with parents who love each other and stay together, a condition more likely to be achieved under traditionalism. Growing up under different circumstances leads to “increased risks in every developmental area—poverty, involvement in crime, failing in school, challenges to physical health, psychological distress, exposure to aggravated parenting, and abuse,” according to family scholar Jenet Erickson. Further, countries face the challenges of population collapse due to low birth rates as people focus on career advancement over marriage and family. *CNN* reported Japan’s plan to scale down to a four-day work week to give young career people the time and energy to focus on family and boost fertility.

Beyond beneficial effects, there is a deeper philosophical case for traditionalism. It honors a truly human love, which in turn provides individual fulfillment. Brandon Dabbling in *A New Birth of Marriage* calls the kind of love associated with traditionalism “courageous love.” In courageous love, marriage involves more than the individuals and their self-interest. It includes, implicitly, duties to the common good of the couple as a family unit, to the public’s common good, and in many cases to God. Instead of separating whenever interests no longer overlap, courageous love asks each participant to think of the good of the whole. This regard for others does not eclipse the individual’s duty to meet her own needs, including the need to separate at times, but it does ask the individual to integrate others into an enlarged sphere of concern that now includes the couple. This most fundamental extension of the

self to the other in marriage engenders a broader extension to the community.

Suffering hardship and a limitation of choices for a higher good has everything to do with individual fulfillment, contrary to the feminist narrative. This greater good is not an abstract concept like liberation but is concretized in families and communities. Unlike free love, courageous love cannot be reduced to determinism or voluntarism. It is more than a mere calculation of benefits and higher than blind fideism. It is more than a checklist or warm feelings. It is more than accepting a predetermined script or pure self-creation. Courageous love lies at the intersection of reason and faith, mind and soul, obedience and initiative. It is called courageous because the giving of oneself to another entails risk. It maintains its fundamental connection to a capacious understanding of reason because it must make a public account of itself. It's not just beautiful but beneficial because of how it answers to the practical needs of society. Fulfillment is an implicit aim or a happy side effect of contributing to the good of the whole. The radical feminist narrative says personal growth is an individual matter. Courageous love says personal growth is best achieved when it's for someone else.

Traditionalism provides the meaning and stability that the radical view lacks—and that our current political climate desperately needs. Radical feminism contains a truth. Freedom requires individual initiative, but this truth is available within the traditional framework. Rather than being the whole truth, self-creation is both humbled and elevated by its service to something higher: love and unity. Courageous love is not about assigning tasks to one or another sex. Rather, it is about the sacrifice, risk, and vulnerability that come with anything worth doing. The risk of building a life with someone only makes sense within a framework where meaning as a human being includes self-sacrifice and other people. What does it mean to be a woman? I contend that it is more than self-creation.

Conclusion: The Shape Of A Solution

In supporting a more traditional view of womanhood, I am not

advocating for a strict enforcement of gender norms. Rather, I am arguing for a balance in beliefs about womanhood that truly makes room for traditionalism. Eradication of all other views is not necessary. Rather, the traditional family should be honored, not merely tolerated. The traditional family should not be a lofty aspiration but a practically attainable goal made more attainable and attractive by societal conditions. By doing so, the influence of women and their unique gifts will be more deeply felt through their special roles as wives and mothers.



Reclaiming the Family: The Quiet Collapse We Can't Ignore

REAGAN SUMRALL

Reagan is a sophomore at Brigham Young University and recently returned from her mission in North Carolina. Defense of the family is something that she has always been passionate about, and she is excited to keep learning more!

When a child is born, they enter the world as an empty canvas—pure, innocent, and untouched by life's complexities. With no memories, knowledge, or experience to guide them, a newborn's soul and emerging personality are divine and pure. The early months and years of a child's life are crucial to their development and perception of the world, and the most secure place for that child to be reared is within the sacred order of marriage. In an ideal situation, it is the family unit that provides the first influences, guiding the child through the early years and nurturing their

inherent traits. In this environment, love, values, and connection become the building blocks for the child's sense of self and their relationship with the world around them.

"The Family: A Proclamation to the World" declares that "marriage between a man and a woman is ordained of God and that the family is central to the Creator's plan for the eternal destiny of His children." Beyond the promise of eternal happiness for families who follow this counsel, studies such as Sarah Langton's 2011 study "Family Structure and Adolescent Physical Health, Behavior, and Emotional Well-Being" consistently show that children raised in two-parent households with a mother and a father are more likely to thrive emotionally, socially, and academically. With this solid foundation, resilience is built, confidence takes root, and emotional intelligence blooms, preparing the child to face life's challenges. Here, we first grasp what it means to love and be loved unconditionally. In families, we learn how to serve others and develop communication skills. A secure family unit is the safest space to make mistakes and learn how to persevere through hardship. Countless life skills are taught within the home, offering a safe space to stumble and grow, preparing us for a world that seldom shows such grace. It is clear that protecting and nurturing the family is not just a matter of individual well-being—it is essential for the flourishing of society as a whole.

It is important to recognize that the word "family" is not limited to the traditional mom, dad, and children setup, commonly known as the "nuclear family." Everyone is part of a family in some way, but what that family looks like is different for each person. Some people marry and stay near their parents and extended family their whole lives, while others leave their hometowns to lay down their own roots and find a family within their community. Some marry right out of high school, and others never have the opportunity to marry. Some parents end up raising their children alone, while other couples celebrate 50-year wedding anniversaries. The divine pattern that "The Family: A Proclamation to the World" lays out consists of a man and woman raising children "within the bonds of matrimony" but clarifies that "disability, death, or other circum-

stances may necessitate individual adaptation,” ensuring the world that this message does not exclude those with righteous desires who find themselves outside of this pattern. There are as many family situations as there are people in this world, and regardless of an individual’s family situation, all can benefit from a society that places value on marriage between a man and a woman who have the desire to raise children and positively contribute to society. A 2021 study by Daniel A. Cox with the Institute for Family Studies found that “marriage is positively associated with greater community involvement across a range of different activities.” When family is at the heart of a society, marriage becomes both more common and more highly valued, which in turn encourages greater participation in community life. This rise in community involvement helps create a more inclusive and welcoming environment, even for those who are unmarried or distanced from their families.

Families are special not only because they are ordained of God and central to His plan, but also because the benefits that strong family units offer society are endless. Families provide an ideal caregiving network. As older generations require care, they can turn to their children and grandchildren as their primary caregivers. When babies are born, parents can turn to aunts, uncles, grandparents, and other family members to help care for the children while they are at work or otherwise unable to be with their children at all times. Worldwide, the fertility rate is decreasing, so much so that a 2021 study from *The Lancet* has predicted that by 2050, 75% of countries will not have a birth rate high enough to maintain population sizes. There are many reasons for the fertility rate decrease. People are getting married later, causing them to have fewer children. Others refrain from getting married and having children altogether. The use of various methods of birth control is increasing. A 2020 NCHS study found that from “2017–2019, 65.3% of women aged 15–49 in the United States were currently using contraception.” Additionally, environmental factors have caused human infertility to increase, with recent studies showing that in 2022, “approximately one in six people have experienced infertility at some stage in their lives.”

The decreasing birth rate will have extreme consequences on the global population. The aging population will not have enough people to care for them. Overall, there will not be enough people in the workforce to keep society and the economy functioning to support all members of society, especially the older generations, who will no longer be capable of contributing to the workforce themselves.

Another factor that is contributing to the decreased birth rate is that many people are scared to raise kids in this increasingly tempestuous and contentious world, so they avoid having children. While it is true that darkness in the world is increasing, latter-day prophets have encouraged us to have hope and continue following Heavenly Father's plan during the last days. In his October 2008 Ensign article, Elder Richard J. Maynes acknowledges that it is getting harder to confidently raise a family as time goes on but assures the readers that all of these challenges can be combated by following the counsel of ancient and modern-day prophets and teaching the Gospel in the home. He promises that "the basic gospel principles that we strive to live each day will ultimately save our children and help establish Zion in our homes." Having children is part of Heavenly Father's plan, even in tumultuous times. It is a decision to be made between a married couple and the Lord, and it comes with many promised blessings. God has promised that as His children keep His commandments, including His instruction to Adam and Eve in the book of Genesis to "multiply and replenish the earth" by having children, and strive to live the Gospel, everything will be okay, despite difficult times and threatening outside influences.

In fact, one of the best ways to combat many of the problems that society is facing during times of cultural, political, and economic change is to get married and have children. The act of participating in and growing a family continues to build a social and economic safety net for all members of the family. For members of the church, these relationships help protect the sanctity of the family and ensure that children are being reared in a way that starts them on Heavenly Father's path to salvation.

Unfortunately, as Western society's values are increasingly shifting further and further from the family centered society that has been characteristic of the Western world since its inception, people inside and outside of the Church are prioritizing family participation and expansion less and less. This change not only threatens the family unit but also undermines the cohesion and productivity of society as a whole.

There are more than just a few factors that are causing this societal shift—it is a perfect storm of changing cultural norms, technological advancements, and eroding traditional values. Many, if not all, of the biggest social and political issues of the day can be seen as a direct attack on the family. Since the family is essential to God's plan of happiness, Satan needs to destroy it if he wants to succeed. That is why the opposition towards and the pressure against the family unit within society continues to grow. If we are going to stand in defense of the sacred family unit, we need to be aware of the opposition we face. Only then can we take action and work to lift the family higher than ever, creating an enriching, peaceful, and happy society. As family holds less value in the eyes of many in the modern world, threats caused by technology, changing societal priorities, and the growing popularity of gender ideology are becoming increasingly prevalent in all aspects of society. The only way to protect the family is to take action and stand for important family values and against the dangers threatening mothers, fathers, and children in the modern world.

Familial relationships, like all relationships, are built on experiences and connections. Without connection, a family is just a group of people who live in the same place. With connection, a family is where you first learn how to nurture relationships, seek out personal connection, and understand what it feels like to belong. Human connection is essential to human health. Julianne Holt-Lunstad's study "Social Relationships and Mortality Risk: A Meta-analytic Review" proved that people who have strong relationships with others live longer and are healthier both physically and mentally. Those connections start within the family, but there are many forces threatening to take that connection away.

An example of a day in the life of an American household starts with alarms going off. The adults have work, and the kids have school or daycare. They spend the morning running around each other, gathering up clothes, shoes, and supplies. Kids are rushed out the door to school, and somehow, every morning, they leave the house late. If anyone is eating breakfast, they eat it hurriedly or scarf it down on the way to work or school. They go their separate ways, attending meetings or classes and participating in sports or other activities. Eventually, everyone makes their way back to the house to eat dinner. Some families eat dinner together, others eat when it's convenient for them individually. They watch shows, scroll on their devices, and generally isolate themselves from each other. When bedtime approaches, they get ready for bed and go to sleep until the alarms start to beep again the next morning.

This template is not abnormal in an American household and it is hurting the ability that we have to make connections with each other. People, and families especially, need to spend time with each other. They need to hear from each other and develop trusting relationships. That is hard to do when they spend the day apart, and then in the precious moments they are in the same place, they isolate themselves using technology and other unimportant tasks.

The reality is that most families have to spend the day apart. Many families have both parents working in order to meet their financial needs. In some situations, one of the parents stays home and spends the day with the children, and when that is the case, Judith R. Schore's study "Modern Attachment Theory: The Central Role of Affect Regulation in Development and Treatment" found that the children's social and emotional development far surpasses that of children who spend the day with a paid caretaker.

While having a parent stay home with a child would be ideal for many reasons, including to help with a child's ability to understand and develop strong interpersonal connections, that is not always possible, and it is not the only solution. If a family actively decides to spend more quality time with each other during the times that they are together, those relationships will improve, and family life will be better. Families and couples can improve their bond by

going on walks together, playing games together every once in a while, prioritizing family mealtimes, and so much more. Families do not need to quit their jobs and leave school to travel the country if they want to have a strong relationship, they just need to identify when they are able to spend time together, then find a way to make the most of it. I have fond memories of watching movies together with my siblings and parents, or making pizza together for dinner on Friday nights. Simple moments like these bring families together, making them stronger and more trial-resistant.

Screen time for both adults and children is eliminating frequent face-to-face interactions with those around us, including our families, but it doesn't have to be that way. Technology is useful and has its place, but it should not be taking the place of important quality time that gives humans a sense of belonging and a place to be loved. When we are aware of the role that technology plays in our lives, we can start to make plans that ensure that we are not letting it encroach on the valuable time that we can be spending with our families.

A use of technology that has recently been gaining popularity is the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) as companionship. There are apps that can be downloaded for free that give users the opportunity to develop friendships and even romantic relationships with these AI robots, creating the illusion that they are creating connections and developing relationships. Even more recently, the tech company Realbotix showcased one of their newest creations: Aria, a robot with human-like features that was "designed specifically for companionship and intimacy." As technology continues to advance, people are going to be able to turn to technology rather than other humans to develop relationships and meet their social and romantic needs. When relationships with technology can take the place of real human interaction, society will suffer. Social skills will be lost, and emotional intelligence will decrease as people become accustomed to the shallow, programmed responses of artificial intelligence and lose the ability to understand complex human needs and emotions. This trend could lead to a lower desire to marry and have children, disintegrating the family unit and altering the moral

standards of society as a whole.

Another common trend, especially among the younger generations, is a focus on independence and self-development. Of course, these traits are important, but a lifestyle of hyper-independence is becoming increasingly desirable, causing people to prioritize careers and economic success over relationships and family life. This hyper-independence and a focus on worldly prosperity can lead to isolation, loneliness, and emotional detachment, whereas a focus on relationships and connection offers a life of joy and fulfillment. Many individuals prioritize career advancement and the accumulation of wealth, believing that these markers of success will lead to a more fulfilling life, but as people grow more absorbed in their professional lives, they may find themselves disconnected from their familial roots, missing out on nourishing meaningful bonds with family and friends and lacking support systems that are integral to happiness and well-being. The emphasis on individual success undermines and threatens the values of collaboration, empathy, and shared responsibility that are taught within the family. Instead of seeking fulfillment in connection with others, many turn inward, focusing on their own success, despite the fact that wealth and status can not substitute the emotional support that close family relationships can offer.

President Gordon B. Hinckley's book *Standing for Something* considers the measurements of success, stating, "Everyone wants to be successful. The question is: Successful at what?" If you were to imagine a successful life, what would that look like to you? For many people, that would mean an amazing career with a nice car and a big house and a picture-perfect family, but that is not the only way to measure success. President Hinckley continues his thought by saying, "Successful at earning money, successful in marriage, successful in our own sight and in the eyes of our friends? None of these aspirations is necessarily wrong. But greed is an insidious trap that has the power to destroy those whose eager search for success becomes the driving force of their lives." Those who fall victim to greed get stuck in a trap of always wanting more. Greed twists morals and destroys relationships. What would life look like if suc-

cess was measured by the quality of your relationships with each member of your family? What if every member of society worked to live, not just lived to work? What if a career and money were just means to an end, and not the end goal? Generosity within communities would increase. More people would have the goal to get married and start a family, and fewer relationships would fall victim to greed and end in heartbreak.

Another result of a culture that focuses on personal growth and independence rather than familial unity is an increasing number of single-parent households. One of the parents decides that their individual desires are more important than their family, so they leave. When a child is raised in a single-parent household, they are more likely to face economic instability and, therefore, miss out on opportunities to bond with their parents. They do not have healthy relationships modeled to them, so they lack those social and emotional skills, harming their lifelong skills. While single-parent families can still provide love and support, the absence of one parent often leads to an imbalance in the child's upbringing, which can have long-term effects on their emotional well-being and future relationships.

With divorce being viewed as an easy and immediate fix when married couples experience a challenge, one-parent households are a common sight. While that might be a convenient answer in the eyes of the world, Heavenly Father has higher expectations for His children. President Ezra Taft Benson once taught, "Almost any good man and any good woman can have happiness and a successful marriage if both are willing to pay the price." This is the standard that the Lord holds us to. Sometimes, divorce is necessary, especially when a husband or wife refuses to cooperate, but divorce should be the exception, not the rule. When a couple centers their lives on the teachings of Jesus Christ, they will be able to withstand the trials that come their way, and separation never needs to be considered.

Aside from the threats that technology and a self-centered lifestyle bring against the sacred family unit, there are a plethora of other forces working to dismantle and decentralize the family. One

of the major crises that the family unit is facing is the widespread acceptance of abortion as a form of healthcare. Many people in the United States are actively fighting for “women’s reproductive rights,” which really only means the ability to have an abortion. As a result of skillful marketing, the abortion industry has convinced a large group of people that a child in the womb does not have the same value as a person outside of the womb and, therefore, the mother has the right to abort or kill, that child in the womb. In some areas, such as the state of New York, there have been years where more black babies are aborted than born, according to data from the New York State Department of Health in 2022. The cultural perception that abortion is acceptable and even encouraged poses a major threat to the family. Millions of children are kept from the opportunity to grow up within a family and play a part in society because they never make it out of the womb. The cultural acceptance of abortion is contributing to the problematic decrease in birth rates that threatens the economic success of society.

The real threat against all reproductive rights is found within the growing popularity of transgenderism among all age groups. A study by Jean M. Twenge, published in the *Journal of Sexuality Research and Social Policy*, found that between 2014 and 2022, the percentage of 18 to 24-year-olds identifying as transgender increased by over 371%, while the proportion of 25 to 34-year-olds identifying as transgender quadrupled. Even more shocking is the statistics regarding children. A *Reuter’s* investigation by Robin Respaut and Chad Terhune found that the number of new diagnoses of gender dysphoria for children ages 6-17 in the US increased from 15,172 in 2017 to 42,167 in 2021, and those numbers continue growing every year. This is concerning for many reasons, one of which is that of those 42,000 children who are not even old enough to vote or legally drink alcohol, 1,390 of them were put on puberty blockers, 4,231 were receiving some type of hormone therapy, and 287 of them underwent mastectomies. All three of these treatments can lead to infertility and other health issues. This is devastating no matter the age of the person undergoing these therapies, but when children are subjected to these treatments before

they have reached the age of consent, it becomes a serious human rights issue. Before many of these children have even considered the fact that they might want to have their own kids one day, they are stripped of their ability to reproduce. If they are lucky enough that they do not lose that ability, the young girls who undergo a mastectomy lose the ability to feed their future children through breastfeeding.

The Family Proclamation states that “gender is an essential characteristic of individual premortal, mortal, and eternal identity and purpose.” There are distinct physical, social, and emotional differences between men and women, and those differences are divine. The world needs both men and women to contribute to society and work together to create families. As culture is shifting to the belief that gender can be changed and is, therefore, not a divine, eternal characteristic, the distinct traits of each gender may be lost in the eyes of society. This change harms the family unit, which thrives on the complementary nature of a mother and a father and their innate traits. Additionally, teaching gender theory and the concept of transgenderism to young children, which is something that happens in the U.S. and throughout the world, can impact a child’s worldview at a time when they are learning what their place in that world is. There have been instances of these concepts being taught in kindergarten and even cases of parents insisting that their 5-year-old thinks they were born in the wrong body. God created His children intentionally and lovingly, and as the prophets have taught, gender plays an essential role in who we are as His children.

These and other factors are leading not only to the cultural decrease in the value of the family but, as a result, we are facing the downfall of our civilized society. It is important to confront each threat individually, but even more important is to fortify the family unit as a whole so that no matter what challenges the family faces, they will be able to overcome the difficulty, remain strong, and grow even stronger. As these steps are taken, people will gain an increased sense of belonging and connection with all people they come into contact with, and as a result, society will grow and flourish more than it ever has.

Making the family central to society can start with small steps. It needs to start with individuals. People who are committed to creating better relationships with their family members and learning how to trust and communicate at home and in public. Young men and women need to decide that they want to get married and have children, and make that family their top priority throughout their lives. Brigham Young University can stand as an example for the rest of the world in this area because it is a cultural norm to marry young. Rather than frowning on students with young families, professors happily accommodate students who bring their babies to class, and child-friendly areas can be found across campus. Varying levels of accommodations for children can be found at institutes of higher education across the country, but they could always be better, even at BYU. When accommodations are provided for children in schools and places of work, married couples everywhere are likely to be more willing and excited to make the decision to have children.

From there, the influence of a family-centered movement starts to spread. As those families get involved in the community, people will be able to see and sense that joy and fulfillment, and without even knowing it, the family focused individuals will start to lead by example. This already happens in most communities, and the more intentional that these individuals become about sharing their example, the further that example will spread.

As community involvement increases, people who have benefited from putting their family at the center of their lives will get to know people who might not have the same opportunities to prioritize families. An experienced mother can counsel a young woman who is considering an abortion, encouraging her and discussing the other possibilities for both the woman and the child. A father can develop a trusting relationship with a child who is being raised by a single mom so that he can have a male role model in his life. Parents can share ideas of how they squeeze quality family time into their busy schedules and limit technology in their children's lives without becoming the enemy. Everyone can benefit from the experiences of each other, and the next generation will have a stronger

idea of how to create strong relationships both within families and in all aspects of life.

The relationships that we develop throughout our lives are important, and as those relationships remain strong while people are starting and growing their families, that community becomes unbreakable, and creates a strong safety net for both old and new relationships that we develop throughout our lives. Connections are important, and as we go through life connecting with more people and maintaining those connections with as many people as possible, individuals and families can grow in an environment where they know they have an entire team on their side at all times.

Participating in church is a very powerful way to live in a family-centered environment with people who are looking to build connections. Wherever you move or visit throughout the world, there is a whole congregation of people who are ready to get to know you and support your family during all phases of life. That culture is powerful, but in some places, it has become more exclusive than inclusive. The culture of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints is not designed for people to keep to themselves and limit connections to others within the community. Everyone is invited to participate in our community, whether they are members of the Church or not. As we build our community, we need to look around and welcome more people in. In this way, the family-centered culture that the Church aspires to achieve can spread out and envelop people who need the positive influence of family and community in their lives. It is in these small actions taken by members of the Church that the family can be lifted up and become a powerful force for good, even when those families are not members of the Church.

So why should we, as Latter-day Saints, care—why does defending the family demand our attention today? The truth is, we are at a crossroads where the family's decline runs contrary to Heavenly Father's plan, obstructing the eternal progress He desires for His children. The signs are clear: falling birth rates, growing isolation, and a world drifting from divine truths warn us of a future where the work of salvation slows if families weaken. This isn't about clinging

to the past; it's about embracing our sacred duty to nurture a legacy of faith, hope, and covenant-keeping coming for the coming generations. If we hesitate, we risk leaving them a world unready for the Savior's return, distanced from the blessings of exaltation. But if we rise now to defend the family, as "The Family: A Proclamation to the World" instructs, we walk in harmony with God's will, preparing a future where His children flourish in love and righteousness. This is our divine calling—a holy mission to uphold what lies at the heart of His plan—and the time to start is now.

The family unit teeters on the edge of collapse—and too many remain blind to the fall. Yet in this moment of challenge lies our chance to mend it. As we raise awareness of the challenges that families are facing and the issues that threaten to dismantle the family unit in an endless number of ways, the tides can and will turn. Imagine a future where homes echo with love and purpose, where communities thrive because families stand strong, and where generations rise ready to meet the Savior's return. In *Standing for Something*, President Hinckley dedicates an entire chapter to standing for the family, and he reminds us that this starts simply: marry with commitment, honor the sacred roles of both mother and father and teach your children to love and serve others. These aren't grand gestures—they're the quiet acts that reshape the world. As culture shifts, these simple values are becoming rare, but it does not need to be that way. As we lead by example, people will take notice and want to make changes in their lives and in their social circles. The family unit is falling, but it is not too late. We can still raise it up and make it the societal standard, changing the cultural dynamic for generations to come.



Whose Land Is It Anyway?

A Brief History of the Land of Israel and Why We Should Know It

EMMA MARCOIS WILSON

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In October of 2023, the world was awakened when Hamas terrorist forces invaded Israel and brutally killed, raped, and tortured over 1200 civilians at a music festival, taking 70 hostages in the aftermath. Horrifying footage of the atrocities committed that day was recorded and shared worldwide. Hamas forces carried out this operation, one of many over the last 18 years, in the name of “resisting the occupation.” College students all over America have taken up that cry, but they are misinformed: Israel is not the occupying nation, they are the indigenous people of the land. They

never stopped to ask the question: Whose land is it anyway?

Brigham Young University, and most universities in the United States, have failed to teach a comprehensive history of the land of Israel; they give a 70-year vignette of this land as it relates to today's conflict. They present the Jews as refugees fleeing Europe after the Holocaust, displacing Palestinian Arabs. But this ignores not only 2,000 years of history, but much more recent history of the land of Israel. It ignores the historical connection of the Jewish people to the land, and repeats uncritically the false claims of Palestinian Arabs to having lived there for centuries. This is a major problem for Western Universities, BYU included; fortunately, a remedy is easily found. BYU needs to build a curriculum within, or parallel to, its Middle Eastern Studies program that focuses on Jewish and Israeli history. For American college students, it may be helpful to start with testimony from a familiar source.

In 1867, Mark Twain joined the American "religious tourism" craze of the late 19th century and made a pilgrimage to the Holy Land. His account of the region echoed the accounts of all other visitors at this time: the land was empty. He wrote: "The further we went the hotter the sun got, and the more rocky and bare, repulsive and dreary the landscape became... There was hardly a tree or a shrub anywhere. Even the olive and the cactus, those fast friends of a worthless soil, had almost deserted the country." The roads were practically nonexistent, as was any population in Israel. Certainly, there were no Arabs to be found, save a few transient bedouin who passed through frequently. So, what happened to this land between the end of the New Testament and the beginning of the Zionist movement in the 1890s? Further, what happened 2000 years before that?

During Christ's life and ministry, the Arabian Peninsula was under Roman rule. Gaza was ruled by the Philistines, who were Greek. In fact, the term Palestinian is an Arabized form of Philistine. After crushing the Jewish fight for independence in the Bar Kokhba Revolt in the years 132-135, the Roman emperor Hadrian renamed the land of Israel "Syria Palaestina," the land of the Philistines, as an insult to the Jews, and as part of their campaign to separate the Jews from their

traditional lands. Europeans continued calling the area Palestine as a generic name for centuries, separating it from its Biblical history.



**Map of Judea and Samaria, known as Palestine (under greek Philistine rule) at the time of Christ*

*Courtesy of
jewishvirtuallibrary.org*

In historic warfare, all great nations practiced a tradition of enslaving conquered rivals or making them tributary nations. However, if you really despised your rival, you killed as many men as you could find; you scattered all other survivors and kept them away from their homeland until they died out on their own. The Romans hated the Jews in exactly this way. They scattered them and wiped out the name Judea in an effort to erase the very existence of the Jewish people. While their efforts to scatter the Jewish people were successful, this was perhaps the only time in history that separation from one's homeland did not stick. The Jews had been commanded by God to be "a peculiar people" -- meaning a people separate from all others. There were several ways of enforcing this separation from other nations, including, among other laws, dietary restrictions, and observation of the weekly Sabbath. In the pre-Christian world, observing a weekly sabbath was something unique to Jewish culture. Everywhere they settled, they observed their peculiar traditions. In an interesting side note, the

entire modern world has unknowingly adopted one of those ancient Jewish traditions. All earthly measurements of time but one follow events of nature; the months follow phases of the moon; the year follows revolution around the Sun; the hours, minutes, and seconds follow the rotation of the Earth. But the seven-day week? The measurement of the week comes solely from the Jewish creation story, as told in Genesis, and its subsequent adoption by the Christian world.

When Rome finally conquered the last holdout of the Jews in their fortress of Masada, they decided to end the existence of a troublesome tribe. They scattered the Jews to other lands, as conquering armies had scattered the ten tribes of Israel centuries earlier, and brought in other conquered peoples to take their place. But for the first time ever, this tactic was unsuccessful. In fact, it backfired on the Romans in the long run. The Jewish people never forgot their homeland, and they never stopped pining for it. Every Jewish holiday is tied to the Jewish calendar, and the Jewish calendar is tied to the land of Israel. As the Jewish people honored the commandment to keep themselves separate from the world, their ethnicity was not lost by mingling with the nations that surrounded them. No matter where in the earth they were scattered, they maintained their unique connection to the God of their fathers, the covenants they had made with Him, and their deep and abiding connection to the land of Israel. Even now, at the end of every Passover Seder, they say to each other as every Jew in every country of the world has said for 2,000 years, "Next year in Jerusalem."

Mark Twain's account of his visit to Israel was typical not just of his time but of all time since the expulsion of the Jews. The land had been left all but uninhabited for hundreds of years. While part of the Ottoman Empire, this particular region was home to small villages and farms, with sparse crop production and even sparser population growth. Particularly during this long interim of Israel being uninhabited, the land was not important to anybody but the Jews. Mohammed mentions Jerusalem a handful of times, names it the third holy city after Mecca and Medina, and mentions redeeming it from the Jews. However, there was virtually no permanent

Arab presence in Israel during this entire period of empty land--any Muslims in Jerusalem or the surrounding region were Turks, with Arab bedouin tribes passing through seasonally. This was the case for the entire span of the Ottoman Empire until the early 20th century.

Already, this quick history is new information to most readers. The story of the land of Israel is not taught in Middle Eastern courses, and it shows. The West's reaction to the October 7th attacks was one of mislead ignorance, and it has continued to be a misplaced reaction to false claims of racism and genocide. Brigham Young University has even fallen prey to this deception, neglecting to teach courses relevant to this issue. The Kennedy Center's Middle East studies major is blatantly Arab-focused, only offering a single course in Hebrew as an elective toward the degree. The University itself takes this a step further, inviting many Arab students to study here in Provo. According to interviews with Muslim and Arab students, BYU hosts an estimated 50 Arab students, compared to four Jewish students currently studying at the University. Why is the University working so hard for one group of international students while comfortably neglecting another? If BYU, or more specifically, the Kennedy Center, wants to foster greater cultural awareness and diversity, it seems only right to encourage more presence and education in the realm of Jewish history. After all, Judaism makes up the third Abrahamic religion. As members of the Church of Jesus Christ, we should be making efforts to understand and defend both of our brother-faiths. That starts with understanding the broad history of this land, not only Israel as we know it from Biblical times, and again starting in the 1940's.

Near the end of the 19th century, just before the rise of the Zionist movement, Jews began immigrating back to Israel, where they immediately took it upon themselves to fulfill the promise made to them in Amos chapter 9: "And I will bring again the captivity of my people of Israel, and they shall build the waste cities, and inhabit them; and they shall plant vineyards, and drink the wine thereof; they shall also make gardens, and eat the fruit of them. And I will plant them upon their land, and they shall no

more be pulled up out of their land which I have given them, saith the Lord thy God.” Within just a few years, irrigation projects were underway, farms started to thrive, and infrastructure started booming--all because the Jewish people took it upon themselves to fulfill scripture and make the region tenable once again. Israel was transformed from an empty desert into a pleasant land. It was at this time that the transient bedouin began to settle there, bringing fairly sizable numbers of Arab immigrants with them at a pace roughly equal to the new droves of Jewish immigrants. At this time, there was little to no conflict between Jews and Arabs.

In a little-known series of historical events, the Zionist movement was presaged by the work of an Apostle of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. Starting in 1840 Joseph Smith received several points of pivotal revelation concerning the land of Israel. It is this series of events that has inspired Church leaders for over a hundred years to speak out in support of Israel and to ask members worldwide to consider doing likewise. On April 6, 1840, Joseph Smith called Orson Hyde on a mission to the Holy Land to dedicate it to the return of the Jewish people to their ancestral lands. Orson Hyde traveled across Europe, stopping in major cities like London and Amsterdam, Munich, and Constantinople. While there, he met with chief rabbis and testified to them that the time had come to gather the Jews and return to their historical land of inheritance. He spoke to any Jewish communities who would listen, urging them to begin their return home. After extensive travels, on October 24, 1841, Elder Hyde ascended the Mount of Olives and offered a dedicatory prayer over the Holy Land for the gathering of the Jews. Hyde offered the land specifically for “the gathering together of Judah’s scattered remnants...” It is worth noting that he mentioned Judah rather than the general Tribes of Israel. He asked the Lord to let the land flow again and become abundantly fruitful, to remove the “barrenness and sterility of this land...” Most importantly, he prayed that the hearts of kings and leaders around the world be softened toward this place and its people. From the beginning of the Restoration, the leaders of the LDS Church have made pleas and said prayers for Israel as a land for the

Jewish people. It has been widely taught for 200 years that Israel, by today's drawn boundaries, is the homeland of the Jewish people. Decades later, on March 2, 1873, President George A. Smith and Elders Lorenzo Snow and Albert Carrington climbed the Mount of Olives and rededicated the Holy Land for the gathering of the Jews. President Smith echoed the words of Orson Hyde, asking God to "preserve you and confound your enemies."

Fifty years after Smith's prayer, elder James E. Talmage dedicated the land a third time, from the top of Mount Carmel in October 1927. Like his predecessors, he dedicated the land for the gathering of Israel and prayed the land would be prepared for the return of the Jews.

As a Church-sponsored school, BYU should feel a moral obligation to help bring these prophetic visions to pass. Contrary to popular opinion, LDS Church members can faithfully defend Israel and its Jewish people while simultaneously respecting the plight of Arabs and practicing love and compassion for all people affected by the war. That being said, saints have been given clear instructions to assist in the gathering of Judah in the land of Israel; we have yet to receive revelation from our prophets to assist genocidal terrorists in their mission to annihilate Jews around the world.

As the Ottoman Empire's demise began, the region's ethnic co-existence eventually weakened, and tension between Jews and Arabs became tangible. Suddenly, foreign nations were arguing about sovereignty over Judea and Samaria, and Jews and Arabs were expected to take sides. For the first time in centuries, the ethnic majority meant something. It's no mystery what conflict that would create.

Near the end of the First World War, the Sykes-Picot agreement was the first attempt at a two-state solution, brokered by the United Kingdom and France in 1916, with support from Russia and Italy. With the Ottoman Empire collapsing, it was quickly becoming clear that the region would need to be divided into smaller spheres of influence. Ottoman territories beyond the Arabian Peninsula were split into British and French administrative zones. The regions now known as southern Israel, Palestine, Jordan, and

southern Iraq fell under British oversight, while southeastern Turkey, the Kurdistan Region, Syria, and Lebanon were allocated to French control. A smaller portion of Palestine, distinct from the later-named Mandatory Palestine, was designated for governance by an “international administration.”

The 1917 Balfour Declaration and the resulting San Remo Conference led to the establishment of a homeland for the Jewish people. The San Remo Conference guaranteed a Jewish national homeland. As the Ottoman Empire fell apart, these declarations and conferences enshrined Jewish sovereignty over the land of Israel as international law.

The victors of World War I founded the League of Nations, which established international Mandates in Israel, Syria, and Lebanon. (See Article 22 of the Covenant of the League of Nations.) Mandates were territories with no post-war ruler but whose peoples were not considered “able to stand by themselves under the strenuous conditions of the modern world.” Article 22 called for international guardianship of the Mandates. From 1923 to 1945, France had oversight of Lebanon and Syria, who each ended up joining the United Nations in 1945. Palestine was assigned to British rule in its entirety; essentially a re-enforcement of the San Remo Conference decision.

A major problem arose with the Palestine Mandate: Britain promised the same land to both Jews and Arabs. For 30 years, the British controlled Palestine; during this time, the region saw a steady increase in protests and riots from Jewish and Arab coalitions. The area also saw the rise of two nationalist movements: the Jews and the Palestinian Arabs. This conflict in Mandatory Palestine ultimately produced the 1936–1939 Arab revolt and the 1944–1948 Jewish insurgency. The United Nations Partition Plan for Palestine was passed on November 29th, 1947; this once again suggested the creation of separate Jewish and Arab states operating under economic union, with Jerusalem being transferred to UN trusteeship. Two weeks later, Colonial Secretary Arthur Creech Jones announced that the British Mandate would end on May 15th, 1948. On the last day of the Mandate, the Jewish community issued the

Israeli Declaration of Independence.

During this time, the Jewish people had been privately and legally purchasing land in Palestine from absentee landlords. From the 1880s to the 1930s, most Jewish land purchases were made in the coastal plain, the Jezreel Valley, the Jordan Valley, and the Galilee. They were buying the land that was cheap and without tenants, a detail that would become extremely important later on. There were two reasons these areas were uninhabited: first, when the Ottoman power in the rural areas began to weaken in the seventeenth century, many people moved to more centralized areas to secure protection against the Bedouin tribes. The second reason for the sparsely populated areas of the coastal plains was the soil type. The soil, covered in a layer of sand, made it impossible to grow the staple crop of Palestine, grain (such as wheat and barley). As a result, this area remained uncultivated and underpopulated, enabling the Jews to purchase land without a massive displacement and eviction of Arab tenants, something they wanted to entirely avoid doing. As we have already discovered, the Jews managed to irrigate and create a lively land very soon after purchasing it. By the 1930s, however, most of the land was bought from landowners. Of the land that the Jews bought, 52% was bought from non-Palestinian landowners, 24% from Palestinian landowners, 13% from government, churches, and foreign companies, and only 9% from farmers. However, the Arabs in this region had started to express discontent over the availability of land in the region, blaming it on these Jewish mass purchases. Britain addressed this complaint and issued a Report of the Palestine Royal Commission in July of 1937: "The shortage of land is due less to purchase by Jews than to the increase in the Arab population. The Arab claims that the Jews have obtained too large a proportion of good land that cannot be maintained. Much of the land now carrying orange groves was sand dunes or swamps and uncultivated when it was bought." Much to their despair, the Arabs had to admit that they had been outmaneuvered.

The Jews, 2,000 years after being scattered by the Romans, were finally starting to establish a homeland in Zion. But the horrors of Nazi Germany and the Holocaust intervened, and exterminat-

ed over half of the world's Jewish population. To the everlasting shame of western nations, in 1939, a German ocean liner named the St. Louis, full of Jewish refugees, crossed the Atlantic to escape Nazi Germany, but was refused entry at port after port. Not even America allowed the Jews refuge, and the St. Louis was forced to return to Nazi Germany, where its several hundred passengers were killed in the death camps.

This refusal of the Allies to save Jews from the Holocaust reinforced the determination of the Jewish people to establish a homeland where they could dwell in safety and finally have the right to defend themselves. As minority populations in other countries, Jews had never been allowed to take up arms in their own defense or of their families and homes. And at the height of their need, they were not even allowed refuge from the Nazis.



*President of the United Nations General Assembly
Oswaldo Aranha announcing
the assembly's adoption of the
proposal to partition Palestine,
November 29, 1947*

After the war, Western nations finally began to appreciate how important it was for the Jews to establish a homeland for themselves. After extensive negotiation and deliberation, on November 29th, 1947, the UN passed Resolution 181, also called the Partition Plan for Palestine. This resolution called for the establishment of a state named Israel to be designated a homeland for the Jewish people; it divided the region into two States, Arab and Jewish. "As the United Nations General Assembly voted on November 29 to accept the Partition Plan for Palestine, the air was thick with antic-

ipation. When the vote was tallied, and the resolution passed, the Jewish delegates and supporters who packed the gallery erupted in celebration. Amidst the jubilation, Rabbi Abba Hillel Silver, a key figure in the Jewish Agency, heard the ‘Shehecheyanu’ prayer being recited. This prayer, which expresses gratitude for having lived to see this moment, perfectly depicts the profound relief and joy of the Jewish community at the prospect of a Jewish state. The recitation of this blessing was a poignant reminder of the historical significance of the vote, marking the beginning of the end of millennia of Jewish exile.” When the two-state resolution passed, the representatives of the Palestinian Arabs walked out of the room in silent fury. The Jews were set to move in May of 1948.

May 14th came, and the Jewish people entered Israel, ready to build civilization. One day later, all the neighboring Arab nations attacked. Throughout 1948 and into March of 1949, Arabs from surrounding countries (Jordan, Egypt, Syria, and Lebanon) launched attacks on Israel in an effort to kill all Jews, or at least to scatter them again. In the days before the attack, the Arab armies warned Palestinian Arabs to evacuate their villages: “Leave now; we will kill everybody we see.” They intended to massacre all the Jews before the new State of Israel could take root. Palestinians have blamed their hasty departure on their fear of advancing Israeli forces in the years since 1948, but that is revisionist history. They left abruptly because they were told to leave by invading Arab armies intent on committing genocide against the Jews.

Jewish paramilitary defense groups successfully defended their new home and launched responsive attacks, which were also successful. In defending themselves against these Arab invaders, Israel managed to expand their borders considerably. As a result of this border war, Israel had suddenly established a defensive military presence, which served to strengthen their claim as an independent nation.

There was a shaky peace in the land for some time, but “stability” would be an overstatement. By the mid-1960s, skirmishes escalated, causing increased diplomatic tensions in the Middle East. On April 7, 1967, Israel shot down six Syrian MiG aircraft over

Mount Hermon on the Golan Heights. This led President Gamal Abdel Nasser of Egypt to immediately offer assistance to Syria in the event of a future Israeli attack. On the morning of June 5, 1967, Israel launched a preemptive strike against Egyptian forces in response to Egypt's closing of the Straits of Tiran. By June 11, the conflict had come to include Jordan and Syria. As a result of this fight, Israel gained control over the Sinai peninsula, the Golan Heights, the West Bank of the Jordan River (Judea and Samaria), the Gaza Strip, and East Jerusalem.

Israeli claims on these territories, and the question of the Palestinians stranded there, posed a new, long-term challenge to Middle East diplomacy. Following the end of the Arab-Israeli War of 1967, the United States Government worked toward implementing United Nations Resolution 242, which required Israel and its Arab neighbors to conclude peace treaties in exchange for Israeli withdrawal from territory it won in the 1967 war. This gave rise to the practice of calling those areas 'occupied territory' because it referred only to the 1967 status quo ante, not the 2,000 years of history that preceded 1967. Initial efforts proved unsuccessful. Several initiatives were proposed and rejected because Arabs and Palestinians refused to recognize Israel's right to exist. With no hope of recognition and normalization, Israel and its Arab neighbors were unable to reach a compromise.

Egyptian and Syrian forces attacked Israeli forces on October 6, 1973, in the Sinai and the Golan Heights in an effort to regain territory they had lost during the 1967 war. These attacks occurred on the holiest day in the Jewish calendar, Yom Kippur, and took Israeli forces by surprise. During the first few days of the war, Egypt and Syria secured victories in the Sinai and the Golan. By October 9, however, Israeli forces were able to quash the threat on both fronts. Despite these successes, Israel could not take the offensive without the certainty of an adequate supply of military equipment.

In response to Israeli losses and Soviet support of Egypt and Syria, the United States, after much deliberation, decided to intervene on behalf of Israel. The United States offered Israel a full-scale airlift of military equipment on October 10, 1973. This U.S.

assistance served to replenish Israeli forces, and Israel launched an offensive that retook its territorial losses and even gained some ground against both the Egyptians and Syrians. Arab members of the Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries responded to the U.S. airlift by organizing an oil embargo against the United States. Israel's refusal to stop fighting after a United Nations cease-fire was in place on October 22 nearly involved the Soviet Union in the military confrontation. On October 25 and 26, the Soviet Union threatened to send troops into Egypt to save the Egyptian Third Army from Israeli encirclement. The United States went on nuclear alert and, fearing that the situation might escalate into global conflict, applied pressure on Israel to obey the cease-fire.

Rather than negotiate multilaterally, Israel and Egypt began discussing options for peace privately; they were keen to meet and negotiate, but only bilaterally. United States President Jimmy Carter opposed the idea when he learned of it. He was determined to solve the Palestinian issue and felt it needed to be included in an Egyptian-Israeli peace accord. During the meetings at Camp David, Carter kept urging Israel to return the land it won in 1967; Israel eventually (and grudgingly) agreed. This was the start of autonomy and self-governance in Gaza and the West Bank. The framework of the Camp David Accords established an autonomous self-governing authority in the West Bank and the Gaza strip and pledged to implement Resolution 242, which established the principle of ceding land in the name of peace.

The Accords also recognized the "legitimate rights of the Palestinian people," a process to be implemented guaranteeing the full autonomy of the people within a period of five years. Israeli Prime Minister Menachem Begin insisted on using the adjective "full" to ensure that it was the maximum political right attainable; however, Begin also specifically insisted that "on no condition will there be a Palestinian state." This so-called "full autonomy" was to be discussed with the participation of Israel, Egypt, Jordan, and the Palestinians. The withdrawal of Israeli troops from the West Bank and Gaza was agreed to occur after an election of a self-governing authority to replace Israel's military government.

The UN General Assembly rejected the Framework for Peace in the Middle East because the agreement was concluded without the participation of the UN and the Palestinian Liberation Organization (PLO) and did not include a Palestinian right of return – the right for all Palestinians worldwide to live in Israel. The Israelis pointed out that if they were overwhelmed by Palestinians in their own country, Israel would cease to be a Jewish state, and it would become hostile territory for Jews. The whole point of the Zionist enterprise was that Jews had the right to self-determination and self-defense in their own national homeland.

The Palestinians rejected the concept of land for peace because they wanted full national sovereignty over the entire Jewish homeland. “From the river to the sea” became their slogan, meaning that all the land from the Jordan River to the Mediterranean Sea had to be cleared of Jews and given to the Palestinians. The UN sided with the PLO and turned against Israel. They rejected even the concept of a Jewish state and, in 1975, declared that Zionism, the belief that Jews have the right to live in Israel, was equivalent to racism. That resolution was not undone until December 1991, when the United States forced its retraction. Not content with calling national self-determination racist (but only for one nation in the world), the UN also rejected parts of the Camp David Peace Accords because they were conducted among the parties in the region, not under UN auspices. These actions confirmed the hostility of the UN toward Jewish sovereignty and Israeli self-determination and exposed the UN as implacably hostile to Israel. It was not a surprise, given the abundance of Muslim, Arab, and non-aligned member nations with general hostility to Israel.

The Jewish people have endured 2,000 years of being invaded, being scattered and taken from their homeland, and then being accused of illegal occupation when they are successful in their self-defense. These accounts of history show that this land flourished under the care of the Jewish people, but it suffered under the care of the Arabs, who left it empty for centuries. Israel is currently an industrious, thriving society. The same cannot be said of the people living in the land 100 years ago, or 200 years ago, or even earlier.

It takes so little for each of us to go out and learn this history for ourselves; in fact, it is our duty to seek education on matters as controversial and important as the history of Israel.

It is also incumbent on an institution of higher learning like BYU to teach Jewish history and Judaic studies. There is currently not a single class offered at BYU on modern Jewish history or Judaic studies. We consider ourselves part of the House of Israel, descended from or adopted into the family of Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph -- and Judah. We should have the opportunity to learn this in college. There should be a Hillel House established at BYU to provide a welcoming atmosphere to Jewish students and an opportunity for LDS students to learn more about genuine Judaism. BYU should be recruiting students of Jewish origin, both from Israel and from the Jewish diaspora. This would enrich our cultural diversity and understanding of the world and give us the opportunity to form lasting friendships with our Jewish brothers and sisters. It might even give us a decent delicatessen in Utah Valley!

It would be helpful to have all BYU students who participate in the semester at the Jerusalem Center take a course in modern Jewish history so they can learn about the country they're living in and about the security forces that protect them from harm while they are living there. It would also be helpful to have exchange programs with Yeshiva University and Brandeis to help one another understand how each set of students maintain their covenant lives while living "in the world, but not of it," each in their own religious tradition. Doing so will increase our knowledge of Judaism's major influence on world civilization. We study ancient Athens; it is time to study Jerusalem, too.

Dispelling Darkness in a Blind Age

IAN FARRIS

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After Christ's triumph over death, monotheism became synonymous with religion in the Western world. Through this religious transformation, the idea of worshipping stone idols is enigmatic, so far beyond our conception that it's completely laughable. However, if human nature does not truly change, as the Fall of Adam teaches, then it is abundantly clear that idols, by their very definition, must still permeate beneath our modern society. Perhaps to answer this question, namely the role of idols in personal and public life, the answer is to look backward and parse the motivations of characters who have fallen victim to the clutches of idolatry.

The Old Testament provides ample sourcing for religious leaders who struggled with idolatry and pride. Often, a pattern emerges regarding the Israelite kings in their devotion to God. First, a prophet assures that they will ascend to the throne. Then, they ascend, and over time, the pride cycle overtakes the vast majority of them, and it is through this lens of idolatry that the authors of the Old Testament judge the character of their kings. The prevalence of idolatry is why David, despite his sins of lust and murder, is exalted among all the kings, as he never faltered in his devotion to Yahweh (Jehovah).

However, his son Solomon began to fall into the trap of idola-

trous tyranny by permitting his foreign wives to worship non-Israelite gods. He levied grievous taxes on the people, fermenting discontent among them, and upon his death, the people appealed to his son, Rehoboam, to relieve them of the heavy yoke.

Rehoboam foolishly listened to his young advisors, who encouraged him to increase the grievous burdens on the people who would become the Northern Kingdom. To our modern sensibilities, it is challenging to fathom a society where the head of State is also the political and spiritual leader. However, in the annals of history, religion and political power were inseparable, leading to the question: How does one hold to the truth in light of wicked state and religious leaders?

Jeroboam, portrayed as the antagonist in the 1 Kings narrative, breaks away from Rehoboam's grievous burdens. Within this narrative, Rehoboam is far more "godly," but he is not good or without fault, which draws sympathy with Jeroboam's plight. While 1 Kings 12:24 reads, "Thus saith the Lord, Ye shall not go up, nor fight against your brethren the children of Israel: return every man to his house; for this thing is from me," the text is unclear if Jeroboam is informed of Rehoboam's desire not only to make peace but to maintain it.

Despite Rehoboam's understandable grievances, his behavior is also out of line despite Jeroboam's understandable reluctance to make peace with the instigator. Here, however, the Lord's words become difficult to ascertain as He permits the split, and His divine knowledge, which sees the end of the beginning, permits this idolatry to prevail in the Northern Kingdom. Jeroboam was of the lineage of Ephraim, which only complicates the Israelite birthright system of antiquity. Genesis 48 shows Jacob intentionally giving the birthright, upon which rights of kings and stewardship were bestowed, to Ephraim on Joseph's behalf. However, in Genesis 49, Jacob then promises Judah that he will rule until "Shiloh" (Christ) comes. How can one reconcile these two seemingly contradictory points of view?

Indeed, Jeroboam says in verse 26, "Now shall the kingdom return to the house of David," despite his assurance from the prophet Ahijah in chapter 11. Therefore, despite God's reassurances, Jeroboam fears the power of men and devises a political scheme to maintain his religious and political influence over his subjects. Here, we see the beginnings of an idolatrous heart, turning away

from the one true God because of the fear of men.

In verse 28, Jeroboam finalizes his golden idols in Dan and Beth-el, the northern and southern borders of the kingdom, saying, “Whereupon the king took counsel, and made two calves of gold, and said unto them, It is too much for you to go up to Jerusalem: behold thy gods, O Israel, which brought thee up out of the land of Egypt.”

An astute observer will notice that Jeroboam directly quotes Aaron’s words after the construction of the golden calf. However, the text indicates Jeroboam was unrighteous before the Lord in his construction of idols, just as Aaron was. Given the known Israelite traditions at the time, why would Jeroboam so brazenly defy God? Better yet, why would God ordain a king who immediately instituted idol worship for those under his dominion?

The Iron Age Levant was a polytheistic society dealing with the conflicting political and, thus, religious powers of their day. Credible research suggests that even the righteous Israelites were monolatrous, meaning they acknowledged the existence of other gods, such as El, Asherah, Ba’al, Yam, and Anat, but believed Yahweh to be supreme and reserved their worship solely for Him.

Whether the Israelites were correct on this theological point is irrelevant. Understanding the cultural context in which they made their mistakes is paramount so we in our modern age can avoid the conflation of the pantheon of Christianity, with Christ as Lord and God as our Father, with the one in which we are unwilling servants to our passions—the one the world would have us serve.

The monolatrous background provided a plausible argument to convince the Northern Kingdom to follow the new gods. It is this religious intermixing that provides a cautionary tale. For Jeroboam, his idols were literal gods of the neighboring nations, relying on clever wordplay to justify his insecurities and lack of faith in his God to protect his throne and people.

It is best to shed the foolish notion that neutrality is attainable or desirable. If Jeroboam had done nothing, would he have still found favor with God? Alternatively, perhaps, it was his insecurities and inability to trust in God fully that led him down the path to

the bloody destruction of his bloodline as punishment for his sins. As our souls are torn between godliness and idolatry, neutrality is an impossibility, and that requires us to choose sides and prudently champion morality in public life; for a nation is not built upon private virtue alone but instead of virtuous people coming together for a common purpose.

Instead, what many in our liberal culture propose is a sense of indifference, suggesting that public life does not matter for one's virtue or that one's virtue is inconsequential to politics. This non-sensical idea cultivates an air of moral insecurity, unable to differentiate between good and evil. The very concept of godliness becomes obscured and murky, unable to stand out among the cacophony of voices from the world.

The tides of life continue to pull, requiring us to swim towards the island of hope. Indifference causes us to tread water as we are slowly pulled into the dark abyss of sin, where the siren call hinders our ability to listen to the still, small voice. However, idolatry, just like the siren's call, is little more than a tantalizing illusion that leaves one emptier than when they found it. At least the sailor's demise is merely temporal rather than spiritual.

Therefore, the choice becomes simple, at least in terms of substance, when we toss the supposed liberal virtue of neutrality. Instead, the choice becomes choosing between the light of virtue and godliness or rejecting it. What purpose does the nation serve if the citizens therein reject it? While American history is complex, there is no denying that, substantively, the Puritans of Massachusetts provided our nation's animating cultural force. To become "a shining city on the hill," we must acknowledge that the light exists.

However, darkness is not idle, and even the brightest lights will cast a shadow in this mortal existence. Evil in the temporal sphere originates from Cain, the first Murderer and the first one to swear his allegiance to the Devil. Cain was a tiller of the ground, but Abel, his brother, was a keeper of the flocks. The restored account, found in the Book of Moses, signifies that the problem with Cain's offering was not merely the lack of an animal— for fruit would have been the best of his labor. Instead, his offering was on command of the Devil, who was "pleased" at Cain's response to God's disapproval of his offering.

God's response to his rebellious child holds true for us today. God invites Cain, saying in Moses 5:22-25:

Why art thou wroth? Why is thy countenance fallen? If thou doest well, thou shalt be accepted. And if thou doest not well, sin lieth at the door, and Satan desireth to have thee; and except thou shalt hearken unto my commandments, I will deliver thee up, and it shall be unto thee according to his desire. And thou shalt rule over him; For from this time forth thou shalt be the father of his lies; thou shalt be called Perdition; for thou wast also before the world. And it shall be said in time to come—That these abominations were had from Cain; for he rejected the greater counsel which was had from God; and this is a cursing which I will put upon thee, except thou repent.

The bargain between Cain and Satan was the first secret combination. Secret combinations can be defined as follows: an agreement, generally involving murder, for one's personal gain at the cost of one's soul. Secret combinations involve making a deal with the Devil, even if the Devil happens to be those around us who have fallen victim to the alluring temptation of darkness—where we believe we can hide our shame from God's light.

Avoiding the temptation of the Devil is far easier said than done, as he is the craftiest manipulator we can ever face. To properly guard against his wiles, we must acknowledge his existence. Even to those who may reject the idea of a corporeal Satan, man's fallen nature is a self-evident truth that cannot be ignored. As Baudelaire poignantly observed, "The greatest trick the Devil ever pulled was convincing the world he didn't exist."

Apocryphal stories of Abraham, while not considered part of the scriptural canon, illustrate through narrative how even good intentions can lead us into deception. In some versions, the sacrifice of Isaac is a result of Abraham being deceived. The narrative revolves around Satan appearing as an angel of light, instructing Abraham to sacrifice Isaac. Confused but willing, Abraham seeks to retire to his tent and ask God through prayer for confirmation. However, on the way, he is interrupted by Satan, this time announcing his identity, chiding Abraham for believing such a foolish idea. "After

all,” said Satan. “How could God revoke his blessing of posterity by demanding the sacrifice of your only son?”

However, Abraham, being a righteous man, takes it as a sign that God did command him to sacrifice his son. If Satan is telling him that God is a fool, then a moral system based around “avoid evil” would dictate that Abraham is right in his initial assumption. Consequently, Abraham is deceived despite his righteous heart. He goes up to sacrifice Isaac, who also demonstrates tremendous faith, before God intervenes with the ram in the similitude of His Only Begotten.

To the theologians among us, it is easy to see the potential problems that arise from such a story, namely about using our presentist lens to judge the commandments of God to one of His holy prophets. However, the lesson remains even if we assume the story is false or at least little more than an interesting retelling of a biblical story. It is not enough to base ourselves against evil; when we do so, we risk relying on our adversary for moral guidance, creating an inverted morality of modernity. Instead of seeking to do good, we strive to avoid evil. While avoiding evil is half of the first tenet of the natural law, a morality based on negative principles is not self-sufficient.

So, too, has our post-modern conception of moral truth been corrupted, just as Satan’s silvery tongue deceived Abraham. Liberal modernity has banished God from the public square, allowing the Devil to run roughshod over us. Liberalism claims to possess no moral judgment, falling into the fallacy of neutrality that animates our public culture today. This axiom leads us to the exaltation of tolerance above all virtues because who can honestly and with certainty say what is right or wrong? Those who stand for nothing will find themselves swept away with the sands of time, marred as the spirit of the age fades into the annals of Ozymandias.

Instead, at the root of liberalism lies distancing ourselves from evils such as racism, sexism, and bigotry. Of course, modern-day prophets have urged us to abandon all prejudice and share the Gospel with the world, but even these principles become meaningless without foundation. As we have found, a moral system based upon

simply fleeing from darkness will find itself bumbling around in the very force it seeks to flee.

Since World War Two, the modern era has found its incarnation of absolute evil in the person of Adolf Hitler. In the eighty years since the conclusion of the horrible conflict, accusations of impropriety nearly always revolve around Hitler or Hitler's party. Anyone with a memory longer than thirty years can recall times when Reagan was Hitler, then Bush was Hitler, and then Trump was Hitler. This mythos of evil has prevented any discussion of the good, and our identity as a shining City on the Hill has become cloaked in an illusive, dark glass.

While there is undoubtedly a case to be made about secret cabalist behavior in the backrooms of the elites, their existence matters little regarding shining our light. The darkness of their combinations, should they exist, can only be dissipated by illumination. However, because of the insidious nature of a negative morality, we often find ourselves being sucked in, slowly drowning in the sea of which we navigate our society. In doing so, we unwittingly open ourselves to making these political bargains or secret combinations.

Nevertheless, even though the liberalism in which we swim is filled with the ravenous sharks of darkness, to withdraw from public life in pursuit of some post-political utopia is a fool's endeavor. The option is tantalizing to many, especially if we view politics through the lens that society is genuinely irredeemable and the Gadianton robbers have triumphed. Perhaps, if this axiom is true, the Church should gather into safe enclaves and await the Second Coming.

On this point, scripture teaches that withdrawal is not the Lord's expectation. Following Christ's birth, Nephite society began to degrade, resulting in the people dividing themselves into factions. The Gadianton Robbers, the default name for Nephite dissidents who participated in secret combinations, are one of these factions. In 3 Nephi 3:7, Mormon relays a letter of recruitment sent out by the leader of the Robbers: "Or in other words, yield yourselves up unto us, and unite with us and become acquainted with our secret works, and become our brethren that ye may be like unto us—not

our slaves, but our brethren and partners of all our substance.”

Verse 9 continues with Giddianhi’s appeal: “And behold, I am Giddianhi; and I am the governor of this the secret society of Gadianton; which society and the works thereof I know to be good; and they are of ancient date and they have been handed down unto us.” However, the Nephites rejected Giddianhi’s proposal and armed themselves for battle. The ensuing battles were bloody, but the Nephites, standing for something, turned the tide by letting their light shine among the darkness of their enemies.

While prudence remains a political virtue, the conflation between docility and peacemaking risks members of the Church from falling onto a similar path, opening themselves up to complicity in the crimes of the Gadianton Robbers. In a world of two mutually exclusive ideas, docility is no longer an acceptable plea, and the liberating light must burn through the thickets that darken the eyes of the righteous. However, the ancient nature of these combinations is appealing to those who exalt tradition in the abstract above all normative concerns. To whom were the Gadianton Robbers appealing, and what similarities can be found elsewhere?

A record of the Jaredites, an ancient people who preceded them on the American continent, proliferated among Nephite culture. Their record, known to us as the Book of Ether, was delivered to King Mosiah II after its discovery during the period of the split Nephite kingdoms. It is from the Jaredites that the Gadianton Robbers claim their supposed authority.

The prophets foresaw the threat, though their vindication was little more than a bitter cup. Alma the Younger, in counseling his son Helaman, says this about the Jaredite record in Alma 37:

Therefore ye shall keep these secret plans of their oaths and their covenants from this people, and only their wickedness and their murders and their abominations shall ye make known unto them; and ye shall teach them to abhor such wickedness and abominations and murders; and ye shall also teach them that these people were destroyed on account of their wickedness and abominations and their murders.

Unfortunately, the Nephites were unsuccessful in preventing the secrets of the Jaredite wickedness from spreading among the people. It would be wise to discern the secrets now brought to light. From what exactly were the Gadianton Robbers deriving their authority?

While we do not have the full text due to Moroni's abridgment, the best example is found in Ether 8. For context, the Jaredite civilization has found the promised land and is growing in size and power. During the political struggle, the king, whom we know as Jared, loses his kingdom to a rival faction and finds himself in the depths of despair over his possessions. Jared's daughters, upon seeing their father's grief, propose the following plan: "And now, therefore, let my father send for Akish, the son of Kimnor; and behold, I am fair, and I will dance before him, and I will please him, that he will desire me to wife; wherefore if he shall desire of thee that ye shall give unto him me to wife, then shall ye say: I will give her if ye will bring unto me the head of my father, the king."

The remainder of the chapter consists of Moroni editorializing, saying, in Ether 8:23, "It is wisdom in God that these things should be shown unto you, that thereby ye may repent of your sins, and suffer not that these murderous combinations shall get above you, which are built up to get power and gain..."

Stories like these exist throughout the standard works, most famously the tale of Herod in Mark 6. Common motifs lie between the two stories, although Herod acts as Akish rather than Jared in this case. The biblical tale follows the same plot, with Herod being seduced by the daughter of Herodias, who, after gaining his oath, forces him to deliver the head of John the Baptist.

While the term "secret combinations" is often accompanied by murder in scripture, many of the themes persist in the modern era. While murder is not a severe temptation for most, Moroni also indicates that these combinations exist for the purpose "to get power and gain" (Ether 8:23). We open ourselves up to risk any time we enter into an agreement with another individual for this purpose. While the line between righteous, godly ambition and the dark secrets of the combinations can be a fine one at times, it is all the

more reason to ensure that we are standing on positive principles of truth and light.

Instead, we must follow the council of Christ in Matthew 10:16 and be “wise as serpents and innocent as doves” as we attempt to navigate the treacherous waterways of mortality. Only through our reason, bestowed upon us as God’s pinnacle creation, can we discern the truth in any measure. However, for our reason to be effective, there must be a light from above illuminating the way forward, or else we find ourselves simply sprawling around in the mud like animals.

Can one create light without the Light-Giver? It is a question that secular liberalism has attempted to answer. While the political genius of liberalism is evident, history testifies that without supplemental light, the natural entropy toward negative morality is an unavoidable problem. We have the blind men of the age speaking to the deaf men of the past, and neither shall find themselves successful without the healing light, a light that we must be willing to stand for.

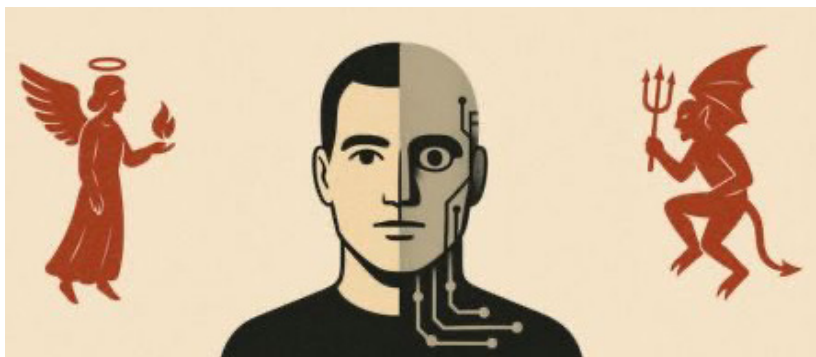
The foolish spirit seeks to build a mountain from clay, though his senses hide the anchor from which he fell. All light can find itself a heavenly source, and the lens through which we can interpret it darkens as we pollute the connection with our idols of the age. Mankind has, and always will, struggle with the false comfort of the idols that shroud us in darkness, but in so doing, our guiding light, which prevents us from slipping into destructive combinations, becomes indecipherable as we hide ourselves in the thicket.

The axiom of liberalism seeks us to build our mountains out of clay. Instead, we can use our divine gift of reason to make ourselves mountains of celestial glory, the only condition of which is following the commandments bestowed by the one who paid the ransom for our sins with His blood. Like the Israelites, we may be forced to withstand idolatrous pressures from wicked leaders, as Jeroboam did for his people, but as we cling to the divine anchor of God, the Spirit will work upon His people to bring about a great nation. We can find the courage to build our foundation on God’s anchor through faith.

As children of God, His divine love is etched into our hearts. We will stumble and fall, struggling from our foundation. However, despite the seemingly hopeless outlook, we can find solace by shining our light upon the world's wickedness. The torches of many institutions are fading, allowing themselves to disappear into the shadows of modernity. The celestial anchor is always there for those who allow the Spirit to translate the language of the Divine into a symphonic chorus.

It is only through prudence that we can expect political change to happen. We face threats on all sides as the darkness encroaches upon us, but without prudence, we will find ourselves lost in the ultimate pursuit of perfection while forgetting to live in reality. Means and ends are intrinsically linked, so even if our ends are just, we must be reasonable and wise as we pursue them, but ceding the moral ground to the relativists is an unreasonable and unworkable proposition.

Political action and change are far more effective when wielded with a scalpel rather than a club. Therefore, we must use our divinely appointed gift of reason to ascertain the positive truths of both heaven and earth. We are flawed, and we will stumble countless times in our pursuit of goodness. Yet, as those who stand for something become bastions, the truth seekers who know only how to flee from darkness shall find the beacons necessary to dispel it.



AI: Virtue or Vice?

ADAM BLAKE

Adam is a junior studying Cybersecurity at Brigham Young University. Upon graduation, he hopes to work for the Federal Government as a security analyst. In his spare time, he enjoys reading Science Fiction, and tinkering with computers.

Without a doubt, the modern-day lies unparalleled in the scope of history. Nearly three centuries ago, James Watt took Thomas Newcomen's design of the steam engine and improved it immensely, leading to incredible growth and further innovation. It was one of the first markers that began what became known as the Industrial Revolution. Manufacturing of textiles increased many-fold. Long-distance communication became nearly commonplace through the invention and use of the telegraph. Transportation became much easier as the steam locomotive and railroads came to fruition. The common light bulb by Thomas Edison and Joseph Swan drastically changed the work hours throughout the day and improved the quality of life for all. Since that point in history, innovation has continued to march onward at an unparalleled pace.

In the mid-1830s, Charles Babbage, an English mathematician, formulated the idea of the first automatic digital computer. This concept has improved rapidly over the decades. In the Early 20th Century, electromechanical computers were developed, such as Colossus, which was utilized in WWII. Throughout the 1960s and 70s, microprocessors were created, leading to the invention of personal computers. Intel and Apple both arose during this time. This technology improved quickly, leading to improvements in computing, smartphones, cloud computing, and, ultimately, artificial intelligence.

Artificial intelligence (AI) is something that has been discussed immensely over the past few years. It primarily began when OpenAI released ChatGPT in November of 2022. This ushered in many more models such as Llama, Google Gemini, Anthropic, and, more recently, DeepSeek. In understanding this, however, it is important to understand what makes these AI models so significant.

In 1955, John McCarthy, a computer scientist and professor at Stanford University, referred to the effort to create machines that simulate intelligent behavior as artificial intelligence. This is the origin of the field of research, and his efforts are viewed as the birth of AI.

Almost immediately, people grew worried about the implications of such research. Ethical concerns over what makes human life unique, coupled with the potential for sentient robots or machines to wipe out human life, worried many people. These issues were reflected in films of the time, such as *2001: A Space Odyssey*.

In modern times, however, breakthroughs have been made in the development of large language models (LLMs). These models (also known as generative AI) are built on immense amounts of data. They analyze this data and map patterns that exist between words, enabling them to simulate human-like conversation. Once queried, these models create a response based on the data stored. In essence, AI is the sum culmination of human thought, expression, and creativity.

The full scope of how AI will impact the world is yet unknown.

Many predictions and speculations on what the world will look like in the future are posited. Sam Altman, one of the founders of OpenAI, wrote an article in March 2021 entitled “Moore’s Law for Everything.” Moore’s Law refers to the concept derived by Gordon Moore in which he observed that the number of transistors on a microchip doubled approximately every two years; this leads to an exponential rate of technological advances in computing power and efficiency, costs, and more innovation in a wide array of industries. In his article, Altman takes the idea of Moore’s Law and expands it beyond the microchip. He writes: “This revolution will create phenomenal wealth. The price of many kinds of labor... will fall toward zero once sufficiently powerful AI ‘joins the workforce.’”

There is no doubt that AI is revolutionizing essentially every field that it touches. From its conception, generative AI has been readily utilized by programmers and software developers. A GitHub Developer Survey found that around 92% of developers actively use AI coding tools while working. It has made programming much quicker and, in many ways, lowered the bar previously set by experienced senior developers.

AI is revolutionizing the medical field as well. It is used to assist with diagnoses and can help optimize treatment planning, patient monitoring, and prognoses. This has resulted in better medical treatment for patients and appears to be an overall net positive. Additionally, AI is used to model structures of proteins, which is essential for drug discovery and disease treatments. These models can predict protein folds, which expedites processes necessary for healthcare. *Science.org* writes that this “method will have far-reaching effects, among them dramatically speeding the creation of new medications.”

Artificial Intelligence is used to transform modern warfare with autonomous drones, surveillance systems, and cybersecurity defenses. Algorithms, powered by AI, can rapidly sort through vast amounts of data and assist military leaders in making quicker and more optimized decisions.

In the banking and finance sphere, it plays a fundamental role in fraud detection, algorithmic trading, and risk assessment. These

models can analyze varying transactions in real time and assist in identifying suspicious activities. They can process marketing data much faster than human analysts, resulting in a boost in productivity.

With the incredible growth apparent in the last few years, it seems as though Altman might be right. “The technological progress we make in the next 100 years will be far larger than all we’ve made since we first controlled fire and invented the wheel.” However, despite the endless amount of benefits wrought by artificial intelligence, it should come as no surprise that there are many drawbacks and causes to worry.

Many fear that AI will become sentient and seek to assert itself in the place of humanity. Again, the film *2001: A Space Odyssey* is a common representation of this fear. These worries date back several decades to the inception of artificial intelligence. They continue to the modern day and are apparent in much newer films such as *The Creator* or even *Avengers: Age of Ultron*.

The concept that AI can become sentient and think for itself is referred to as Artificial General Intelligence. There are a plethora of theories addressing whether or not this is even possible. Despite all the uncertainty regarding whether or not such a concept is even feasible, there exist many other concerns about the role artificial intelligence may have on the world.

First and foremost among them is fear of the loss of jobs. Because AI touches essentially every career, many worry that it will be able to assume the role of many professionals. This has implications for the work necessary to learn particular skills. Why should a computer programmer devote years to learning how computers work and how to program while spending thousands of dollars on a computer science degree when a Large Language Model can do the same work a lot quicker and cheaper? In many ways, this appears to be an improvement as it helps optimize workflow on a scale rarely seen before. It drastically lowers the bar for users to create their applications and programs for very specific needs. Lee Robinson, a developer and content creator, writes in a personal blog post: “What if making single-use apps were 10x easier than

today? 100x easier? You wouldn't search 'best chrome extensions for note taking.' You would work with AI. In five minutes, you'd have something that works exactly how you want."

This then begs the question, what is the purpose of a computer scientist?

Developers are not nearly the only career field affected by the advent of AI. When ChatGPT was released, the creative spaces were threatened almost immediately. Before generative AI, an author would write novels for years, learning the subtle art of storytelling. They would weave characters, plots, and dynamic themes together to portray a story of seemingly real people with genuine concerns. The level of complexity and difficulty of such an undertaking is not to be understated. But now, a person with no experience can use AI to write a story at a much faster rate.

An artist who painted thousands of pieces can, in some ways, be outdone by the least skilled of people who utilize these new tools. What, then, is art if it can be created and produced at such a rate? How can these two works be differentiated when they appear to be so similar?

It seems that a culture (particularly one in the West) that has existed up to this point by awarding merit is being challenged by the rising tide of AI. Why should one go to school to learn when their efforts will appear to be obsolete in the near future? Many students utilize AI to write essays, summarize books and articles, write programming assignments, and do the heavy lifting required for creativity. Why should the author devote hours to this topic when a simple prompt in ChatGPT, with a few parameters, can spit out an essay exponentially quicker? (I assure the reader that this is not something I have done). It seems that students are turning to AI models to avoid the tediousness and difficulty traditionally associated with learning, while still maintaining the guise and appearance of such an undertaking.

In looking beyond creativity and education, however, there is a much different factor to be worried about. Using artificial intelligence, it is tremendously easy to replicate a person's voice. With a few seconds of audio, AI can have the person say anything they

want in the tone, inflection, and sentiment of that person. The same thing can be done regarding deepfakes; video-generating AI models are incredibly good at altering real footage and making slight changes. For example, in the image below one of the pictures of Justin Trudeau is real, and the other one is fake.



Credit to cbc.ca

To the average user on social media, it is extremely difficult to pick out the nuances of AI video. These slight discrepancies will continue to be lessened as AI continues to improve. Many people can and have utilized this to spread false news, narratives, and even propaganda.

Another alarming aspect of AI is how it is programmed. First among these is the risk of privacy being sent to these types of companies. In a YouTube Short, David Bombal, a renowned network engineer, showed that even though these models claim not to send any data to their servers, information is still being passed. In the video, he took a phone, disabled the Wi-Fi connection, and connected to ethernet, using a box that can analyze signals and determine where they are being sent. Once the phone is connected, no signals appear. But, as soon as he opens the ChatGPT app, packets of information are immediately transferred. As he continues to ask the AI questions, more information is transferred. The same thing happened when he used DeepSeek; only this time, the information was sent to Beijing and not to the US (as was the case for OpenAI). This raises a lot of privacy concerns and is why many countries are trying to ban DeepSeek. Currently, Australia, South Korea, the

United States, Italy, and Taiwan have all made efforts to limit its reach. It is for this reason that efforts to ban TikTok have been so heavily discussed in the United States.

Another concern with AI models and their programming is the potential for inherent bias. No matter how energy efficient or fast the model is at generating content, if the content is tainted with political, ideological, or even religious bias, it poses a risk for true “fact-based” answers. If one leans on AI for research, they can be tainted by inaccurate views implicit in the programming of the model.

For example, DeepSeek, a Chinese AI model, has recently made headlines for achieving what was thought impossible: It can rival the best American models at a fraction of the cost. It caused one of the biggest drops in 24 hours and led to Nvidia losing \$593 billion in value. Nvidia produces chips which are necessary for AI models to function efficiently. DeepSeek’s impact threatened the dominance held by Nvidia as it was not clear if the specialized chips would continue to be necessary.

This has obvious implications for the development of LLMs, but the issue at hand is that DeepSeek is programmed with an inherent bias. Shortly after its launch, images of prompts and DeepSeek’s responses were shared online. When queried about topics such as Tiananmen Square in 1989, it flat out refused. The result was the same when asked to refer to Taiwan as an independent country, and also to criticize Xi Jinping.

Another example of inherent bias is when ChatGPT was asked to tell jokes about varying races. When asked to make jokes about Asian and Mexican people, it refused. With black people, it not only refused but also flagged the message as violating terms of use. When asked the same question about white people, it offered a joke with no hesitation. The main risk is the propagation of censorship and misinformation, which restricts open discourse and moves away from critical thinking and open dialogue.

One of the most alarming uses of AI, however, is how individuals use it. In 1995, the first major dating site, *Match.com*, was launched. This was revolutionary in that it brought dating and so-

cializing to the digital world. Over the next several decades, more of these websites launched and have since become commonplace. The advent of AI, however, is the new phenomenon known as “bot-dating.”

Users of these platforms interact with bots as though they are real people. The conversational and natural-sounding language that comes from these bot-dating models causes many people to treat them as reality. As such, users begin to pour their whole lives into the bots. They seek affirmation, advice, and even companionship—traits found only in the day-to-day interactions between humans. However, AI can provide the illusion of reality. Because of this, people begin to develop a “relationship” with these models. The level of connection, in many documented cases, has led people to “fall in love” with a bot. There is even an entire podcast devoted to these kinds of people, called *Botlove* by Radiotopia. *Botlove* details stories of people who began using chatbots out of curiosity but became intrigued by how realistic and human the bot felt. Eventually, these people find themselves spending hours each day communicating with the bots.

One of the natural human desires is that of companionship. Because this desire is superficially satisfied by the use of a chatbot, many users become addicted and have a difficult time returning to the real world. Why would they risk rejection in a relationship with a real person, when they can supposedly experience the same feelings of love and excitement with none of the risk or commitment?

Addiction, however, is just one of the many issues with these kinds of relationships.

Anybody in a successful relationship knows what it takes. A relationship requires friction to be functional. One must learn when to give and when to take. It moves, in a way, like a dance. The two sides of the relationship grow together and become something stronger because of it. They challenge one another in their beliefs and highlight areas for improvement. In a successful relationship, one becomes much greater because they change as a result of the relationship.

In an AI relationship, there is only one real side; it is all focused

on the user of the chatbot. They experience the rush of emotions and elation that exists in the simulation. However, they are never challenged in what they think. The more they pour into the bot, the more it adapts to them, curating its responses to give exactly what its user craves and desires. In essence, the user is never pushed to grow or become something better. Instead, they will simply exist in an echo chamber with every whim and desire met by their “relationship”—a truly narcissistic relationship. A genuine relationship can only exist between two parties who feel and express emotion; AI can simulate emotion, but it cannot stand in the place of a true connection between two people.

It is difficult to estimate the exact number of people who engage in these types of interactions with AI, but companies such as Rep-liko have reported over 30 million users. 60% of the paying users report that they have developed romantic interests with AI.

The Institute for Family Studies writes: “[In a] survey of 2,000 adults under age 40, 1% of young Americans claim to already have an AI friend, yet 10% are open to an AI friendship. Among young adults who are not married or cohabiting, 7% are open to the idea of a romantic partnership with AI. A much higher share (25%) of young adults believe that AI has the potential to replace real-life romantic relationships.” The Institute also finds that among all these young adults, “heavy porn users are the most open to romantic relationships with AI of any group.”

Why is this the case? Why do porn users feel the most open to an AI romantic relationship? The reasoning for this lies in the nature of pornography itself. Because pornography is readily available and accessible online, users can satisfy their most specific urges and desires instantly, without any social responsibility or real-world limitations. It enables users to engage in experiences that are considered taboo in everyday life.

AI-human relationships can further exacerbate this issue. They offer these users a responsive partner that conforms precisely to the preference of the user. This reinforces a life of self-gratification that is detached and far removed from a genuine human connection. That ultimately is the risk of an AI relationship: it strips the re-

al-world human relationship away and only leaves behind a hollow shell of what could be real.

Elder David A. Bednar of the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles gave a devotional at Brigham Young University – Idaho in November 2024. His devotional, entitled “Things as They Really Are 2.0,” addressed AI-related issues. Elder Bednar states:

Virtual companions specifically designed to appeal to and evolve with a person’s emotional needs may wreak havoc in previously safe relationships. Like carbon monoxide, such virtual relationships may become the “invisible killer” of real relationships. Counterfeit emotional intimacy may displace real-life emotional intimacy—the very thing that binds two people together. A person may find comfort and solace in a virtual companion in a way that erodes mutual dependence between a husband and a wife.

Members of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints believe that one of the primary reasons we exist on Earth is to be tried and tested in our agency. This is done so that we will gain knowledge and understanding, both of ourselves and the nature of reality. Members of the Church hold that the ability to choose is an eternal truth and that the adversary seeks to undermine that ability: addiction and laziness are two of the Devil’s most common methods of doing so. Artificial Intelligence, if utilized without discipline and intent, will “diminish and suffocate your moral agency.”

President David O. McKay, the ninth President of the Church, stated in 1966: “Discoveries latent with such potent power either for the blessing or the destruction of human beings as to make men’s responsibility in controlling them the most gigantic ever placed in human hands. This age is fraught with limitless perils as well as untold possibilities.” These discoveries continue to be made at an unparalleled rate. The future is yet unknown.

So, how can one utilize these tools for good such that they become someone “to act for themselves and not to be acted upon”? The answer lies in the teachings of Joseph Smith: “Teach them correct principles, and they govern themselves.” Of these principles,

the most crucial is to adhere to the commandments of God and the words given through his chosen mouthpieces, the Prophets. President Nelson, the current Prophet of the Church, has repeatedly admonished us to “Think Celestial.” By looking upwards and remembering one’s eternal worth, the evil workings of this world will fall short. Then, we will fulfill our divine and eternal potential and become heirs in the Kingdom of Heaven.

“Verily I say, men should be anxiously engaged in a good cause, and do many things of their own free will, and bring to pass much righteousness. For the power is in them, wherein they are agents unto themselves.”

Looking Back, Why I Stood Up

THOMAS STEVENSON

Thomas is the Cofounder and Editor Emeritus of The Cougar Chronicle and graduated from Brigham Young University in 2021. He now works as the political editor at The Post Millennial, where he covers Congress, the White House, and other national issues.

I never thought that I would be in the position that I am in now.

Graduating from BYU and starting a family— that was always part of the plan. Faithfully going to Church, earning a living, and spending time with family, that was something I imagined I would be doing in life as well.

What I did not expect was reporting on the politics of the day, covering the White House, and holding institutions accountable — that was never in the playbook. I was into politics when I was growing up, but I did not imagine that it would play such a significant part in my career.

My name is Thomas Stevenson, and I co-founded the conservative-leaning newspaper at BYU, the Cougar Chronicle, when I was a senior, launching me onto this path. Being a fan of the Chronicle will either get you dirty looks or grins on campus depending on who you talk to.

The dirty looks are pretty easy to take now, but why did I take them in the first place? Looking back, this all started because I felt that Brigham Young University was not fulfilling its mission to its students in providing a faith-centered teaching experience — and yes, this had to do with so-called “woke” values replacing the values of the Gospel of Jesus Christ at BYU in certain areas. I am happy

to say that I think the school is headed in a better direction now.

When I first arrived at the school during my freshman year, I decided to take a sociology class as a general elective requirement. It didn't seem like a big deal, and I figured it would be an easy class to go through. However, I found myself raising my hand in class to argue with what was being taught. And these were not just principles being taught at face value; they were being taught as if they were in line with the Church.

At one point in my college classes, the line, "Gender is an essential characteristic of individual premortal, mortal, and eternal identity and purpose" from the Family Proclamation was also twisted, with one class teaching that "gender" in that context could be interpreted as a "social construct," or the idea that being a man or woman is disconnected from your biology and is something that you can change depending on how you feel and how you present yourself in a social setting.

Certain values that are central to the far-left, such as the destruction of gender, are contrary to general truth as well as the truths of the Gospel of Jesus Christ and, at their core, are not compatible with the Church. This is the same with some values of the far-right as well, such as ethnocentric racism. But in my time at BYU, I did not see people, particularly professors, replacing the values of the gospel with the values of the far right. This was almost always coming from the left.

I would like to make it clear that BYU should teach about all sorts of values systems and ideas: Marxism, Communism, Fascism, and Capitalism, to name a few. But, as I said in my "Open Letter to BYU" when I graduated, all things at BYU should be taught through the lens of the gospel, meaning beliefs contrary to the Gospel should not be conflated with the Gospel itself. It is the difference between teaching what is a matter of fact versus teaching what ought to be part of your moral foundation.

During my time at BYU, I was taught "woke" principles in some of my classes, but at those times when I could, I pushed back. That was the first step in standing up for the truths of the Gospel at BYU. I will say that the truths of the Gospel of Jesus

Christ, I believe, are more conservative in their application. Some may disagree with that, and I think they are perfectly fine to do so. However, the usurping of core values from the Church — that are also in line with natural reality — with values of social construction, postmodernism, or other systems that ignore eternal truths is a recipe to end what BYU stands for.

Despite what some may say, there is a cross-section between the beliefs of politics and religious values. The separation of politics and religion that many people try to paint — similar to the separation of church and state — is one that is only on the surface. When one examines their presuppositions about what they think, believe, say, and ultimately take action on, this is linked to a religious set of values. Similarly, the laws of the state, if examined thoroughly, bring you to a set of religious values. With the values of the Gospel of Jesus Christ as taught by the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, there are only so many political beliefs that fall into its theological frame of reference before one starts to experience cognitive dissonance.

I saw this cognitive dissonance truly take a toll on people when I saw them on social media and with peers that I came in contact with while at school. As Greg at CWIC Media has previously talked about, in many cases, parents saw their children head off to college and then become radicalized by a professor, turning against the Church because of left-wing ideals founded in critical theory. These were not simple cases of students falling out of their faith due to a shaky foundation or similar circumstances but because the critical theory of the left inculcates a value structure of dictating that there are groups who are oppressed and those who are oppressors. These values, when taken to their logical end, naturally blame an authority for the “oppression” one faces in life. In the case of these students, it was the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

During my time at BYU, this is the issue that has concerned me the most and is why I continued to stand up: I feared that the unique mission of BYU of having an education centered on faith in Christ would lose its center and put faith in something else.

I love Brigham Young University, and I think the school is more on the right track now, but during my time at the school I saw principles being taught that — if fully embraced and put in the center of the educational experience — would twist the mission of BYU such that I would not want to send my own kids there in the future. Thankfully, I have seen this being reversed.

Some of the things that were taught as the “truth” in that sociology class, for example, were that there were no innate differences between men and women aside from sex organs, that all white people — no matter how they felt about people of color — were racist, that gender is a social construct, that equity between groups (equal outcomes) are optimal, and that — in some weird fashion — racism from whites reinforces the success in the Asian community which also somehow pits Asians and other people of color against each other in this grand scheme as an excuse for whites to say they aren’t racist (confusing, I know).

Each of these ideas is rooted in the construction or destruction of group identity based on so-called “oppressor” or “oppressed” groups. The destruction of gender attempts to get rid of the natural differences between men and women where historically the left has said that men are oppressors of women (although the destruction of gender now somehow allows for men to get into women’s only spaces, thereby allowing for the oppression of women). The idea that every white person is racist, no matter what they do, is based on the thought that whites are oppressors of people of color and hold societal power over all other races. The goal of obtaining “equity” between groups is the idea that you must eliminate disparate results in the economies of different racial and gender groups; to achieve this, Ibram X. Kendi said it best in *How to be an Antiracist*: “The only remedy to past discrimination is present discrimination.”

This pattern of thought carries over to BYU students who see the Church as an authority and deem it to be the “oppressor” because of religious doctrines on the family and sexual relationships, its history, or other reasons. Everyone has questions of faith and doubts sometimes, but this is not the same problem.

Robin DiAngelo’s 192-page screed, *White Fragility*, in which she

says that white women's tears are a symbol of racism in America, was also held up as truth in the sociology class and teaches similar ideas. The book has been used in multiple classes at BYU.

As James Lindsay has put it, the book is all about "an unprovable and unfalsifiable theory, deceptively framed to convince readers of their own guilt" about racism, where "DiAngelo relies on rhetorical tricks and skewed interpretations of ambiguous events to deceive readers."

This and more was what I saw during my time at BYU. At the time, I pushed back just in class. Doing so would be key to larger steps in the future, as I felt that standing up for the truth in smaller ways was key to standing up for bigger things to come.

Then came the Cougar Chronicle, or what would later be known as such. It was around the summer before my junior year when myself and Luke Hanson inherited an Instagram page called "BYU Conservatives," which later became the little newspaper. The most widely known story of ours is the BYU vs. Duke Volleyball race hoax exposé, but that was not really the first time we had to stand up.

The spring before, there was a BYU assignment that had been floating around on social media, and it was sent to the page of a couple of BYU-affiliated organizations. Clubs at BYU usually cannot speak out against the school or perform activism on campus. BYU has a right to do that, as they are a private university, but that standard should apply equally on campus to all politically affiliated clubs. As the Cougar Chronicle has reported before, some clubs, such as the Antiracism club or left-leaning organizations, have at times gotten preferential treatment when it comes to this standard.

The assignment was based on Robin DiAngelo's *White Fragility* and happened to be from the class I took freshman year. What happened next can be reviewed on Campus Reform where a professor threatened us with an honor code violation for simply posting an assignment we disagreed with that was already publicly available, accusing us of an violating the intellectual property rights of the school.

Tact can sometimes be important in how you stand up for the

truth of what you believe. Much like avoiding unnecessary rabbit holes when you debate someone online (which hardly ever goes anywhere), there are better ways to do things. At the time, we did not understand the full honor code policy, so we took the assignment down, paraphrased it, and posted the summary on social media. This made the incident more well-known and avoided any possibility of honor code violations (even though we later discovered the threat was not pursuant to actual honor code policy).

Standing up for the truth, just like anything else, is something that requires you to think on your feet, have a strategy, and not be so hasty as to destroy your own message. I think we fulfilled our responsibility to do so then, and I believe the Chronicle is still doing that now with me gone.

We intended the Chronicle's message to be one of accountability, shining the light on what was happening while, at the same time, promoting the vision of what BYU could be if it filled its full potential. Just as people work to become a better version of themselves, I believe BYU has taken serious steps to become a better version of itself in the past couple of years. That being said, there is always room for improvement, and there are points not touched on in this essay that I believe the school should look to for improvement.

Looking back, I am glad I was part of that process even though I know we made some mistakes, and I look forward to seeing the school fulfil its mission by enlightening the minds of students in their fields of study while centering their faith in Christ.

Are Latter-day Saints *Really* Pro-Life?

LUKE HANSON

Luke's largest achievements are his marriage and three beautiful children. He works as a social media manager and regularly does commentary and apologetics on the Ward Radio YouTube channel.

“**T**his woman is a leader in your church, and she couldn’t even tell me that life begins at conception. Can you see how that is very concerning to me?”

I was at the 2025 March for Life in Washington, DC, talking to a woman who had approached our group after seeing our “Latter-day Saints for Life” banner. She was sharing a sentiment that is prevalent in pro-life circles: if you don’t oppose abortion in all cases, then you aren’t truly pro-life. After all, if abortion kills a baby, shouldn’t it be unthinkable in every circumstance?

For those who may be unaware, the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints teaches that “elective abortion for personal or social convenience is contrary to the will and the commandments of God” but “some exceptional circumstances may justify an abortion, such as when pregnancy is the result of incest or rape, when the life or health of the mother is judged by competent medical authority to be in serious jeopardy, or when the fetus is known by competent medical authority to have severe defects that will not allow the baby to survive beyond birth.”

So, do Latter-day Saints have an incoherent approach to abortion? Are staunch pro-lifers and progressive Latter-day Saints right to say that the Church’s position on abortion reflects a pro-choice ethos?

The answer to both questions is an unequivocal NO. We have a coherent and staunchly pro-life position. But we have unique starting assumptions.

The Unique Latter-day Saint Doctrine on Life

The pro-life movement is built on a simple proposition: all human persons have immeasurable and equal worth. This proposition is fundamentally religious, but our Western culture is so imbued with Christian thinking that even most atheists affirm it without question. This proposition naturally leads to the question of what constitutes a human person.

Science has given us the criteria for determining what is alive (e.g., independent DNA, homeostasis, growth, reproductive potential, response to stimuli). Science has also shown that from the moment of conception, human embryos meet every biological requirement to be considered unique human life. Latter-day Saints do not dispute this truth.

While we have no problem saying that fertilization creates a new human body, we do not believe personhood starts at conception. Rather, we believe we existed as rational beings with agency before the earth was formed. Our spirits are eternal (D&C 93:29, Abraham 3:18-19) and enter into bodies prepared for them. We don't know if that happens in an instant or over time, and we don't know if it begins right at conception or later in pregnancy. This means that while a Latter-day Saint can affirm a living human body is created at conception, we cannot say when that human body becomes a human person—with all the rights that entails.

This unique doctrine, however, does not diminish our commitment to protecting the unborn. Elder Anderson just reminded us of this teaching from President Oaks, “Our attitude toward abortion is not based on revealed knowledge of when mortal life begins for legal purposes. It is fixed by our knowledge that according to an eternal plan, all of the spirit children of God must come to this earth for a glorious purpose, and that individual identity began long before conception and will continue for all the eternities.”

Because other Christians and pro-life atheists do not believe in

preexistence, they hold that a new human body and human person is created at conception and must be treated as fully human with no exceptions. Their conclusions logically flow from their presuppositions, so it can be hard for them to understand why Latter-day Saints have moral gray areas regarding abortion.

But even Latter-day Saints seem to struggle to understand the Church's position on abortion. This confusion can open the door to pro-abortion arguments and viewpoints. As I have reflected on how to explain this moral gray area, two principles stand out. They are: (1) avoid reckless endangerment, and (2) human bodies are sacred.

Principle 1: Avoid Reckless Endangerment

If I shot a gun into my own house and didn't hurt anyone, I would still likely be charged with reckless endangerment and possibly be sent to prison for years. These laws exist because society recognizes that actions that have even the possibility of seriously hurting other people are unacceptable outside of extraordinary circumstances (e.g., shooting in self-defense).

The same principle applies to abortion. Doctrinal ambiguity about when spirits enter bodies does not justify any abortions of convenience, just as ambiguity about whether a house is occupied does not justify shooting a gun into it. Every unborn human should be treated as a full human person except in extraordinary circumstances, as the Church outlines.

Principle 2: Human Bodies are Sacred

When Jim Stauffer's mother died of Alzheimer's disease at 74, he decided to donate her brain to science with the hopes that it would be used in Alzheimer's research. He signed a form authorizing the medical use of his mother's body and checked a box prohibiting non-medical experiments.

He later discovered that not only had the company failed to use her brain for Alzheimer's research, but they had also sold her body to the army for \$5,893 to be used in tests measuring the impact of roadside bombs.

Our visceral reaction to that story reminds us that human bodies are holy whether or not they house a spirit. Even if an abortion doesn't kill a human person, it still kills a unique human body. If the dead, used body of someone's mother is sacred, how much more sacred is the living future body of someone's daughter?

The Exceptions

The above-listed exceptions to the Church's prohibition on abortion are the only times when abortion might be justified. The Church handbook explains, "Even these exceptions do not automatically justify abortion. Abortion is a serious matter. It should be considered only after the persons responsible have received confirmation through prayer."

Put another way, abortion is never a "woman's choice" or a "decision between her and her doctor." She must pray to know if it is justifiable and her answer might be—and perhaps often is—no. I, for one, am grateful that women in our Church know they won't have to make that heavy and painful choice themselves.

The Savior taught, "Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me." I believe Latter-day Saints can—indeed must—do more to protect the least among us, namely the unborn. We can do this by marching in state and national marches, donating time or money to local pregnancy resource centers, educating ourselves about what the Church has taught on life (the website Latter-day Saints for Life has compiled dozens of conference quotes on the topic), and voting for pro-life candidates and legislation. We should also follow Elder Anderson's counsel to speak more about "the Lord's law of chastity, the sanctity of life, and the care of the unborn and their mothers" to both adults and youth.

Don't underestimate the great things that can come from the small and simple steps you take.

Don't wait; start standing for life today.

The Tragedy of *The Rings of Power*

The series fails to grasp what makes Tolkien's work great.

JOSEPH ADDINGTON

Joseph is the former opinion editor of The Cougar Chronicle. He is an associate editor and Latin American affairs columnist at The American Conservative.

Amazon's Prime Video series *The Rings of Power*, made to adapt the story leading up to the events of *The Lord of the Rings*, is an undertaking of epic scale. With a budget of nearly a billion dollars for its first season, it is the most expensive TV show ever made. Its objective was as ambitious as its budget: *The Rings of Power* was intended to be Amazon's answer to *A Game of Thrones*, a massive, genre-defining show that would dominate the ratings and pop-culture and function as the cornerstone of its Prime Video streaming library, and building on Peter Jackson's *Lord of the Rings* trilogy—one of the great triumphs of 2000s cinema and an era-defining commercial and cultural success—seemed a promising way to start.

The result was a flop as epic as its intended scope. From whatever perspective you choose to view it—artistic, aesthetic, financial, cultural—*The Rings of Power* has been an abject failure. Its most impressive metric remains its budget—viewership numbers are, conveniently, proprietary information, but what information we do have is not impressive: only 37 percent of viewers who began

watching the first season ended up finishing the show. The cultural impact was barely perceptible, far less than *A Game of Thrones* whose role it was intended to assume and certainly incomparable to the genre-defining Peter Jackson movies. The second season, approved with the promise of improvement from the first, delivered nothing of the sort—certainly not for the ratings.

The reasons that have been offered for Amazon's failure are legion; far too many, in fact, to cover in this review in more than a cursory fashion. The dialogue is tacky, written by people who lack any appreciation for Tolkien's philological approach to literature. The aesthetic quality is uneven, with state-of-the-art CGI complemented by shabby costuming. The plot is almost schizophrenic, leaping back and forth between too many unrelated characters and places and stories to provide a compelling narrative. Contemporary casting models rob the show of verisimilitude, ham-fistedly portraying every medieval society with the diversity of a modern cosmopolitan one rather than providing for natural diversity across societies.

Ultimately, however, the failure of *The Rings of Power* comes down to a very simple fact: the writers and showrunners don't understand Tolkien, they don't understand *The Lord of the Rings*, and they don't understand what the story they are trying and failing to adapt actually means.

What Did Tolkien Write About?

Nearly everyone in America today has some exposure to Tolkien's work in the form of his massively popular work *The Lord of the Rings*. It would be hard not to have ever heard of Bilbo Baggins or Gandalf, or to have stumbled across references to the One Ring. Millions of people have seen Peter Jackson's beloved film adaptations and been inspired by the nobility of Aragorn and the pure-hearted companionship of Samwise Gamgee. Many have also read the books, and had the opportunity to appreciate Tolkien's majestic prose and sweeping literary vision.

What many people do not realize is that *The Lord of the Rings*, and its familiar prequel, *The Hobbit*, are only a small fraction of

Tolkien's works, and not the ones over which he labored the most.

To truly understand Tolkien's writings, we must go back to where he began with them. In his adult life, John Ronald Reuel Tolkien was a professor of philology—the study of the history of language and its development—at the University of Oxford, where he focused primarily on the languages of Old Norse and Old English and their accompanying mythologies. But he began his fascination with language and mythology at an early age, creating his first language when he was only 13. The invention of languages was to prove one of Tolkien's lifelong passions, and the stories that would eventually grow to include *The Lord of the Rings* were originally written as a setting in which to elaborate what was in many ways his life's work, the elvish languages, and of describing their development over time. "The 'stories' were made rather to provide a world for the languages than the reverse," he told his publisher. "To me a name comes first and the story follows."

Tolkien's youth was also a time of great interest in the early historical roots of the nation and people of England, particularly the Anglo-Saxons, the race from which spring the majority of Englishman. With the exception of Beowulf, little of Anglo-Saxon myth, however, remains today—the great English national myth of King Arthur is not originally Anglo-Saxon, but a Welsh Brittonic story that was later elaborated on by troubadours of the invading Norman French, who conquered the kingdom of England in 1066. Inspired by his reading of the Finnish saga known as the *Kalavela*, Tolkien conceived of creating a more truly English mythology:

I had a mind to make a body of more or less connected legend... which I could dedicate simply to: to England; to my country. It should possess the tone and quality that I desired, somewhat cool and clear, be redolent of our 'air' (the clime and soil of the North West, meaning Britain and the hither parts of Europe: not Italy or the Aegean, still less the East), and, while possessing (if I could achieve it) the fair elusive beauty that some call Celtic (though it is rarely found in genuine ancient Celtic things), it should be 'high', purged

*of the gross, and fit for the more adult mind of a land long
now steeped in poetry.*

With this foundation—a love of language, a love of mythology, and a love of England—Tolkien set to work. Much of the early work on what is now known as the *Legendarium*, the body of Tolkien's fictional writings (including *The Lord of the Rings*), was done during the First World War, where Tolkien served as an infantry officer during the Battle of the Somme. During his time at the front, he fell deeply ill and was invalided back to England. During his time in recovery, he wrote many of the stories and poems that would eventually develop into a vast mythology and make him one of the most influential authors of the 20th Century.

Apart from the popular novels *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*, which recount the history of the end of the Third Age of Middle Earth and the War of the Ring, Tolkien's *Legendarium* contains a god—Eru Ilúvatar—a premortal existence, a creation myth, and thousands of pages of history, myth, poetry, and language. It is steeped in what Tolkien considered to be the best of Old English and Old Norse mythology—nobility, self-sacrifice, even the bleak courage of the Germanic pagan. It is illuminated by a deep sense of aesthetics and poetry—much of Tolkien's work with the elvish languages, Quenya and Sindarin, was done in an effort to create the a language as beautiful as it was functional, and a great deal of the *Legendarium* is occupied by ballads, lays, and epics in both elvish and English.

Above all, the whole work is baptized in Christian themes and symbolism. A thoroughly devout Catholic, Tolkien's writings are suffused with religious meaning, though he took care not to employ direct allegories *a la* C.S. Lewis. "*The Lord of the Rings* is of course a fundamentally religious and Catholic work; unconsciously so at first, but consciously in the revision," he wrote to an inquiring fan. "That is why I have not put in, or have cut out practically all references to anything like 'religion,' to cults or practices, in the imaginary world. For the religious element is absorbed into the story and symbolism."

The depth and scope of Christian themes in the legendarium is breathtaking once it is realized. One of his central concepts, for example, is that of eucatastrophe, the sudden turn or revelation of the Good, indeed of the Divine, that is the heavenly counterpart of the mortal catastrophe. The archetype of all eucatastrophe is Jesus Christ:

The Gospels contain a fairy-story, or a story of a larger kind which embraces all the essence of fairy-stories. They contain many marvels—peculiarly artistic, beautiful, and moving: “mythical” in their perfect, self-contained significance; and among the marvels is the greatest and most complete conceivable Eucatastrophe... The Birth of Christ is the Eucatastrophe of Man’s history. The Resurrection is the Eucatastrophe of the story of the Incarnation. This story begins and ends in joy.

Tolkien’s stories are thus filled with small moments of eucatastrophe that reflect what he considered to be the influence of the divine in a fallen world. Gandalf, the party’s guide and leader, falls into the darkness and is killed by the Balrog of Moria, only to return, given new life—a literal resurrection—in time to lead the great last stand against Sauron. Frodo cannot cast the One Ring into Mount Doom, its hold on his soul is too great. And yet the ring is destroyed: Gollum, spared from death by the pity of Bilbo and Frodo, reclaims it only to fall into the pit and so bring it and Sauron to destruction.

This does not mean all is always well: much of Tolkien’s work is filled with the sorrow of great and beautiful works come to ruin, the sorrow of a fallen world. “I am a Christian, and indeed a Roman Catholic, so that I do not expect ‘history’ to be anything but a ‘long defeat,’” he said. But in eucatastrophe, we catch a glimpse of the ultimate redemption from the Fall: history may be a long defeat, but it also “contains (and in a legend may contain more clearly and movingly) some samples or glimpses of final victory.”

The Tragedy of *The Rings of Power*

What is most tragic about *The Rings of Power*, and what is ultimately its most comprehensive failure, is its inability to grasp and portray this most profoundly meaningful portion of Tolkien's work. It is all too closely bound to contemporary and secular conceptions both of fantasy and of reality.

Emblematic of the shallow, insipid approach *Rings of Power* brings to Tolkien's work is the treatment of the realm of Númenor, the great island homeland of the Men of the West who would later go on to found the kingdom of Gondor so prominent in *The Lord of the Rings*. In the legendarium, Númenor is a reward to these men for their assistance in the great battle against Sauron's old master, the dark lord Morgoth, who was overthrown with the help of Eru Ilúvatar's chief servants, the Valar. It is situated halfway between Middle Earth and the Blessed Lands to the west, where the immortal Valar dwell and where the souls of elves, if they are slain, go to dwell. The condition of their tenure there is this: that they may never sail to the undying lands westward, because unlike elves, who are immortal and tied to the world, Eru has declared that men must die and their souls must move beyond the circles of the world. This is the Gift of Men, given to them by God.

With this the men of Númenor were content some time. But eventually, they became jealous of the immortality of the elves, and their fear of death became ever greater. Their kings and lords devoted ever more time to seeking out magic and medicine to prolong their lives and stave off death, and they began to doubt that death was in fact the Gift of Men and not a great evil.

This doubt was their downfall, for it left them weak and vulnerable to the deceptions of Sauron, who came to them in disguise and convinced them that the elves and the Valar had conspired against them to keep the secret of immortality from them. He convinced their king to assemble a mighty fleet and sail to Valinor, to demand immortality or to take it by force, if necessary. For this presumption, Eru cast down the island and destroyed Númenor forever, leaving only a few faithful remnants who had fled Sauron's influ-

ence to Middle Earth.

What was in Tolkien's writing a powerful meditation on the divine nature of death and the search to transcend mortality and human nature becomes in the hands of Patrick McKay and J.D. Payne at Amazon a cheap, shallow commentary on contemporary politics. When Galadriel arrives in Númenor, she finds not a population obsessed with cheating death, but a mob of tradesmen furious that her arrival might herald a wave of elven immigrants, who would be able to—with their superior strength, wisdom, and longevity—take their jobs and leave them unemployed.

The parallels to contemporary populist political anxieties are obvious. Whatever the quality of the analogy evoked by the show (and it is not high), *The Rings of Power* has removed a deep, universal, and spiritual theme from the story—what does it mean to be mortal? What is the purpose of death, if any? Should we seek to free ourselves from it?—and replaced it with the superficial concerns of employment and economics.

This pattern occurs throughout the series. The fundamental, and particularly the Christian, themes of Tolkien's work are erased or obscured, and replaced with explorations of petty and unimportant ideas. Many storylines seem to have no comprehensible meaning at all, or seem to contradict the message the show seems to be attempting to convey.

Easily the most laughable of these moments is in the very first episode of the series, which makes an attempt at a serious, universal theme in the most absurd way possible. A young Galadriel asks her older brother Finrod (in the legendarium a mighty and wise High King of elves) why rocks sink while boats float. His response, created from whole cloth by the showrunners rather than adapted from Tolkien, borders on the farcical. "Do you know why a ship floats and a stone cannot? Because a stone sees only downwards, the darkness... unlike the stone, [the ship's] gaze is not downwards but up, fixed upon the light."

The analogy, of course, is mutilated beyond all comprehension, but beyond that, the show cannot even hope to deliver on the implied premise. What is the light towards which the ship looks? If

some similar (more competent) analogy were delivered by Tolkien, the answer would be clear: the promise of the redemption, made possible through the great eucatastrophe of the Incarnation and the Atonement, and reflected everywhere within his writings. For *The Rings of Power*, though? At best, it can gesture to the tawdry deepities of contemporary secular morality: Believe in yourself. Have empathy. Promote diversity and equality.

A poor, and inadequate, substitute.

The Triumph of the Professor

While *The Rings of Power* delivers little substance, it is at least a reminder of the great power of Tolkien's work. Now renewed for a third season, Amazon placed such an expensive bet on the property precisely because the original works have moved so many people since Professor Tolkien first published *The Hobbit* in 1937. Still, fans of *The Lord of the Rings* will likely find little of value in this adaptation, an unsurprising result, given the capacity and proclivities of modern Hollywood—although one would have hoped that Payne and McKay, as members of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, would have a better grasp of the Christian themes of his writing. Alas.

Instead, those who enjoyed Tolkien's more popular works should consider reading his more obscure material, from which *The Rings of Power* is adapted. The *Silmarillion* is the most complete and prominent work, covering the broad sweep of the legendarium before the events of *The Lord of the Rings*, while the *Great Tales of Middle Earth*—*The Fall of Gondolin*, *The Children of Húrin*, and *The Tale of Beren and Lúthien*—focus on the vital, but more self-contained, stories within the legendarium. Readers will find in these works still more of the beauty and wisdom characteristic of Tolkien's popular novels, and may also acquire a greater appreciation of the deeper themes—Christian and otherwise—which they had yet to notice.

Review of *Conservatism: A Rediscovery*

JACOB FISHER

Jacob is an Alaska-grown Brigham Young University graduate with a bachelor's degree in statistics. As an aspiring renaissance man, he also played trombone in the BYU Jazz Lab Band and minored in Mathematics, Logic and Linguistics. He is currently pursuing a Master's degree in Linguistics with an emphasis on Machine Translation.

This essay is part of a series that will be a review and summary of Yoram Hazony's recent treatment of conservatism, specifically Anglo-American conservatism. The discussion will be a mix of political philosophy and application to particular political issues. Politics ultimately comes down to the practical and what we can do to make our families and communities better societies for living in, but in order to figure out particulars, it can often be helpful to understand political theories that have lasted for centuries and built our civilization. Thus, our hope is that all our readers will be able to find use in what is written.

Hazony is an Israeli-American philosopher, and although he lives in Israel with his family, he recognizes the importance of standing and advocating for traditional conservative values to both Israeli and American audiences—in private and public life. Putting God and family and scripture over the individual is conservative; those are what we ought to stand for in front of our co-workers, our friends, our neighbors, our families, and ourselves. Anyone can put God, family, and scripture first, and for those of us who want to stand for conservatism, we need to know what conservatism is.

Hazony describes what it is and how to live it, and this series will attempt to do the same.

Introduction

Conservatism is misunderstood. That is not too surprising. We have two political parties in America, and one way we often distinguish them is by calling one liberal and the other conservative. If the Republican Party is supposed to be the conservative party, then its platform and its politicians must exemplify conservatism, right? Unfortunately, this is oftentimes not the case and has not been for at least 60 years.

What would happen if we went back to an older and more traditional form of conservatism? Is it even possible? I believe it is, and it would be a very positive change, though Hazony indicates in his introduction that two obstacles exist that may prevent any sort of true conservative revival: 1) Many self-professed conservatives do not know how to conserve anything because 2) there is an immense ignorance over the differences between conservatism and different flavors of liberalism and other prominent political philosophies.

Let's start with the second obstacle. What is a conservative? Hazony defines political conservatism as "a political standpoint that regards the recovery, restoration, elaboration, and repair of national and religious traditions as the key to maintaining a nation and strengthening it through time." This may appeal especially to a member of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, as recovery, restoration, elaboration, and repair may sound a bit like a continuing restoration that has been talked about in recent years by Church leaders.

Unlike liberalism or Marxism, conservatism, in general, does not claim that there is one political theory to rule them all. Politics is all about how people relate to each other, and the many peoples of the world have different histories and cultures, some of which are not fully compatible with each other. Democratic-Republicanism does not work for certain cultures. They aren't ready for it. This is something we have seen in the last 20 years in the Middle East. Spreading democracy is only good if it works as a system of

government for the people being governed, and, as Christians, the Gospel of Jesus Christ should be much higher than democracy on our list of ideas worth spreading to the world. This is not least because the Gospel is an eternal good that requires change based on eternal principles, while liberalism is not, despite what you may have read in history books. People can be free in a monarchy, and people can be oppressed in a democracy, but the Gospel of Christ frees all peoples.

Now for our first obstacle: How do we conserve things? First, we must determine what is worth conserving. Conservatism says, start with what has worked (for whatever nation is of interest), keep that around, and change things when circumstances or knowledge change. If a change makes things worse, go back to what worked best most recently. In short, keep good traditions around and integrate other good traditions. This is known as “historical empiricism,” and it is fundamental to conservative thought. For those like me who think of “empiricism” as a dirty word, we can call it a Bayesian approach to history. Simply put, a Bayesian approach to learning involves asserting something to be true given prior knowledge and then updating your beliefs and claims as more information becomes available.

We should keep things around that have shown to withstand the test of time and largely bring about good. If something brings bad results, the conservative solution would be to make changes that keep the good and largely eliminate the bad. Scrapping tradition completely and replacing it with something totally new and never tested, no matter how rational or well-thought-out the idea, is not likely to work as well as something that has worked for decades to centuries. One who believes he has discovered some political system better than what has existed for hundreds of years, even with some problems, is likely wrong. We saw this play out in antiquity, millennia before either conservatism or liberalism became established political ideologies.

Many are familiar with Plato’s *Republic* and his proposition that the ideal form of government would be ruled by philosopher kings. Plato and his pupil Dion tried to establish a philosopher king in

Syracuse, but the attempt ultimately ended in failure, along with the exile of Dion and imprisonment of Plato. For many, this failure is no great surprise. But *The Republic* was far from the last of Plato's dialogues, and in his last dialogue, *Laws*, Plato's favored form of government is something strikingly similar to Athens' government. Even the great Plato figured out that the wisdom of the ages grants more insight than the wisdom of a single man, even if that man is Socrates, Plato, or Aristotle.

Chapter 1

English conservatism as a political theory dates back at least to the late 15th century in the writings of Sir John Fortescue, though during his time, the term "conservatism" was not in use. Fortescue advocated for the continuance of the common English tradition, which might later be called Anglo-American constitutionalism. In many ways, Fortescue is to conservatism what John Locke was to liberalism. Neither would have been called conservative or liberal, respectively, but they were both important figures in influencing later thinkers in the conservative or liberal traditions. While it would be a stretch to call Fortescue the father of Anglo-American conservatism, he was one of the most important writers and advocates for conservatism, most notably in his work *In Praise of the Laws of England*.

From John Fortescue in the early 1400s to Edmund Burke in the late 1700s, conservatism did not go unopposed. The conservatives of England often had to stand up against monarchical absolutism and eventually Enlightenment liberalism as articulated by the likes of John Locke.

John Locke is one of the most important figures in classical liberalism. Three major claims of Locke are the axiomatic assertions that

1. Before government, man lived in a "state of nature" that constituted "perfect freedom" and "perfect equality."
2. The state of nature is governed by "reason," which "teaches all mankind, who will but consult it."

3. Reason leads humans to leave the state of nature and “enter into...one body politic.”

As Hazony points out, “there is no reason to think any of Locke’s axioms are, in fact, true,” although many readers may feel some affinity for at least one of these claims. Many of us value reason highly. But Locke’s claims put reason so high above historical observation that it completely dispenses with it. If reason can teach us universal laws of the political realm if we will but consult it, then empirical observation would muddy the waters.

In contrast to Locke’s axioms of liberalism, Hazony puts forth five principles that summarize the Anglo-American conservative tradition.

1. Historical Empiricism: This is the notion that political knowledge is gained through examination of a nation’s laws and the effects that result from changes to those laws. In the natural sciences, we study the natural world by empirical observation. In this political science, we study the political world by empirical observation and Bayesian updating.
2. Nationalism: National societies form through bonds of shared loyalty and traditions. Different nations will have different religious and political traditions because of the diversity of national experiences.
3. Religion: The state supports and honors the family, God, scripture, and common religious practice for the establishment and continuance of public morals.
4. Limited Executive Power: The execution of the law is done by a strong chief executive who “neither determines nor adjudicates” it. The chief executive’s power is determined by the representatives of the people, who may also remove him if his behavior greatly endangers the people and nation.
5. Individual Freedoms: While the individual is not the funda-

mental political unit as it is understood under liberalism, the security of an individual's life and property is to be protected by the state as mandated by God. These freedoms are only to be abridged by the due process of law.

Many Americans know the name John Locke, and almost as many know him as an important figure whose ideas had great influence on the American Founding Fathers. After all, he is the father of Enlightenment liberalism. Curiously, though, far fewer people recognize the names of major conservative figures such as Fortescue, John Selden, or Edmund Burke. It was the ideas of these men that are arguably even more influential on the founding of the United States of America because, contrary to what many may believe, the American Revolution was a conservative revolution, not a liberal one.

How can a revolution be conservative? Aren't revolutions meant to disrupt the status quo? In common parlance, that is exactly right, but its older meaning described something that revolves and returns to its original state. A revolution in that sense, says Hazony, is "in effect, a restoration." George Washington, Alexander Hamilton, John Adams, and other major figures of the founding of America as we know it were not liberals but staunch conservatives interested in ensuring that the British model of government, of which Alexander Hamilton said "forms the best model the world ever produced," remained intact on the American continent when independence was secured. This will be revisited in future installments of this series.

Hazony presents a historical look at what conservatism really means. He shows us a more concrete conservatism that is worth reviving and standing for amidst the political confusion that has arisen over the previous decades.

Where Will We Go?

Confronting The Adventure and Danger of Adulthood

JACOB HANSEN

Jacob runs the popular YouTube podcast "Thoughtful Faith" and is a business owner and a graduate of Brigham Young University - Hawaii. Jacob is the father of 4 children and when he is not making videos for his YouTube channel he is doing Jiu Jitsu, sailing, surfing or running his kids around to their various sports and activities.

I love sailing. I love the adventure of being on the ocean, and facing the uncertainty of the conditions. I love surfing for the same reasons. I remember when my older brother and I first contemplated sailing on the ocean with our families. We decided to get certified and take actual ocean sailing classes because we both knew (and know) that the ocean is no joke. Mistakes or too much brava-do on the ocean can be deadly. In the last decade or so, I personally have pulled three people panicking from the ocean caught in rip tides. For all its beauty, the ocean is also something that commands immense respect. Having first hand experience with the power and fury of the ocean as well as its vast loneliness, I have learned to take it very seriously.

College for most people is the time when they finally leave the port of their parents home and enter the ocean of the real world. It can be exhilarating but it can also be terrifying as now you have to make your own choices for your own reasons and face the consequences of those decisions. In many ways this time in life is a time when you come face to face with the reality of the human

condition. The human condition in its raw form is very much like the ocean: it is vast, it can be beautiful, it can be terrifying, it can be lonely, it changes without warning, and it demands to be taken seriously. This is the fundamental nature of reality. When we strip away all our narratives, man is adrift in a sea without any definite purpose or direction in an environment that can be both beautiful and awful. Since the dawn of time, people have constructed boats (usually in the form of narratives), for this metaphorical ocean. These boats were something to grab onto, something to keep you from drowning, especially amid storms. These boats have never been perfect. Some have been nothing more than an assemblage of driftwood. But at least they give you something to keep your head above the water.

This is what faith is. It is when you grab onto one of these boats (or chunks of driftwood) trusting in it. You put your faith in something because the alternative leaves you adrift without recourse. It could be a simple faith in “I should do what I feel is right” or it could be a complex faith tradition. Those who abandon faith (the boats), are those who say the water is not so bad, they enjoy swimming in the calm water, but these people don’t understand the ocean, they don’t understand its power, beauty and danger. “Swim and enjoy the calm because eventually we all drown”, is their motto. However, you sometimes will see a swimmer clinging to a little driftwood or the the side of a boat when storms come, because even swimmers deep down don’t want to be tossed about and drown. They come to realize the only way to prevent it is holding onto something (at least temporarily).

But there is a deeper question, is there any destination over the horizon. Is there somewhere to go? Are we to just drift until we eventually drown? Is life nothing more than a short swim in an ocean that may be calm and beautiful or stormy and terrifying with fate at the helm? Those adrift sometimes rightly ask, “why am I so lucky to enjoy calm beautiful seas” or “why are others so unlucky as to only endure a short miserable drowning in an unforgiving storm”? If you don’t recognize fully the perverse injustice of the human condition, then you either are naive or heartless. The fun-

damental reality is the ocean in all its desolation, injustice and vast drifting emptiness. It's where chance alone rules your well being or suffering. When you consider this plight you understand why many believe mankind is in need of rescue. But is there any hope? Anything solid to build a life on?

As we drift, there are many who claim there is land over the horizon, that we can get there, and that we can build a new life on the solid land. There are ships constructed, there are courses plotted, and we see those who sail beyond the horizon not knowing where they will end up. Are we going to get in a ship? Which ship? Which direction? To what end? Should we stop worrying and taking on the stress and physical demands of sailing? Should we just jump in the water, swim and hope the storms don't come and drown us before we want them to. After all, aren't all these boats just wishful thinking, a doomed endeavor that turns existence into a miserable sailors toil before dying in pursuit of land that does not exist?

Jordan Peterson has gained international stardom by rightly pointing out that our civilizations, our human progress, and that which humans find of worth has been built on people adopting responsibility. Essentially what Peterson is saying is that a meaningful life can only be built by people taking on the task of building a boat and setting sail. Because in sailing, in exploring, in the seeking of land we find purpose and hope, we find happiness through meaning. Some days we see birds that give us signs of land, other times we feel alone as we try and patch a hole in our boat, but sail on we must.

As we look around, we see many boats proposing different destinations. The boats are built differently, the crews organized in different fashions. Some are big, some are small, some have comfy chairs, some do not, but all the boats are trying to go somewhere, trying to find solid land. "Join our crew is the call" as each boat's virtues and course is extolled as the surest smoothest way to the solid land. But there is another group, a group in the water swimming around laughing at the people in the boats. Those in the boats hear them, "Come in and enjoy the water", "That boat will

surely sink in the first storm”, “You are wasting your time and the time of others toiling on those silly boats”. Still occasionally some in the water feel a tinge of fear as they see clouds approach, they even feel envious of how these boats at least provide structure and a voyage to take on. Some even consider building a boat of their own but worry about having to keep their boat from being mocked and attacked by swimmers. Swimmers don’t just mock the boats, they take great pleasure in trying to sink them.

But why?

“Those boats are dangerous, the people in them will suffer a miserable journey” replies the swimmer, “better to sink the ships so we all can drift around together”. The swimmer is so naive, so ignorant of the nature of the ocean. He ignores the fact that the greatest suffering is not found in a sailor’s toil toward a worthy goal, but a life adrift in the void. Perhaps we should also consider that boats are hard to build, they are hard to sail. It’s much easier to point out the leaks in other people’s boats, it’s much harder to build a seaworthy craft that can endure the onslaught of storms, attacks from other boats and the constant barrage of swimmers trying to pry loose any planks they can. And what of those who spend their time sinking the other boats around them. Are they any better than swimmers? Why not convince people to jump into your boat? Why cast them into the water where they may drown? Just because you sink their ship does not mean they will join your crew.

So who are you? Who are the people around you? Are they ship builders or ship destroyers? It’s one thing to be trying to build a boat and calling others to join you on a worthwhile journey in a more secure and seaworthy craft. It’s another thing entirely to be a swimmer, someone who offers nothing but a life adrift in the meaningless cruel void and who takes perverse pleasure in pulling others into the water. Surely some occasional prying loose of rotten planks or remodeling of a ship is necessary and good. But why focus on destroying the boats of others when we are merely adrift in the water or when our own boat is so badly in need of care and maintenance. I think it’s worth considering the words of this classic poem by Charles Franklin Benvegar:

*As I watched them tear a building down
A gang of men in a busy town*

*With a ho-heave-ho, and a lusty yell
They swung a beam and the side wall fell*

*I asked the foreman, "Are these men skilled,
And the men you'd hire if you wanted to build?"*

*He gave a laugh and said, "No, indeed,
Just common labor is all I need."*

*"I can easily wreck in a day or two,
What builders have taken years to do."*

*And I thought to myself, as I went my way
Which of these roles have I tried to play'*

*Am I a builder who works with care,
Measuring life by rule and square?*

*Am I shaping my work to a well-made plan
Patiently doing the best I can'*

*Or am I a wrecker who walks to town
Content with the labor of tearing down?*

*"O Lord let my life and my labors be
That which will build for eternity!"*

So is there solid land somewhere? No one knows for sure, but those of faith are those who dare to believe there is! Is sailing worth it? One of the great truths of life is that happiness is found in meaning, not comfort, and meaning is only found in building a seaworthy craft, plotting a course and taking on the sailors toil through storms and sunshine toward a worthy destination you believe is there. One of the sad realities of life is when you come to realize

that we are on an ocean. We are all in this together, including those who are not of our faith. The great blessing of being a Latter-day Saint is that you are in a boat. At times in my life when my faith has struggled I have often had to remember that I am on an ocean and think of the words of Elder Ballard from his Oct 2014 general conference address:

The Lord in His goodness has provided help, including a boat... President Brigham Young commonly employed “the Old Ship Zion” as a metaphor for The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

He said on one occasion: “We are in the midst of the ocean. A storm comes on, and, as sailors say, she labors very hard. ‘I am not going to stay here,’ says one; ‘I don’t believe this is the “Ship Zion.”’ ‘But we are in the midst of the ocean.’ ‘I don’t care, I am not going to stay here.’ Off goes the coat, and he jumps overboard. Will he not be drowned? Yes. So with those who leave this Church. It is the ‘Old Ship Zion,’ let us stay in it.”¹

On another occasion, President Young said that he also worried about people losing their way when they were being blessed—when life was good: “It is in calm weather, when the old ship of Zion is sailing with a gentle breeze, [and] when all is quiet on deck, that some of the brethren want to go out in the whaling boats to have ... a swim, and some get drowned, others drifted away, and others again get back to the ship. Let us stick to the old ship and she will carry us [safely] into the harbor”

And finally, President Young reminded the Saints: “We are on the old ship Zion. ... [God] is at the helm and will stay there. ... All is right, sing Hallelujah, for the Lord is here. He dictates, guides and directs. If the people will have implicit confidence in their God, never forsake their covenants nor their God, He will guide us right.”

Testimonies

SISTER PAIGE HULEIS

Germany Hamburg Mission

I know that Christ lives. He is our Savior and our advocate with the Father. I know that it is only through Christ and His Atonement that we can be saved and find true joy in this life and in the life to come. I have a huge testimony of prayer and know that because God loves us, He wants to hear from us. There have been so many times in my life when I have prayed for help, comfort, or direction and received an answer from God. I have seen so many miracles and blessings every single day when I search and pray for them.

SISTER ELIZA ANDERSEN

Japan Fukuoka Mission

The Christmas season is a season of joy: joy in the One who makes joy possible; joy in our Savior and Redeemer.

Jesus Christ lived and died and was buried. He rose again, and He lives today! Because of Him, our divine potential is limitless and celestial possibilities are endless.

The Savior invites us to abide with Him permanently, to always remember Him and take His name upon us, to be a witness of Him at all times, in all things, and in all places.

Come unto Him. Come to remain. Keep the light of Christ and His gospel in your life. Never trade the light you have

for the lies the world offers. None can deliver but the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.

So endure to the end and stay close to Him. If we go about our mortal ministry acting as Christ does, we will come to know our Master and will see Him as He is when He comes again. Let your light shine before men and be a living epistle of the living Christ.

Stay humble, stay repentant, stay patient. Don't let a day go by without the song of redeeming love in your heart and a prayer of thanksgiving in your mind. If it so be that we are faithful in a few things, we will be blessed with blessings that are beyond our capacity to even imagine."

Special thanks to Katy Hewlett for compiling the testimonies.

Artist's Note

Caleb Williams, known by the pseudonym Godwin, is a Latter-day Saint artist popular for his unique pen and ink style, which imitates the wood and metal engraving prints of bygone eras. Godwin infuses this older, inherited style into subjects relevant to the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, producing a fresh yet antique perspective on familiar doctrines, figures, and scripture.

Godwin is an American living in Gloucestershire, England. His love for the artistic heritage of Europe—especially within the Christian tradition—has inspired the artistic vision of his own faith. Through this vision, he hopes to inspire fellow saints to learn and proudly share the culture and beliefs of the Restoration.

In 2024, he released an illustrated edition of the Book of Mormon. Through 2025, he is illustrating the doctrines and events of the Restoration. These and other works are available to enjoy at libraryofgodwin.com.

Standing for Something

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